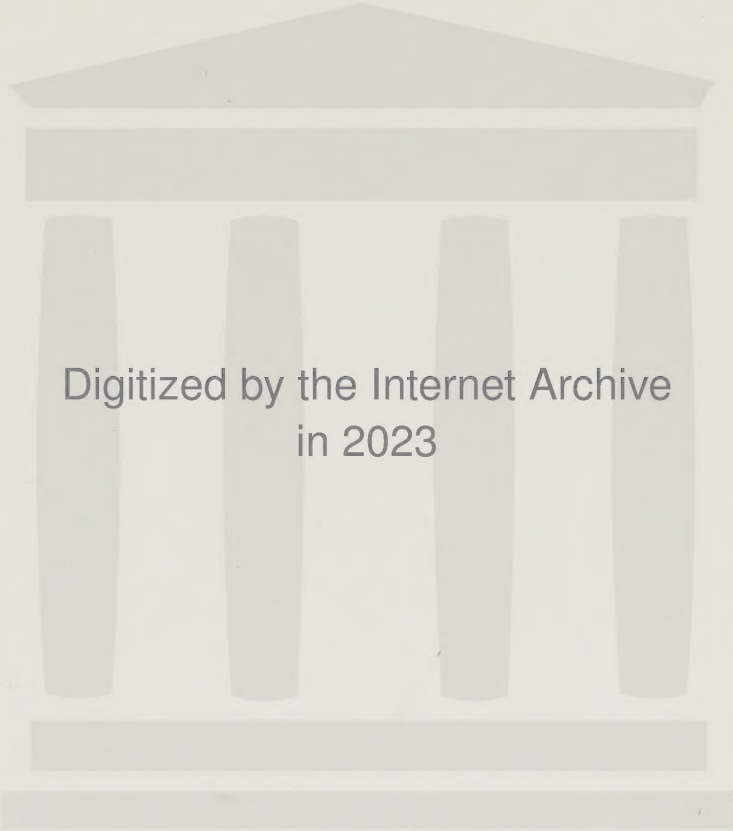


UNIVERSITY
PENNSYLVANIA
LIBRARIES





Digitized by the Internet Archive
in 2023

https://archive.org/details/isbn_0714634638

**BEYOND STALINISM:
COMMUNIST POLITICAL EVOLUTION**

BEYOND STALINISM: COMMUNIST POLITICAL EVOLUTION

edited by
RONALD J. HILL

WITHDRAWN
FROM
UNIVERSITY OF PENNSYLVANIA
LIBRARIES



FRANK CASS

5C
474
B47
1992

First published 1992 in Great Britain by
FRANK CASS & CO. LTD.
Gainsborough House, Gainsborough Road,
London E11 1RS, England

and in the United States of America by
FRANK CASS

Copyright © 1992 Frank Cass & Co. Ltd.

UNIVERSITY
OF
PENNSYLVANIA
LIBRARIES

British Library Cataloguing-in-Publication Data

Beyond Stalinism: Communist Political
Evolution. — (Journal of Communist
Studies Series, ISSN 0268-4535; Vol. 8, No. 1)
I. Hill, Ronald J. II. Series
320.5

ISBN 0-7146-3463-8

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data

Beyond Stalinism : Communist political evolution / edited by Ronald J.
Hill.

p. cm.

"This group of studies first appeared in a special issue of
Communist studies, vol. 8, no. 1" —T.p. verso

Includes index.

ISBN 0-7146-3463-8 (hard) : £24.00

1. Communist state. 2. Europe, Eastern—Politics and
government—1945–1989. 3. Soviet Union—Politics and
government—1945–1991. 4. Post-communism—Europe, Eastern. 5. Post
—communism—Soviet Union. I. Hill, Ronald J., 1943–
JC474.B47 1992
321.9'2'09—dc20

92-12866
CIP

This group of studies first appeared in a Special Issue on Beyond Stalinism:
Communist Political Evolution of *The Journal of Communist Studies*, Vol. 8,
No. 1, published by Frank Cass & Co. Ltd.

All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced in any form or by any
means, electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording or otherwise, without the prior
permission of Frank Cass and Company Limited.

Typeset by Regent Typesetting, London
Printed by Antony Rowe Ltd, Chippenham

Contents

Preface		1
Communist Politics: An Evolutionary Approach	Ronald J. Hill	3 0
The Soviet Union: Gorbachev, <i>Perestroika</i> and Socialism	Stephen White	23
Saints and Demons: Communism, Post-Communism and Political Evolution in Poland	Paul G. Lewis	41
China's Interrupted Revolution	Shaun Breslin	63
The State: Has the 'Withering Away' Thesis Finally Withered Away?	John Hoffman	84
Economic Reform and Political Evolution in Eastern Europe	Martin Myant	107 0
Groups, Interests and Political Aggregation in East Central Europe	Michael Waller	128 0
The Evolution of Party Systems in Eastern Europe	Sten Berglund and Jan Åke Dellenbrant	148
Communism and Political Evolution	Adam Westoby and Ronald J. Hill	160
Index		175

1EAL7734

Preface

The related concepts of change, development, 'evolution' and similar ideas with reference to communist political systems has long been an interest of mine – indeed, since, as a graduate student at the University of Essex in the 1960s, I pursued a seminar course on 'totalitarianism'. My experience of living in the provinces of the Soviet Union later persuaded me of the inappropriateness of at least a rigid application of that concept, and my subsequent studies of Soviet political life convinced me that below the summit of political power much was taking place that had strong implications for the system's ability to cope.

The work of Soviet scholars in the 1960s and 1970s, about which I wrote in a book published in 1980 (*Soviet Politics, Political Science and Reform*), demonstrated the existence of theoretical approaches to the increasingly complex Soviet reality that might well lead to significant changes in policy once the unimaginative and complacent Brezhnev leadership left the scene. They also demonstrated the existence of reformist ideas within the communist establishment. Admittedly superficial studies of other 'socialist' countries, particularly in Eastern Europe, suggested parallel scholarly developments there, with similar implications for political life. That generation of thinkers had their opportunity under Gorbachev from 1985 onwards. Events since then have demonstrated the accuracy of some of their critical analyses, while proving that their prescriptions for induced political evolution were too late: the world had moved on.

A further interest has been the interaction between 'capitalism' (or liberal democracy) and 'communism', particularly the impact of capitalism's technical innovations on some of communism's basic principles of rule. In particular, the penetration of barriers through the general relaxation of East–West tension and, recently, the communications revolution, made the task of conducting an experiment on an isolated, captive population ever more unsustainable. For reasons well argued by other scholars, the transformation of the Stalinist form of communist rule seemed to me to be unavoidable sooner or later. What was not obvious was that the system as such was incapable of reform, and its collapse was inevitable if the peoples who lived under the system were to have any hope of enjoying the standard of living and the civil rights and

individual freedoms that I have taken for granted, along with most of the Western world.

The present collection of essays brings together these areas of interest, by using the concept of evolution to explore various forms of change in the communist and 'post-communist' world. I am grateful to the contributors for their efforts in elucidating and illustrating various facets of the concept, and for the wealth of factual information that their case studies bring together. I also thank the members of Lorton House, an independent charitable association that promotes the academic study of communism and related concepts and sponsors *The Journal of Communist Studies*, for affording me the opportunity to put together this collection, which I trust readers and students of communism will find of interest and value.

RONALD J. HILL

Communist Politics: An Evolutionary Approach

RONALD J. HILL

The concept of evolution, despite obvious limitations, offers insights into developmental processes within ruling communism and from communism. A new and evidently vigorous type of political system has rapidly collapsed, to be replaced eventually by multi-party democracy. A system whose central goal was the induced evolution towards a utopian society displayed limited capacity for adaptation to meet changing needs. Following the death of Stalin, modifications to the system permitted the evolution of different strains of communism, without changing the fundamental characteristics of the species. In the 1980s the system demonstrated its inability to adopt survival mechanisms in a society that presented challenges and pressures very different from those that suggested viability in the 1930s and later. After the collapse and near-extinction of communism in power, those societies enter a new stage in their political evolution, in which some 'genetic material' has been transferred, through political culture, from the communist regime.

Until barely three years ago, the world seemed in the twentieth century to have acquired a distinct form of political system: that of communism as a form of rule. It seemed to be a stable system, capable of evolutionary adjustment. By the 1960s, at the latest, differences could be discerned among the various countries that were experiencing such rule, and from the late 1970s a new sub-discipline of political science was developed to examine those distinctions: comparative communism.¹ Whatever the nuances and shades of emphasis, the distinctions of practice, the divergences in laws and the institutional modifications, it was believed that the 'communist' political system had become a permanent feature of world politics.

Indeed, the political geography of the world was defined in terms of such an assumption: 'East' meant 'communist' while 'West' implied

Ronald J. Hill is Professor of Soviet Government in Trinity College, Dublin, Ireland; his books include *Communist Politics Under the Knife: Surgery or Autopsy?* (London: Pinter, 1990).

liberal democracy, so that political terms bore fairly remote connections with physical geography: the West included Australia and Japan, while Prague – longitudinally west of Vienna, Helsinki, Stockholm and Athens – was an ‘eastern’ capital city.² The coinage of the term ‘Third World’ to represent the emerging nations of Asia, Africa and Latin America implied the existence of two previous ‘worlds’, one of which (sometimes even called the Second World) referred to the communist-ruled countries. There was an open and explicit hostile rivalry between the ‘free’, ‘democratic’, ‘bourgeois’, ‘capitalist’ systems of the ‘West’, and the ‘communist’ systems of the ‘East’. Moreover, the long-term tendency apparently favoured the ‘communist’ ‘East’, which expanded after the Second World War into Eastern Europe, Asia and Indochina, and from the early 1960s included Cuba, in the 1970s acquired adherents in Africa, and had evidently penetrated Central America following the Sandinistas’ coming to power in 1979. As late as the autumn of 1990, Robert Mugabe seemed intent on creating such a system in Zimbabwe.

In all the countries that acquired communist governments, certain key principles were adhered to and common features were adopted. First among these was rule by a Marxist (more commonly Marxist-Leninist) party, hierarchically organized and disciplined by democratic centralism. So central was the single party’s dominance that the communist system has been characterized as a *partocracy*;³ apologists have identified the party’s ‘leading’ role as a ‘law of the development of socialist society as a whole, that is, a socio-political law’ – in other words, as the hallmark of the socialist (that is, in conventional usage, communist) system;⁴ even where other parties were allowed to exist, their position was clearly subordinate to the ‘hegemonic’ Marxist-Leninist party (which was frequently not called ‘communist’);⁵ and in a number of communist-ruled countries the permanency of the communist party’s ruling position was enshrined in the state constitution (Article 6 of the 1977 USSR Constitution; Article 4 of the Constitutions of Czechoslovakia and Cuba; Article 3 in the Polish Constitution; Article 3 in Hungary; and the Prologue of the 1974 Constitution of Yugoslavia).⁶ Until the very recent past, there was every reason to believe that the distinctive political system based on the communist party’s political monopoly had become a permanent feature of the world’s political experience.

The end of the 1980s saw the collapse of this system in the USSR and the countries of ‘Eastern Europe’ and elsewhere, including Mongolia.⁷ In the various countries of the region, a multi-party system is in the making. In cases where alternative parties to the communists have existed all along, those have been revived and joined by fresh political forces; where the communists enjoyed a complete monopoly (as opposed to occupying

a position of hegemony amounting to political monopoly), new parties have arisen to compete in the political arena alongside the communists, who in a number of cases have changed their name to indicate their reformed identity and, it is to be presumed, intentions.⁸ In the Soviet Union, the process to date has proceeded less far, although there are significant regional variations, and the failed coup of August 1991 boosted the final collapse of communist party rule and opened the way for 'post-communist' political evolution.

While the various forms of diversification that were witnessed in the past might be interpreted as forms of *evolution within communism*, what is now occurring is manifestly *evolution from communism*. If the concept of political evolution is to be of any assistance in permitting insights into developmental processes, it needs to take both of these aspects of the question into account.

Evolution as a Metaphor

The notion of political evolution is a metaphor taken from theories in the natural world. This point was made by Adam Westoby in his recent history of the communist movement, entitled *The Evolution of Communism*.⁹ However, that book presents a detailed history of change and development in the movement without fully exploring the ramifications of the metaphor. The present contribution is intended to do precisely that.

There are many dimensions of the notion of communist political evolution, which the various contributions to the present symposium examine. It is, of course, to be compared with the concepts of 'change' and 'development', while possessing, in my view, a range of supplementary concepts that render it of particular value in illuminating the place of communism in human political experience. The concept of 'change' is exceptionally vague, and indicates practically nothing except a lack of stasis and permanence in a given situation. Indeed, on one level, it states the banality that the whole of existence is in constant flux. The concept of 'development', which enjoyed a period of vogue in the 1960s and early 1970s, came to be associated with unilinear Western (specifically North American) views of change, in which there was an almost inevitable correlation between certain kinds of economic and social change on the one hand and political change on the other. The cultural superiority embedded in views such as that which described the citizens of the United States as 'politically modern' helped to discredit the concept,¹⁰ at the same time as references to former colonial countries as 'un-

developed' were replaced by 'underdeveloped' and later 'developing'. In that particular argument – which suggested, for instance, a clear relationship between the socioeconomic changes associated with urbanization and industrialization and the establishment of democratic political processes of the parliamentary type – the communist regimes of Eastern Europe, in particular, posed special problems of classification. Their advancing economies appeared not to lead automatically to political pluralism, although theories of 'convergence' relied for support on evidence of political change in the wake of socioeconomic change.¹¹ There is, indeed, a plausible argument to be made in such terms, most pithily expressed by Holmes: 'a more sophisticated society needs a more sophisticated form of political rule'.¹²

Marxism and Evolution

It is doubly appropriate that systems inspired by the Marxist vision should be discussed in evolutionary terms. In the first place, Marx and Engels were quite clearly thinkers influenced by the philosophical fashions of their day, a principal one of which was the evolutionary theory of Darwin (born nine years before Marx, 11 before Engels), whose *Origin of Species* was published in 1859, and who continued to write works on themes that were at least compatible with the work of Marx, if not directly complementary to it.¹³ Marx's familiarity with the work of Darwin was made quite plain by Engels in his eulogy at Marx's graveside in 1883: 'As Darwin discovered the law of evolution in organic nature, so Marx discovered the law of evolution in human history.'¹⁴

That raises the second reason for examining Marxist-inspired regimes in evolutionary terms: Marxist theory was itself consciously evolutionary. It posited the principle of change, rather than stasis, presenting a model of the development of human society and projecting forward towards the pinnacle of social organization, namely communism. There is, therefore, in the Marxist philosophy a compulsion towards change: a desire to alter the way society functions, and it is a compulsion on which successive generations of communist leaders in various parts of the world have acted, in the belief that they were, so to speak, assisting in the creation of a new species – or, at least, fostering the development towards perfection of the species that traditional opinion saw as the pinnacle of creation or evolution.

Moreover, Marx identified what he saw as some of the mechanisms the prompted change, particularly technical progress and changes in ownership relations. According to his model, the 'fittest' survived, and outworn

systems gave way to 'progressive' new systems, until 'communism' was eventually reached. Furthermore, for communism to survive as a force in a given society, it had a vital need to adapt, by taking on some of the characteristics of the previous society, as reflected in cultural needs, political experience, and various other traits of the population concerned. That alone explains, through the metaphor of evolution, some of the variations from the original Stalinist model that emerged over the decades.

Marx and Engels, impressed by the Darwinian concept of evolution, did not live long enough to witness the development of the science of genetics, which adds a further dimension to the study of evolution, by identifying some of the mechanisms that lead to change. The metaphor can thus be extended by incorporating some of these into our study of communism.

And finally, the collapse of communist rule invites comparisons with the history of the natural world. If 'communism' as a form of rule is to become extinct, is it possible to identify functions that it fulfilled – such as preparing the ground for more viable species (as perhaps the dinosaurs did)?

There is a particular point of interest, which is the focus of John Hoffman's contribution below: the position of the state as one of the central elements in most analyses of politics, including the Marxist one. While the ultimate goal was the 'withering away' of the state and its replacement by 'communist self-administration', the practice of communist rule has entailed a luxuriantly growing state, which successive leaders have attempted to domesticate, either by removing some of its powers, or by professionalizing its functioning, to date with relatively little success in the country of its origin.

Forms of Evolution

As noted above, there is more than one form of 'evolution' to be examined in relation to communism as a political form: various strands of evolution *within* communism and evolution *from* communism.

Within communism, beginning with Marx, the 'Revisionism' of Eduard Bernstein before Marxists came to power anywhere in the world can be seen as a response to the changing environment of capitalism. Indeed, Bernstein's classic work was entitled in its 1909 English translation simply *Evolutionary Socialism* – a further reflection of the impact of that concept on the minds of socialist thinkers.¹⁵ The rise of joint-stock companies, the consolidation of capital and its export to overseas

colonies, the enrichment of the working masses both materially (that is, in economic terms) and through education and political concessions (particularly the extension of the franchise, leading to the rise of non-Marxist Labour parties): these factors changed the context in which communists existed, and survival – and eventual success as a political movement – required adaptation.

Leninism, too, was a major evolutionary adaptation, reflecting the specific conditions of the Russian working class in the years of Tsarist oppression. If Marxism itself can be seen as offering a prototype, Leninism in theory and in practice established the first viable system of rule by Marxists. The adaptations of the ideology, in the theory of imperialism, gave impetus to the creation of a species of government in an environment that was believed not to be hospitable to the socialist revolution. The adaptations made to the 'classic' Marxist revolutionary seizure of power are well known, and led to the notion that the Bolshevik revolution of October 1917 was at best a 'premature' revolution – that concept itself a metaphor that casts doubt on the viability of the organism.

That organism – a political system dedicated to political transformation in favour of the working masses – did survive, although not in the form envisaged by traditional Marxist thinkers: indeed, the metaphor may be further extended by suggesting that the organism was genetically deformed at birth. It evolved, nevertheless, into a brutal dictatorship under Stalin, which was deemed to be the authentic model of a socialist system. There is much discussion, among socialists and their opponents alike, concerning the relationship between Lenin's system and Stalin's: was Stalin's a distinct system, significantly different from Lenin's? Or was it a logical evolution of basic principles of Lenin's form of rule? Was Stalinism a distortion, a disfigurement of Marx and Lenin? Or was it the logical evolutionary pinnacle of the Marxist approach to society?¹⁶

There are no definitive answers to these questions. What is clear, however, is that the long-term viability of the system created by Stalin was already in doubt by the time of his death, or shortly afterwards, and Khrushchev deliberately induced a form of evolution. The overextended administrative apparatus was forced to wither, and the terror that had been an everyday experience of communist rule was largely abandoned, to be replaced by administrative and political forms of control. The communist party's position was restored to the centre of the system, and in subsequent years that institution was to develop into a major political, social and economic force. Under Brezhnev the evolution continued, with attempts to adapt the mechanism of government to meet the growing demands of an increasingly complex society. In particular, as Hoffman notes below, the professionalization of the state enhanced its ability to

survive, and indeed to thwart fresh attempts to induce the system's further evolution.

Meanwhile, the system had been transplanted into other soil elsewhere, adapting to local conditions in the process. In Eastern Europe and in Asia the Leninist-Stalinist form was imposed or adapted with greater or lesser rapidity, depending in part on the environment into which it was introduced and its political and geographical proximity to the original variant. In Eastern Europe, where Moscow's control was the strongest, there was initially strong adherence to the prototype. Here, perhaps, the concept of cloning is an apt parallel: that entails producing a genetically identical copy, either by nuclear transplantation – placing reliable communists into key positions – or as a direct descendant of a single parent cell.¹⁷ As the intensity of the external pressure declined after Stalin's death, however, to be replaced by pressures from inside the system, modifications occurred. In some cases – the GDR in 1953, Poland and Hungary in 1956 – the viability of the 'clones' was in question, in what appeared to be attempts to induce a throw-back to the previous form.

In Yugoslavia, indeed, where the severance from the 'parent' took place at an earlier stage, an evolutionary path was embarked upon that differed in significant ways from its progenitor. The role of the party was modified; the economy was managed somewhat differently with less central direction; individual freedoms were greater; in general, the country was more open to external influences, through tourism into the country and the departure and return of many citizens as workers in Western Europe, particularly the German Federal Republic. This 'viral infection' led to the modification of the system into something that was less distinct than the original pattern, and one that appeared to enjoy potentially greater viability: its fitness for survival, depending less on coercion and control, appeared to the Western observer to be higher.

In China, the adaptation to local conditions was reflected in the origin of the system (peasant-based, rather than dependent on industrial workers), but there, too, a clone of Stalinism was created that survived in some of its characteristics longer than the Soviet prototype. Indeed, following the split in the movement after 1956, two varieties within the species fought for dominance. The intensity of the struggle for survival has varied, and the outcome remains unclear. In the early 1990s, systems of the Soviet type appear to have proved themselves incapable of sustained existence: that raises new issues concerning evolution, which will be explored below.

Other strands of evolution also occurred: Leninism gave birth not only to Stalinism but also to Trotskyism, a variety or species (which in turn has given rise to sub-species) that has been politically less successful than

those that were modeled on Stalinism, but may have had greater intellectual influence. Its 'purity' may assure it of survival now that Stalinist forms have been discredited and are withering.¹⁸

Communist Rule: Genus or Species?

One question that arises in this connection, in the context of the metaphor of evolution, is how far the various examples of communist systems are properly to be regarded as separate species or as variants within the same genus.

It might well be argued that there have been different evolutionary lines from Marxism, with the Soviet variant giving rise to closely modelled sub-species in Eastern Europe, some of which showed their own tendency to independent evolution, a Maoist version of somewhat more remote progeny, a North Korean variant that developed along independent lines, and various forms in Cuba, Africa and elsewhere that, while clearly related to the principal examples of the species, appeared in some (perhaps superficial) ways to be *sui generis*. In addition, the various non-ruling forms, while clearly related to the main stock, have diverged, in some cases sharply, in the effort to survive in the different political climate of pluralist liberal democracy, or severe underdevelopment.

Again, the Linnean taxonomy may help to distinguish communist political systems from others, and to distinguish among branches within the 'species'. The 'political system' may be seen as a 'kingdom' – the highest classification of living species – the other perhaps being 'economics', each representing a distinct sphere of activity within human society.¹⁹ Types of political system then become species or genera within the kingdom – and there are, of course, multiple forms of classification, in which the communist system may be a distinctive species (as the proponents of 'comparative communism' tended to treat it), or, more frequently, a variety of totalitarianism, itself a sub-species of authoritarianism, alongside dictatorship, military rule, or even, very occasionally, a variety of democracy;²⁰ one classification placed it in two of the common categories, as a totalitarian form of democracy.²¹ In such an approach, examples such as the short-lived Marxist regime in Somalia in the early 1970s – or the even shorter-lived ones in various parts of the world in the 1920s – might be seen as unproductive and unsuccessful branches on the communist evolutionary tree, while those that appeared capable of sustaining their existence over a certain period may have succumbed like the dodo, the marsupial wolf and other species that have died out. If the effect of hostile propaganda, limitations on trade and

other external features of communist rule are seen as having contributed to the final demise of the system, that may be equivalent to a natural species being hunted to extinction.

There is quite a separate approach to the question, however, and one that is more compatible with Marx's own approach, although different in emphasis. This would suggest that 'socialism' (or 'communism' as a form of rule) is a phase within the social, economic and political evolution of a society – or even of the human species – beyond bourgeois capitalism (itself an evolutionary subspecies beyond feudalism). For communists, the natural pinnacle of human social evolution is 'communism', a kind of society not yet attained, in which relationships of harmony and collaboration replace those of selfishness and greed that have been dominant until now; 'socialism' – the experience of communism as a form of rule – is a transition period, when, following the revolution, a burst of evolutionary adaptation prepares both the economic and social environment and the capacity of the human species to survive in different conditions. The forms of ownership are radically altered, and *ipso facto* the human species adapts its mental outlook and hence its behaviour, from the pursuit of selfish interests to the advance of the common good.

A variant of such an approach, espoused by some non-Marxists, sees the experience as mainly one in which the groundwork is done for a modern political system: communism as a form of rule deliberately induces environmental change – specifically, economic modernization, a change in the social structure, and changes in the political culture through education and experience – that permits the creation of a democratic system. In such a view, communism as a form of rule in the twentieth century becomes an intermediate species that has an impact on the environment such that the system itself cannot survive without drastic modification: only a process such as democratization is capable of permitting the continuing existence of the system. As two seasoned observers recently noted of the Soviet case: 'The Stalinist order, as modified after his death, has proved inadequate to cope with the conditions that Gorbachev inherited on coming to power'.²² They also suggested that the process of reform initiated by Mikhail Gorbachev in the Soviet Union (and the same may apply to other countries that have abandoned Stalinist communism) would not make the Soviet Union a Western country 'in this century or in the first decades of the next one'.²³

But that again raises a philosophical challenge: at precisely what point can it be said that one system has evolved into another? Here, the limitations of the concept of 'evolution' become plain. In the natural world, a general definition of a species relates to a capacity of fruitful interbreeding ('reproductive isolation').²⁴ Political systems do not breed.

However, an adaptation of the approach does permit us to classify systems in terms of interactions of other types, and thereby perhaps to identify when a system has experienced evolutionary transformation. As a general rule, in the modern world there have been clusterings of states along ideological lines (commonly referred to as blocs). Ideological compatibility has led to political collaboration, economic co-operation including within-bloc trading patterns and communication flows, the copying of institutions and practices, military alliances, and a range of other mutually reinforcing contacts: these are the social equivalent of the gene exchange of reproduction. By contrast, such contacts with members of the alternative bloc (species) have been restricted by various 'barriers to gene exchange' comparable to those between herring gulls and black-backed gulls, which are essentially behavioural.²⁵ As individual systems evolve, their patterns of contacts likewise undergo modification: within-species contacts may be reduced (as between China and the Soviet Union and her allies in the 1960s); inter-species contacts may be expanded, opening the way to fresh influences that present pressures towards evolutionary change (trade with the West; expanding tourism and cultural exchanges; mass media penetration). Such 'interbreeding', conducted between species of such fundamental distinction that they have 'little chromosome homology', may produce hybrid societies that ultimately have no reproductive capacity or viability since there develops a conflict between the needs of the society and the capacity of the system to satisfy those needs. Political sterility results – as in much of Eastern Europe by the 1970s – that is every bit as constricting for the future of the species as the sterility of mules and other hybrids.²⁶

Sources of Evolution

While 'interbreeding' may cause evolution towards political sterility, there are other concepts and analogies from the natural world that may be used to help understand some of the processes involved in the evolution of communist systems. Natural selection theory, supported by modern genetic science, teaches that mutations are a critical contributing factor in speciation, and by extension of the survival of the 'fittest' species – those that possess the capacity to adapt to environmental change by mutation, whether within a gene ('point mutation') or a chromosome ('chromosome mutation'). Genetic engineering, or gene manipulation, applies this by altering the genes that make up chromosomes, thereby modifying the treated organism, whose genetic material (DNA) is restructured. The intention is to enhance a particular quality in the organism; however, the procedure may be hazardous, producing unintended effects.²⁷ The paral-

lel in spontaneous mutation is the creation of cancerous cells, and these examples show that the mutation can occur naturally within the organism, or be induced by an external mutagen (in nature, various forms of radiation, ultraviolet light, gases such as mustard gas and other substances).

The arrival of a political leader – a Khrushchev, a Dubcek or a Gorbachev – of a different political outlook from his predecessor or his colleagues can serve the function of a ‘point mutation’: a specific change within the system of institutions and practices that has a dramatic impact on the system’s ‘genetic make-up’. Rapid economic development, with its accompanying change in social structure, geographic migration, rise in education levels and other consequential effects, is of such fundamental significance that it may be regarded as equivalent to ‘chromosome mutation’, and it places great pressure on the political system to adapt if it is to retain control. The adoption of a specific political institution or practice from outside – say, contested elections – may be a form of ‘genetic engineering’ that proves hazardous to the organism, inducing a pathological (cancerous) change in the cell. Opening up a society to freer information flows may be seen as the equivalent of exposing an organism to mutagenic radiation: the seepage of foreign influences (through tourism, contacts with persons living abroad, hostile broadcasting, and so forth) has long been a source of irritation to communist governments, which have attempted to restrict such ‘contamination’. In all such cases, the society (organism) is subjected to a process that modifies its basic make-up, inducing a change that may enhance its capacity for survival – but may also reduce its chances. Developments in the external environment – the growth of global communications; technological developments; worldwide population growth; the creation of new nation-states – place new pressures on systems which require them to adapt, or to face extinction.

Post-Communist Evolution

The experience of much of the former communist world in recent years has been one of attempted adaptation, but in most cases this has come too late to ensure the survival of that system of rule. Communist rule, as it has been experienced in the twentieth century, appears to have little future, and the issue becomes one of adaptations in a process of evolution from that system. The metaphor remains an appropriate one, since – as communist revolutionaries discovered in their day – no revolution creates *ex nihilo*:²⁸ the society continues, with traditions, habits, ways of thinking and various cultural and psychological traits that have developed over

many centuries. These form, as it were, part of the genetic stock – the chromosomes – of the post-revolutionary society. The very fact of revolution – the collapse of one ‘system’ and its replacement by another – undoubtedly has some effect in reordering the genes, and in the new arrangement different ones may be dominant from those of the pre-revolutionary society.

Moreover, the opportunities in the post-communist world for the introduction of exogenous influences – for interbreeding, in other words – facilitates the enrichment of that genetic stock, so that the creation of a working democratic system is enhanced. Nevertheless, the point needs to be borne in mind as the former communist-ruled countries struggle to establish working democracy in their societies: evolution takes place through a process of genetic mutation. It is a long-term process, and it involves constant adaptation and adjustment. Genetic engineering cannot restructure the genes of a tiger so that it can give birth to a snake: a political revolution, likewise, cannot instantly convert a system based on imposed central control into a fully-fledged stable participatory democracy.

Communist Political Evolution

No metaphor can reflect a situation exactly, and there are difficulties in applying that of evolution to a social system. Even in the natural world, there is a tendency to identify evolutionary trends on the basis of hindsight, if only because it is difficult (it may be impossible) to identify such long-term trends as speciation as they occur. Moreover, as noted above, the notion of interbreeding is particularly difficult to apply to political and social systems, since they exist alongside other systems, whose very existence affects the performance and very identity of communist systems.

Nor is it clear how the ‘communist’ phase relates to the long-term existence of a society. If ‘communism’ is a form towards which all societies are evolving (as orthodox Marxists believe), then communism as a form of rule can only be a stage on the evolutionary road. But Stalinism can also be seen as the pinnacle of evolutionary development, from Marx through Lenin, that has subsequently suffered decay leading to probable extinction. On the other hand, if such communism is seen as essentially a developmental method (as it has been by, for example, Ulam and Kautsky),²⁹ it becomes a mere stage in the general evolution of society towards a different pinnacle of evolution, participatory democracy – the system that alone can cope with the demands generated by an advanced society. As a further alternative, communism in its Stalinist form (and

derivatives) may be a distorted version of liberal ideals, created through the mutation of such ideals under the influence of eighteenth- and nineteenth-century ideas of revolution. That would be seen as a mutation harmful to the species, but creating a different species that was quite capable of survival in conditions different from those of the original species: an adaptation, in other words, that was favourable to the survival of the species in a changed environment.³⁰

A final difficulty in applying the concept lies in the very nature of society and political systems. A particular political system – communism – may collapse in a given society, but the society in most cases lives on, carrying some of the ‘genetic material’ with it, in the form of experiences and skills that will influence the nature and performance of the successor system. In the natural world, by contrast, an extinct species cannot be revived, and its genetic material can have no further influence on successor species. Nevertheless, the metaphor of evolution, perhaps a little stretched in places, directs our attention to some of the features of social and political development experienced by communist-run systems and faced by post-communist societies. In the chapters that follow, some of these aspects of communist political evolution are explored.

In the first part, three case studies explore aspects of political evolution in individual ‘communist’ countries that have experienced different forms of evolution. Stephen White examines recent trends in the Soviet Union, the country where the building of communism was first embarked upon, which, as virtually the lone pioneer, established the forms of communism as a system of rule that was imposed upon or emulated by other countries. While evolution from the harshness of Stalin’s rule undoubtedly took place – partly in response to changes induced by that system in the economic and social basis of the political system – it was in the second half of the 1980s that vigorous attempts were made to induce evolutionary change from above. However, those attempts led to a surge of pressure from below, such that the long-term continued existence of the system, let alone the integrity of the traditional system of communist rule and the values of socialism and communism, were placed in serious doubt, and the system finally collapsed at the end of 1991. That society split into a number of separate systems that each embarked on a new phase of political evolution. In Poland, as Paul Lewis demonstrates, the post-communist regime set about expunging half a century of the nation’s history. The communist system of rule quite simply failed to demonstrate sufficient adaptive capacity, or a basic ability to cope with the pressures of managing a modern economy and society; the hostility of the population was a fundamental underlying feature, as was the association of the form of rule with the traditional antagonistic neighbour to the east.

Yet, for all the desire to abandon the despised system, the prospects for evolution in the direction of pluralism and democracy are not certain, and will depend, as Lewis argues, on extensive institutional development and, it should be added, a considerable amount of psychological adjustment after half a century of cradle-to-grave welfare provision coupled with effective exclusion from political life: those features apply equally to other societies that are entering a new evolutionary phase after communist rule. For, as Sten Berglund and Jan Åke Dellenbrant argue in their contribution, the emergence of party systems to replace the communist monopoly poses certain difficulties that need to be overcome if the half-century of rule by communist monopoly is to evolve into Western-style pluralist democracy. 'Extreme pluralism' presents all manner of potential difficulties of instability and competition, as the inevitable economic hardships find political expression in fragmentation of opinion and of organization, and combines with resurgent nationalist sentiment to seek scapegoats in ethnic minorities. The future evolution is uncertain, argue Berglund and Dellenbrant, but is likely to be uneven, although in the general direction of pluralist democracy.

In China, where after a decade or more of apparently successful economic reform demands for political reform were met with brutal, even 'traditional communist' repression in June 1989, Shaun Breslin associates different potential evolutionary lines with individual leaders and factions within the movement. The Chinese example evinces remarkable similarities with the history of the Soviet Union and even pre-revolutionary Russia, particularly the ambiguity of attitudes towards the West: should these 'backward' societies emulate the West (meaning Western Europe and, in the late twentieth century, the US), or seek to avoid doing so? As ideology was replaced by economic performance as a legitimating factor, pressures to emulate the West became unavoidable, with possibly inevitable consequences for the evolution of the system.

The following contributions look at particular aspects of evolution. John Hoffman examines the evolutionary dimension of Marxist theory, in which the state – the central feature of political systems, and in Marx's analysis essentially an instrument of class rule – was expected to wither away. The paradox that communists in power have created a hypertrophied state apparatus under the control of the communist party finds resolution in the recent dramatic changes in communist-ruled countries: for, without the liberalizing elements of the revolutions of the late 1980s, any prospect of the 'withering away' of the state was impossible to contemplate. Ironically in the eyes of many, therefore (although Hoffman does not extend his argument so far), the end of communism as a form of rule frees Marxism of its Stalinist (and even Leninist) baggage,

with all their pernicious distorting effects, and may ultimately pave the way for an intellectual rehabilitation of Marxism as a serious analysis of the course of history.

Martin Myant uses case studies of three East European countries – Poland, Czechoslovakia and Hungary – to relate the problems of economic development with those of political evolution. He argues that attempts by communists in power in those countries (and the argument holds elsewhere) to introduce economic reform failed in the long term, despite apparent successes, and for identifiable reasons, including lack of commitment by those charged with devising and implementing the reforms. Protection of entrenched interests and ideological hostility to reform were but two impeding factors; so was a general failure on the part of managers and administrators to understand the requirements of any market-oriented reform. They certainly lacked the appropriate skills to function effectively in a market situation, which is one of the principal difficulties facing post-communist Eastern Europe. In addition, a growing public willingness to accept political compromise for the sake of basic forms of economic security brought together the economy and the polity, ‘the main problem solving mechanisms of human society’, which ‘interact with each other and transform each other in the process’.³¹

It was recognized by some that effective economic reform required simultaneous political reform, so much was management of the economy associated with the particular institutions, methods of rule and indeed whole approach to government of communists. It has, indeed, been argued in recent years that the failure of the Soviet economic reform under Kosygin in the 1960s was due in large measure to his failure to support it with appropriate political reforms.³² Again, as Myant argues, in the former communist countries today, the interdependence of politics and economics is such that the requirements of economic recovery and future management are influencing the shape of the emerging political structures.

Finally, Michael Waller tackles an issue that has been accorded increasing attention recently, first in relation to evolution within communism, and now more pertinently in connection with the processes of evolution from communism: the role of groups, interests and political aggregation. The Stalinist enforcement of the supremacy of ‘public interests’ (as defined by the communist party) over all ‘secondary’ or lower-order interests (group, institutional, individual) came under attack in the Soviet Union as long ago as 1957, and the notion of legitimate interests has become commonplace in the political rhetoric of communist countries.³³ Moreover, as long ago as the mid-1960s it was being suggested that ‘interest groups’ existed in such countries.³⁴ Nevertheless, citizens

were never accorded the right to express their interests openly and organize in pursuit of them: 'dissidence' – at best barely tolerated, frequently clandestine activity – was the closest approximation, joined at the other 'pole' by regime-sponsored organizations through which 'interests' might be channeled. Waller demonstrates the significance of some of the informal public associations – institutions would be too strong a word at that stage – in establishing nuclei of organizations on which effective representative institutions could be built after the fall of communist rule. The collapse of communist rule, which had imposed an artificially restricted range of acceptable views and interests, has opened the way to the emergence both of strong forms of social identity – religion, region, ethnicity – and of various organizational forms of expression – at their most structured in the form of political parties, as discussed by Berglund and Dellenbrant.

These essays all focus on change, and while the attempts to induce evolution within communism are highly relevant to the present situation – most importantly because their broad failure led to the ultimate failure of that system to adapt and survive – it is the further evolution that is of topical interest. As argued above, half a century or more of imposed monolithic rule cannot but have left its mark on the evolution of the societies concerned. Whether biological organisms are capable of learning from their life experience and passing on the acquired characteristics to succeeding generations is still an unresolved mystery of evolutionary theory (although there are strong theoretical arguments against it, and the theory's principal author, Lamarck, is held in low regard by conventional geneticists today).³⁵ Adverting once again to the limits of the metaphor when applied to the development of political systems, it seems clear that societies can learn from their own past, and pass accumulated wisdom from one generation to the next, and from one political system to another. Continuity between pre- and post-revolutionary attitudes, culture, practices and even institutions is a natural phenomenon, and, it has been argued, had considerable impact on the nature of the original Stalinism model of communism as a form of rule.³⁶

The studies in the present collection suggest a common lesson. This is not that communism as a form of rule cannot evolve, either by deliberately induced reform or by responding to environmental pressures: communist systems do possess some adaptive capacity, even though in practice they have shown limits to this. In order for those systems to survive, however, the adaptations that need to be made are such that they require a transformation into a different type of system. The Stalinist or communist system of rule can cope with certain problems, it appears, so long as it uses its traditional methods: once it begins the

evolution towards liberalism and pluralism, it releases forces that tend towards its own destruction.

As various countries emerge from the communist straitjacket, they are free to reject or to retain elements of their own recent experience, and to borrow from the experience of others. There is no single model of liberal democracy; there is no single model of party organization; there are in the societies emerging from communist rule a variety of attitudes towards the proper balance between individual and collective interests; and the world situation – in which virtually instantaneous global communications, uniformity of products and production methods, common cultural artifacts, and even a single language that is acquiring a commanding status as a language of international communication – itself presents pressures for the adoption of certain values and institutions that permit societies to respond to the demands of their citizens. All these factors – and others – will influence the political evolution of communist and ex-communist countries beyond Stalinism. Each society will strive to establish its own identity, within what may be recognizable as the broad democratic tradition. It will not be surprising if some more than others bear the imprint of their experience of communist rule, which may have been incorporated into the 'genetic code' – the political culture – just as communist rule reflected some of the values of pre-communist societies. These are interesting times, and the concept of political evolution permits the observer to identify and focus on the emerging patterns of change.

NOTES

1. More properly, the term should be the comparative study of communism, since it was study through the method of comparison, rather than the communism, that was 'comparative'. Among works of the past 25 years that approached communist systems comparatively (or, in most cases, in parallel) one might cite Ghița Ionescu, *The Politics of the European Communist States* (London: Weidenfeld & Nicolson, 1967); Ghița Ionescu, *Comparative Communist Politics* (London: Macmillan, 1972); Chalmers Johnson (ed.), *Change in Communist Systems* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1970); Robert G. Wesson, *Communism and Communist Systems* (Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall, 1978); Bogdan Szajkowski (ed.), *Marxist Governments: A World Survey*, 3 vols. (London: Macmillan, 1981); Robert Wesson, *The Aging of Communism* (New York: Praeger, 1980); Robert Furtak, *The Political Systems of the Socialist States: An Introduction to Marxist-Leninist Regimes* (Brighton: Wheatsheaf, 1986); Richard C. Gripp, *The Political System of Communism*, (London: Nelson, 1973); Gary Bertsch, *Power and Policy in Communist Systems*, 2nd edn (New York: Wiley, 1982); Gary K. Bertsch and Thomas W. Ganschow (eds.), *Comparative Communism: The Soviet, Yugoslav, and Chinese Models* (San Francisco, CA: Freeman, 1976); Lenard J. Cohen and Jane P. Shapiro (eds.), *Communist Politics in Comparative Perspective* (Garden City, NY: Anchor Books, 1974); Leslie T. Holmes, *Politics in the Communist World* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1986); Stephen White, John Gardner and George Schöpflin, *Communist Political Systems: An Introduction*

(London: Macmillan, 1982; 2nd edn, 1987; 3rd edn, 1990); Daniel N. Nelson and Stephen White (eds.), *Communist Politics: A Reader* (London: Macmillan, 1986); Robert G. Wesson, *Communism and Communist Systems* (Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall, 1978). Indicative of the tendency to engage in broad comparative study of communist-ruled systems was the publication of the short-lived journal *Communist Affairs: Documents and Analysis*, which appeared for three years in the early 1980s; the more successful *Studies in Comparative Communism*, published since the late 1960s; and the present quarterly *Journal of Communist Studies*, launched in 1985; the US government-funded *Problems of Communism*, while aiming at somewhat different goals, also served to facilitate comparisons among communist systems; finally, the multi-volume series of monographic textbooks, *Marxist Regimes: Politics, Economics and Society*, the first volumes in which were published by Frances Pinter (now Pinter Publishers) in 1985. These contributions – either explicitly comparative in their approach or designed so as to facilitate such study – complement theoretical works on Marxism and communism in various area studies, particularly several dealing with the East European communist-ruled states. The latter would include Ionescu (1967), H. Gordon Skilling, *The Governments of Communist East Europe* (New York: Crowell, 1966); Teresa Rakowska-Harmstone and Andrew Gyorgy (eds.), *Communism in Eastern Europe* (Bloomington, IN, and London: Indiana University Press, 1979); and Joni Lovenduski and Jean Woodall, *Politics and Society in Eastern Europe* (London: Macmillan, 1987). There have also been many volumes that focused on specific themes across communist-ruled systems: for example, Leslie Holmes (ed.), *The Withering Away of the State? Party and State under Communism* (London and Beverly Hills: Sage, 1981); Archie Brown and Jack Gray (eds.), *Political Culture and Political Change in Communist States* (London: Macmillan, 1977; 2nd edn, 1979); Neil Harding (ed.), *The State and Socialist Society* (London: Macmillan, 1984); Archie Brown (ed.), *Political Culture and Communist Studies* (London: Macmillan, 1984); Martin McCauley and Stephen Carter (eds.), *Leadership and Succession in the Soviet Union, Eastern Europe and China* (London: Macmillan, 1986); Myron Rush, *How Communist Countries Change their Leaders* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1974); Raymond Taras (ed.), *Leadership Change in Communist States* (Boston, MA: Unwin Hyman, 1989). Historical works include François Fejtő, *A History of the People's Democracies: Eastern Europe since Stalin* (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1974); Lily Marcou, *Les Pieds d'argile: Le Communisme mondial au présent, 1970–1986* (Paris: Ramsay, 1986); and Adam Westoby, *The Evolution of Communism* (Oxford: Basil Blackwell for Polity Press, 1989). The list could go on indefinitely. The communist-ruled countries themselves produced comparative works on 'the political system of socialism': for example, I.P. Il'inskii, B.A. Strashun and V.I. Yastrebov, *Politicheskaya sistema zarubezhnykh stran sotsializma* (Moscow: Mezhdunarodnye otnosheniya, 1981); it is significant that this title refers to the political system (rather than the political systems) of socialist countries, implying a belief that the communist-ruled countries shared distinctive political arrangements. A branch of the literature discussed whether communist systems should best be studied as a distinct type, or within the comparative study of political systems, or within area studies (Russian studies, Asian studies, Latin American studies, African studies, and so forth): see Frederic J. Fleron, Jr., 'Soviet Area Studies and the Social Sciences: Some Methodological Problems in Communist Studies', in Frederic J. Fleron, Jr. (ed.), *Communist Studies and the Social Sciences: Essays on Methodology and Empirical Theory* (Chicago, IL: Rand McNally, 1969), pp.1–33, and the editor's preface, pp.vii–viii; Valerie Bunce and John M. Echols III, 'From Soviet Studies to Comparative Politics: The Unfinished Revolution', *Soviet Studies*, Vol.XXXI, No.1 (1979), pp.43–55; H. Gordon Skilling, 'From Soviet Studies to Comparative Politics: The Unfinished Revolution: A Comment', *Soviet Studies*, Vol.XXXI, No.3 (1979), pp.441–2; also Jerry F. Hough, *The Soviet Union and Social Science Theory* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1977), esp. Ch.11, 'The Comparative Approach and the Study of the Soviet Union'.

2. The point is elaborated in the European context in Egbert Jahn, 'The Future of Europe, Eastern Europe and Central Europe', in Ronald J. Hill and Jan Zielonka (eds.), *Restructuring Eastern Europe: Towards a New European Order* (Aldershot: Edward Elgar, 1990), pp. 203–18, esp. pp. 203–5.
3. See Abdurakhman Avtorkhanov, *Proiskhozhdenie partokratii* (Frankfurt-am-Main: Possev, 1973).
4. See, for example, N.I. Azarov and P. Slavov (eds.), *Sovershenstvovanie politicheskoi nadstroiki sotsialisticheskogo obshchestva* (Moscow: Vysshaya shkola, 1984), p. 77.
5. See Jerzy W. Wiatr, 'Political Parties, Interest Representation and Economic Development in Poland', *American Political Science Review*, Vol. LXIV (1970), pp. 1239–45.
6. See William B. Simons (ed.), *The Constitutions of the Communist World* (Alphen aan den Rijn: Sijthoff & Noordhoff, 1990).
7. The term 'Eastern Europe' has been in common use for almost half a century to refer to the communist-ruled countries to the east of the 'Iron Curtain': specifically, the former German Democratic Republic, Poland, Czechoslovakia, Hungary, Romania, Bulgaria and Albania, with Yugoslavia occupying a slightly less certain position in the 'bloc'; the old geographically-based distinctions between Central, East-Central, Northern, Southern and South-Eastern Europe ceased to be part of the political lexicon, and the six, and later ten and now twelve, states that adhered to the Treaty of Rome arrogated to themselves the identity of 'European Community': see Jahn, op. cit., pp. 204–5. Already the old terminology is being revived, and the blanket term 'Eastern Europe' is being replaced inside those countries by the term 'post-communist Europe'. See also Timothy Garton Ash, 'Eastern Europe: The Year of Truth', *The New York Review of Books*, 15 Feb. 1990, p. 17. In the present collection, no standard usage has been imposed on contributors.
8. The change of title has been to little avail, however, in Hungary, Poland or Czechoslovakia: Romania is a moot case, given the strength of former communists in the National Salvation Front; in Bulgaria and Albania (and Mongolia, where other parties have likewise been legalized) the former communists enjoyed initial electoral success, although their long-term performance seems likely to deteriorate.
9. Westoby, *The Evolution of Communism*, p. 14, suggests that the use of the word 'evolution' is an analogy.
10. As an example of such writing, see Kenneth S. Sherrill, 'The Attitudes of Modernity', *Comparative Politics*, Vol.1, No.1 (1969), pp.184–210, a study of the attitudes of 'politically modern man' based on 'the assumption that the United States is modern' (p.184).
11. See, for example, Alfred G. Meyer, 'Theories of Convergence', in Johnson, *Change in Communist Systems*, pp.313–41, esp. p.322.
12. Holmes, *Politics in the Communist World*, p.74.
13. For selections see Mark Ridley (ed.), *The Essential Darwin* (London: Unwin Hyman, 1987).
14. Quoted in Adam Ulam, *The Unfinished Revolution: An Essay on the Sources of Influence of Marxism and Communism* (New York, NY: Vintage Books, 1964), p.12.
15. Eduard Bernstein, *Evolutionary Socialism: A Critique and Affirmation*, translated by Edith C. Harvey (London: Independent Labour Party, 1909; reprinted New York: Schocken Books, 1961).
16. See, for example, the contributions to Robert C. Tucker (ed.), *Stalinism: Essays in Historical Interpretation* (New York: Norton, 1977).
17. See M. Abercrombie, M. Hichman, M.L. Johnson and M. Thain (eds.), *The New Penguin Dictionary of Biology* (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1990), p.121.
18. An alternative way of looking at Trotskyism, and indeed other schismatic Marxist sects, is to see them as fossils: valuable for the historian of ideas and political movements, just as the fossil record is vital for the study of evolution of species.
19. See Robert A. Dahl, *Modern Political Analysis* (Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall, 1963), Ch.1.
20. That is certainly how communists themselves – and not simply the party's propagandists

- viewed their creation; for a Western explication of the significance of this, see Jerry F. Hough and Merle Fainsod, *How the Soviet Union is Governed* (Cambridge, MA, and London: Harvard University Press, 1979), p.289.
21. See J.L. Talmon, *The Origins of Totalitarian Democracy* (London: Secker & Warburg, 1952).
 22. Seweryn Bialer and Michael Mandelbaum, *The Global Rivals: The Soviet-American Contest for Supremacy* (London: Tauris, 1989), p.172.
 23. *Ibid.*, p.173.
 24. Abercrombie et al., *Dictionary*, p.525. These authors point out the limitations of such a traditional definition, and indicate alternative approaches. See also Colin Patterson, *Evolution* (London: British Museum (Natural History), 1978), p.13.
 25. Patterson, *Evolution*, pp.94–9.
 26. For a summary of hybrid sterility, see Patterson, *Evolution*, pp.38–9; Abercrombie et al., *Dictionary*, pp.281–2.
 27. Abercrombie et al., *Dictionary*, p.227.
 28. Isaac Deutscher, *The Unfinished Revolution: Russia, 1917–1967* (London: Oxford University Press, 1967), p.11.
 29. See Adam Ulam, *The Unfinished Revolution: An Essay on the Sources of Influence of Marxism and Communism* (New York: Vintage Books, 1964); John H. Kautsky, 'Comparative Communism versus Comparative Politics', *Studies in Comparative Communism*, Vol.VI, No.2 (1973), pp.135–70.
 30. See Patterson, *Evolution*, pp.70–1.
 31. See Gabriel A. Almond, 'Capitalism and Democracy', *PS: Political Science and Politics*, Vol.XXIV, No.3 (1991), pp.467–74 (p.467).
 32. See Ye. Ambartsumov, 'O putyakh sovershenstvovaniya politicheskoi sistemy sotsializma', in Yu.N. Afanas'ev (ed.), *Inogo ne dano* (Moscow: Progress, 1988), pp.77–96 (p.79). In the same book, S. Dzarasov states that the failure of NEP in the 1920s and the Kosygin reforms of 1965 was due to the absence of the political preconditions for their success see his 'Partiinaya demokratiya i byurokratiya: k istokam problemy', *ibid.*, pp.324–42 (p.324).
 33. See the brief analysis of the emerging Soviet literature on interests in Ronald J. Hill, *Soviet Politics, Political Science and Reform* (Oxford: Martin Robertson, 1980), Ch.5.
 34. See, in particular, H. Gordon Skilling's seminal article, 'Interest Groups in Communist Politics', *World Politics*, Vol.XVIII, (1966), pp.435–51; also his later collection, H. Gordon Skilling and Franklin Griffiths (eds.), *Interest Groups in Soviet Politics* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1971). Other scholars also took up the theme.
 35. Lamarck's postulation of the inheritance of acquired characteristics suffered by the development of the science of genetics. Lamarckism – in the form of Michurinism, – was made officially 'true' under Stalin and Khrushchev, as popularized by Trofim Lysenko. His claims concerning the 'yarovization' of wheat (transforming spring into winter varieties) were granted the sponsorship of the highest political authorities, until discredited in the 1960s, after much damage had been caused to Soviet agriculture: see Patterson, *Evolution*, pp.148, 177–8; Abercrombie et al., *Dictionary*, pp.318–19. One philosopher who maintained the validity of Lamarckism was Arthur Koestler: a summary of his objections to 'the narrow sectarianism of the neo-Darwinists of our own age' is to be found in his *Janus: A Summing Up* (London: Hutchinson, 1978), Chs.X and XI.
 36. See Stephen White, 'The USSR: Patterns of Autocracy and Industrialism', in Brown and Gray, *Political Culture and Communist States*, pp.25–65; also, for a fuller treatment, Stephen White, *Political Culture and Soviet Politics* (London: Macmillan, 1979), Ch.2.

The Soviet Union: Gorbachev, *Perestroika* and Socialism

STEPHEN WHITE

The Russian revolution of 1917 was originally conceived as part of a transition to socialism on a global scale. The failure of that strategy led to a far-reaching debate about the means by which a relatively backward Soviet Russia could advance by itself to a communist future. The Gorbachev years saw the issue addressed in terms of the construction of a 'humane, democratic socialism', seen as part of a global process; individual scholars and publicists advanced still further towards a socialism that would embody a multi-party system and a variety of forms of ownership. Increasingly, however, still more radical commentators identified the origin of Soviet difficulties as Leninism itself. There was, in fact, little popular support for a return to capitalism; but the experience of Soviet rule showed that the authorities in that country needed the political experience of the West as much as they needed its capital investment.

The Russian revolution was conceived as a step towards a worldwide socialist revolution. The leading capitalist states, it was thought, were held together by finance capital; a decisive blow at the 'weakest link', the Russian empire, would lead to the overthrow of capitalism first in that country and then worldwide. The first Soviet administration was simply a 'workers' and peasants' government', not one that was associated with any particular state, and steps were taken in early agreements – notably the treaty with Finland of 1 March 1918 – to make provision for supra-national forms of economic management.¹ The constitution of the RSFSR, adopted in July of the same year, accorded the political rights enjoyed by Russian citizens on an equal basis to foreigners employed within the territory of the RSFSR and 'belonging to the working class or to the non-exploiting peasantry', and they enjoyed the right to elect and be elected to the soviets (representative councils) and their executive committees. As new nations joined the proletarian revolution and united with the RSFSR, the jurist Peter Stuchka suggested, it was likely that the title of the constitution would in due course have to be changed to that of the 'European Soviet Federated Socialist Republic'.²

Stephen White is Professor of Politics and a member of the Institute of Soviet and East European Studies at the University of Glasgow. A second edition of his study of the Gorbachev administration, *Gorbachev and After*, appeared in 1991.

The Russian revolution, Lenin explained, was 'only the beginning of the world socialist revolution'. There was no doubt that the socialist revolution in Europe 'must and will begin. All our hopes for a *final* victory of socialism are founded on that certainty.' They had never deluded themselves, he added, that they would be able to complete the transition to socialism without the help of the international proletariat. The Russians had begun the revolution; the French, Germans and British would complete it, and socialism would be victorious.³ They were fighting not only against Russian capitalism, Lenin explained in January 1919: they were 'fighting against the capitalism of all countries, against world capitalism, for the freedom of all workers'.⁴ It was a struggle, moreover, in which the Bolsheviks were bound to be successful. 'No force on earth,' Lenin asserted in March 1919, could 'hold back the progress of the world communist revolution towards the world Soviet republic'.⁵ That July, he declared in the summer of 1919, would be the 'last difficult July': the following July would be met by the 'victory of the international Soviet republic – and that victory will be complete and final'.⁶

The Communist International (Comintern) was established in March 1919 to give the workers of the world the decisive leadership they needed. The first issue of its new journal appeared, appropriately enough, on 1 May 1919. 'In 1919 the great Communist International was born', declared an editorial; in 1920, it promised, 'the great international Soviet republic will be born'. The International's chairman, Grigorii Zinoviev, writing in the first issue on the prospects for proletarian revolution, noted that 'while these lines are being written, the Third International has as its main base already three Soviet republics – in Russia, Hungary and Bavaria'. But nobody would be surprised if by the time his lines appeared in print there were 'not three, but six or more Soviet republics'. In a year, he forecast, they would 'already be beginning to forget that in Europe there was a struggle for communism, for in a year all Europe will be communist'. Capitalism might survive for a further year in Britain and America; but this would be 'beside a wholly communist European continent'.⁷

The Soviet republics in Hungary and Bavaria, however, soon foundered, and by the end of the year Lenin, while expressing his 'firm belief' in victory, drew attention to the 'difficulties and sacrifices' that had been experienced.⁸ Zinoviev admitted to the Second Congress of the Comintern in the summer of 1920 that they had been 'over-enthusiastic': 'two or even three years', he conceded, might now be necessary before Europe became Soviet. The victory of the Communist International, he wrote, was none the less 'unconditionally guaranteed', and in the 'shortest possible time' they would see the international Soviet socialist republic.⁹

The year 1920, the Comintern's journal admitted, in the end turned out to be 'a year of difficult struggles' in which a number of heavy defeats had been suffered.¹⁰ On the whole, Zinoviev told the thirteenth congress of the Russian Communist Party in 1924, they had judged the objective tendencies of development correctly. But the factor of 'time', he admitted, 'we did not assess entirely accurately'. At the time of the Brest-Litovsk treaty of 1918, even Lenin had been convinced that the victory of the revolution in most of the advanced capitalist countries was a matter of two or three months at most. It was now clear that such a revolution would be a matter not of 'three months, but of a far longer period'.¹¹ In short, a particular course of political evolution towards world-wide socialism envisaged following the socialist revolution gradually came to be seen as unlikely in the expected time-scale.

One consequence of this disappointing experience was a greater degree of attention to the revolution in the developing and colonial world. The Second Congress of the Communist International in 1920 was urged by its journal to 'direct its attentions to the East – for whoever is able to approach the subject nations of the East and then make them his allies ... will emerge victorious in the final struggle between labour and capital'.¹² Soviets, Lenin insisted in his address to the congress, were possible in the countries of the East: not workers' but peasants' or toilers' soviets. The principle of the soviet was a simple one, and it applied not only to proletarian but also to peasant, feudal and semi-feudal relations. On this basis, it would be possible to unite the revolutionary workers of the developed countries with the 'revolutionary masses of those countries where there is no, or almost no, proletariat, with the oppressed masses of colonial, eastern countries'. More generally, revolutionary work of this kind must now become their 'main task'.¹³

A second reorientation was, inevitably, towards the construction of a socialist society within the USSR itself – a second form of intervention in the process of attempting to create a new species of human society. The possibility that the period of stability in Western Europe would be short-lived could not be discounted. But the third congress of the Comintern, which met in the summer of 1921, had to reckon with the failure of the ill-judged 'March action' in Germany and with the introduction of the New Economic Policy in Russia itself. This, Zinoviev admitted, was a 'political setback for the entire workers' movement ... that slowed down the tempo of the proletarian revolution'. The converse was also true: the setback that the Western proletariat had suffered between 1919 and 1921 had also influenced the policy of the first proletarian state.¹⁴ A more revolutionary strategy enjoyed some support within the party during the 1920s, and developments such as the British General Strike and civil

unrest in China suggested it might not be an entirely unrealistic one. In the event, the party reoriented itself towards 'socialism in one country', and opponents of such a strategy were deprived of their positions and sometimes of their liberty. A socialist society, on this basis, was supposedly achieved in the late 1930s; but it still remained to elaborate a strategy by which a large but peripheral nation, without obvious advantages in terms of its political traditions or level of development, could achieve a transition to the fully communist society of the future.

By the time Gorbachev came into office, however, after several decades of 'socialist construction', it was clear that the evolution of Soviet society towards 'communism' had been led into stagnation, and that decisive new measures would be needed to induce the appropriate changes.

Gorbachev and the Problem of Transition

Gorbachev, on his accession to power, saw economic reform as 'the key to all our problems, immediate and long-term, economic and social, political and ideological, domestic and foreign', and the only way in which a new kind of Soviet socialism could be built.¹⁵ Increasingly, however, the emphasis shifted to political reform as the means by which economic development could be accelerated, and to the elaboration of a model of socialism that advanced decisively on those that had preceded it. Gorbachev described this vision at the Central Committee plenum of April 1985, hardly in the most memorable terms, as a 'qualitatively new state [*sostoyanie*] of society'.¹⁶ Elsewhere he referred to it as 'developing socialism', differentiating it from the 'developed socialism' that was supposed to have been constructed in the Brezhnev era, and still more so from the utopian vision of a society rapidly advancing towards full communism that had been current in the Khrushchev years. Later still, from 1990, the objective became 'humane, democratic socialism'.¹⁷ And yet, six years or more into the new administration, the nature of Gorbachevian socialism remained frustratingly elusive. What kind of society did he envisage, beyond some rather vacuous generalities? Was the vision a coherent and convincing one? And how was it to be achieved: was there agreement about it within the leadership and the wider society, and did a political agency exist that could bring it into being?

Gorbachev's early speeches paid relatively little attention to the longer-term objectives he had in mind for Soviet society. His acceptance speech, in March 1985, promised that the strategy worked out by the twenty-sixth party congress (over which Leonid Brezhnev had presided) and at subsequent meetings of the Central Committee would remain

unchanged: his policy would be one of 'the acceleration of the country's socioeconomic development [and] the perfection of all aspects of the life of the society'.¹⁸ His first full address to the Central Committee in April 1985 again emphasized the importance of the twenty-sixth congress and called for a 'steady advance' rather than a clear break with earlier policies; the party's general line, as he explained it, involved 'the perfection of developed socialist society', a characterization that was thoroughly Brezhnevian in tone. Gorbachev did call for 'further changes and transformations' and for the establishment of a 'qualitatively new state of society, in the broadest sense of the word'. However, it was changes in the economy that would be decisive in any development of this kind, and the speech was largely preoccupied with such familiar matters as growth, waste and labour productivity.¹⁹

The most authoritative statement of the party's longer-term purposes is its programme, first adopted in 1903 and then in further editions in 1919 and 1961.²⁰ The 1961 programme, hailed by Khrushchev as a 'Communist Manifesto of the modern era', was best known for its assumption that the achievement of a fully communist society had become 'an immediate practical task for the Soviet people'. By the end of that decade, it promised, the strongest and richest capitalist country, the USA, would be overtaken in total production. By the end of the 1970s a state of abundance would be created and a communist society 'in the main' would be constructed, to be 'fully completed' over the following period.²¹ These optimistic perspectives were quickly abandoned by Khrushchev's successors, and under Brezhnev it began to be claimed that the USSR had achieved no more than the construction of a 'developed socialist society', a new and quite distinct stage of Soviet development whose further evolution into full communism would be a matter for the fairly distant future.²² The party programme of 1961 was clearly difficult to reconcile with these rather different perspectives, and the twenty-sixth congress in 1981 approved Brezhnev's proposal that a new edition should be prepared. The essentials of the existing programme, Brezhnev explained, were still valid, but 20 years had elapsed since its adoption, and there were many developments it had failed to record, among them the fact that Soviet society was proceeding to communism through the 'historically extended' stage of developed socialism.²³

Brezhnev became chairman of the committee that was charged with the preparation of a new draft, and on his death the following year his successor, Yuri Andropov, assumed the same responsibility. Andropov set out his general approach to such matters in a speech in the spring of 1983 in which he emphasized that the Soviet Union was 'only at the beginning' of the long historical stage of developed socialism: there must

be no exaggeration of the country's closeness to communism, and no attempt to minimize the difficulties that lay ahead.²⁴ Discussing the party programme more directly, Andropov told the Central Committee in June 1983 that many of its directives had in fact been realized: links between citizens and deputies had become closer, and national discussion of major items of legislation had become a well-established practice. Some of the assumptions of the programme, however, had not withstood the test of time, and there were elements of 'detachment from reality, undue anticipation and unnecessary detail'.²⁵ These emphases were repeated by Konstantin Chernenko, party general secretary from 1984 to 1985. He stressed the need to remove the 'over-simplified impression of the means and dates by which a transition to the higher stage of communism' would take place, and warned that developed socialism would itself be a 'historically protracted period'.²⁶

Gorbachev succeeded Chernenko not only as general secretary but also, it emerged, as chairman of the commission preparing the new programme. He set out his thinking in an address to the Central Committee in October 1985. Gorbachev emphasized the continuity of political principle between the new version of the programme and its predecessors, but he also pointed out the need for 'creative development' in the light of changing domestic and international circumstances. His speech reflected his predecessors' determination to avoid 'excessive detail and groundless fantasy', and in particular any 'rushing ahead, introducing communist principles without taking into account the level of society's material and intellectual maturity'. The central aim, he explained, was to attain 'a qualitatively new state of Soviet society through acceleration of the country's socioeconomic development'. The economy, as before, would have 'a decisive role', but so too would the widening of socialist democracy, including the active participation of ordinary people in state and public affairs.²⁷ The draft programme was published in the central press for public discussion in October 1985; altogether, Gorbachev told the twenty-seventh congress the following February, six million responses had been received from ordinary citizens, raising a whole variety of issues.²⁸

A number of these correspondents, Gorbachev reported, had in fact suggested that the new text should be considered an entirely new (fourth) party programme, rather than a revision of the third, because the changes it proposed were so far-reaching.²⁹ Perhaps the most striking single change in the new programme was the abandonment of the optimistic perspectives of its Khrushchevian predecessor. The 1961 programme, for instance, had defined itself as 'a programme for the building of communist society'; the revised version of 1986 was no more than a programme for

the 'planned and all-round perfection of socialism' and for further advance to communism through the country's 'accelerated socio-economic development'. The dates and stages by which communism was to be reached disappeared entirely; the 1986 programme, on the contrary, noted that the party did 'not attempt to foresee in detail the features of full communism', and warned that any attempt to advance too rapidly was 'doomed to failure and might cause both political and economic damage'. The collectivist emphases of the 1961 programme – more and more services such as transport and housing to be provided free of charge; more public catering and shared upbringing of children, for example – found no place in the new text, nor did the promise of a minimum one-month paid holiday for all citizens. The 1986 programme, similarly, contained no reference to the historic goal of the withering away of the state: its main emphasis was on practical and short-term objectives, and it struck a disciplinarian rather than utopian note in its references to careerism, nepotism and profiteering.³⁰

Both the new version of the programme and a revised set of party rules, approved at the twenty-seventh congress, included a reference to 'developed socialism'. During the period since the 1960s, as the party programme put it, the USSR had 'entered the stage of developed socialism'.³¹ Some of those who had commented on the draft of the new programme, Gorbachev revealed, thought the term should have been entirely removed; others, on the contrary, thought it should have been dealt with at greater length. The reference to developed socialism had in the end been retained, he explained, partly because it figured in the programmes of other ruling parties, but mainly because the term had been misrepresented. It had, in fact, originally been employed as a reaction against 'simplistic ideas about the means and time periods for carrying out the tasks of communist construction'. Latterly, however, it had become no more than a framework for the recording of successes, with little attention paid to problems such as the intensification of production or the improvement of food supplies. It was the earlier, less complacent version of the term that Gorbachev wished to emphasize.³² Developed socialism, nonetheless, did not subsequently figure in the general secretary's speeches or in party documents, and it was replaced later in the same year by the term 'developing socialism',³³ implying a still earlier stage in the transition towards the communist society of the future.

A fuller statement of Gorbachev's vision of the Soviet future came in the conclusion of his address to the nineteenth party conference in 1988. They were looking, he told the delegates, for a socialism that 'renounced everything that deformed socialism in the 1930s and that led to its stagnation in the 1970s', a socialism that would inherit the 'best elements'

of the thinking of its founding fathers, together with the constructive achievements of other countries and social systems. Although it was impossible to describe such a society in a detailed way, some of its main features could and should be indicated. Such a socialism, Gorbachev explained, would be a system of 'true and tangible humanism in which Man is really the measure of all things'. There would, for instance, be a dynamic and advanced economy with the highest possible labour productivity based upon a variety of forms of property and worker participation. It would combine a broad measure of central planning with a great deal of autonomy for individual enterprises, which would be self-financing and interconnected through a market. The basic needs of all for housing, health care and employment would be satisfied; at the same time the abilities of individuals would be highly rewarded, where this was appropriate, in both moral and material terms. A society of this kind would have a high level of culture and morality, and it would be managed by a system of genuine people's rule, of 'profound and consistent democracy'. This 'new image of socialism' was described by Gorbachev as 'democratic and humane', and in turn 'an important stage in the advance to communism'.³⁴

Gorbachev expanded upon this vision of a 'qualitatively new state of society' in an address to senior party functionaries in July 1989. It would, he explained, be 'a society of free people, a society of and for the working people, built on the principles of humanism, socialist democracy and social justice'. It would be based upon a variety of forms of public ownership which would enable people to be masters of their own lives and to give full play to their energy and abilities. Economic development would be based on self-regulation, with the centre playing a purely coordinating role. It would be a society in which the people would have 'absolute power and the full range of rights', and it would be based on both 'the finest traditions of Soviet democracy and the experience of mankind's democratic evolution'. Nations and ethnic groups, similarly, would have equal rights, at least within the Soviet federation. This would be a society with 'a rich inner life and a high level of culture and morality', and it would be 'open to the world, to co-operation in the interests of building new international relations based on free choice, equality, security and universal values'. However, this was no more than a 'general outline' that needed to be developed in detail by members of the scholarly community: indeed, it was 'vitally necessary' that they do so.³⁵

Gorbachev himself contributed to this task in an extended statement, 'The socialist idea and revolutionary *perestroika*', which appeared in *Pravda* in November 1989. It drew upon a series of speeches he had made in the late autumn, particularly an address to an all-union student forum.

If at first he had thought it would be sufficient simply to eliminate various shortcomings in Soviet life, Gorbachev explained, he was now in no doubt that nothing less than a radical reconstruction of the whole of society was necessary. There was no detailed plan to guide this work, nor could there be; but it would certainly avoid the command-administrative methods of the Soviet past and the capitalist methods of the West. A process of this kind – *perestroika* – would occupy ‘a lengthy stage in the historical development of socialism’, extending into the twenty-first century. Its ultimate objective would be the establishment of a ‘genuinely democratic and self-governing social organism’ in place of the authoritarianism and bureaucratic system that had come into existence in the Stalin years. Gorbachev had no doubt that the ‘socialist choice’ of October 1917 had been the correct one: the alternative at the time, he argued, had not been liberal democracy but some form of military dictatorship. Neither should Marx be blamed for developments he had been unable to foresee. Socialism, in any case, had to be conceived as ‘a global process’. The experience of other countries and movements, particularly European social democracy, provided much from which they could learn; and the future lay in a co-operative rather than a confrontational relationship between the USSR and the wider world, from which both sides could benefit.³⁶

Official perspectives of this kind were summed up in the ‘Programmatic Declaration’ adopted by the twenty-eighth party congress in July 1990. Entitled ‘Towards a Humane, Democratic Socialism’, the declaration insisted, as Gorbachev had done, that the origins of Soviet difficulties were to be found, not in any deficiency in the idea of socialism itself, but in the strategy that had been chosen to implement it. The declaration included a set of ‘urgent anti-crisis measures’ to deal with some of these concerns, including a new union treaty and the stabilization of the consumer market. For the longer term it envisaged the strengthening of civil liberties, a ‘stage-by-stage transition to a market system’, international co-operation, and democratization of the party itself. Gorbachev, in his own contribution to the discussion, spoke of ‘a civil society of free men and women’ which would replace the ‘Stalinist model’ of the past. Continuing the work of the twentieth congress of 1956, its purpose was to ‘profoundly democratize and humanize society, to make it free and create living conditions worthy of a human being’. The congress also agreed to begin work on a new, fourth party programme, which would replace the version of the third programme approved in 1986. According to an early draft, released in 1991, the new programme would give the CPSU the task of carrying out ‘historically progressive aims’ (but not necessarily communist ones), and socialism itself was defined as a society

of 'economic effectiveness, social justice, political democracy and human solidarity' (but not necessarily of public ownership).³⁷ For many, this was an abandonment rather than an evolutionary development of the revolutionary perspectives on which the regime had originally been founded.

Models of Socialist Society

This broad vision of the Soviet – and indeed global – future was carried forward in the late 1980s and early 1990s by a group of reform-minded academics and commentators, among them Fedor Burlatskii, Boris Kurashvili and Anatolii Butenko. Burlatskii, a people's deputy as well as a scholar and journalist, argued in favour of a decentralized, self-managed socialism which drew upon the experience of the New Economic Policy of the 1920s and of the socialist tradition in other countries. Two different conceptions of socialism, Burlatskii suggested, had been applied in the USSR during the post-revolutionary period. One of these was 'war communism', a centralized model based upon commands and coercion and harking back to the militarized society of the civil war. The other was the more relaxed model of the New Economic Policy, which was based upon a mixed economy and more democratic norms. The war communism model had enjoyed considerable popularity, in part because of the USSR's 'authoritarian-patriarchal culture', and had later taken the form of Stalinism, with its belief that the state should play the major part in the transition to socialism. This concept – state socialism – was however not properly socialist, and in any case it was inappropriate to modern conditions. It should be replaced, in Burlatskii's view, by a different concept, that of 'public, self-managing socialism', in which many functions at present performed by the state would be devolved to civil society and its institutions.

What would this 'qualitatively new model' of a 'more effective, democratic and humanistic socialism' look like? It would, Burlatskii suggested, be based on a wide variety of property forms, including state property which would be developed to the higher level of public ownership of the whole people. It would incorporate a variety of forms of enterprise, including individual, family and co-operative as well as state productive units, which would be economically self-sufficient and interrelated through a market. There would be a sharing of power between the party, the state and social organizations, and each of these would be based on more democratic norms, including the development of self-management, elections, the rotation of office and attention to public opinion. A wide variety of cultural trends would coexist, and a socialist culture and personality would develop. This form of socialism, based upon the

accountability of the state to society rather than vice versa, would take a long time to develop, but it was this form of socialism that supporters of *perestroika* hoped the party conference of 1988 would develop further³⁸ – as indeed it did.

Another, somewhat bolder, version of a Soviet 'tomorrow' was presented to the readers of *Moscow News* by Boris Kurashvili, a senior researcher at the Institute of State and Law of the USSR Academy of Sciences.³⁹ The future socialist society, he explained, would be one in which state planning would be retained in only a few essential sectors, but which would otherwise rely upon market forces. It would incorporate a variety of forms of property, including joint enterprises in which employees held up to 49 per cent of the shares. The party and state apparatus that was responsible for the management of the economy would be reduced to about one-tenth of its present size. Intra-party democracy would be revived within the CPSU, primarily through party-wide discussions and votes on major issues. 'Real power' would be restored to the elected soviets, and a 'mass public political organization' with some similarities to a second party would be set up to run them. In international relations there would be an era of 'growing co-operation' between capitalism and socialism, leading towards a synthesis that would combine the best features of both (Lenin's formulations on such matters, he suggested, were 'not always satisfactory').⁴⁰ Writing later on 'models of socialism', Kurashvili looked forward to a further stage of 'democratic socialism' that would include respect for minority rights, a separation of powers, genuine federalism and 'a socialist multi-party system'.⁴¹

Another contributor to the discussion was Anatolii Butenko, a department head at the Institute of the Economics of the World Socialist System at the USSR Academy of Sciences. In his writings of the early 1980s, which were strongly influenced by the Polish crisis, Butenko argued that Soviet-type societies did not eliminate 'contradictions', in particular those between the sectional interests of managers and the working people they directed.⁴² Writing subsequently and at greater length, Butenko set out a vision of the Soviet future that was based on the concept of 'socialist popular self-management' and which involved the abolition of the *nomenklatura* system of appointments and a wide-ranging electoral reform.⁴³ Interviewed in *Pravda*, Butenko placed the greatest emphasis on the emancipation of labour as the goal of socialism. This meant more than the elimination of exploitation, which had already been achieved in the Stalin period: it meant the elimination of the oppression of man by man, which could be achieved only by the working class itself and not by a bureaucracy on its behalf. Butenko called in particular for the establishment of a socialist civil society, based on a wide dispersal of ownership (so

long as workers depended upon their employers, even under public ownership, they could never become the agents of their own destiny). This meant individual and private as well as state and municipal ownership; and in the political sphere it meant 'genuine popular rule – rule of the people by the people themselves'.⁴⁴

Butenko was one of a group of leading scholars that met regularly during the late 1980s under party auspices with a view to formulating an adequate and up-to-date conception of socialism.⁴⁵ The results of their labours appeared in the party press in 1989: they summed up the perspectives of the most strongly reformist section of the social science community. Lenin's 'new model of socialism', they argued, had been put into effect during the 1920s, but then replaced by a Stalinist system that had 'created an alienation of the individual from ownership, from power and from the results of his work'. Liberating society from this legacy was no easy matter, because not only officials but wide strata of the population thought this Stalinist model was in fact the very essence of socialism. The statement distinguished, as Butenko had done, between exploitation (which had been eliminated by public ownership) and oppression, which had continued. More controversially, and following Hayek and other critics of socialist collectivism,⁴⁶ the group went on to argue that complete state ownership led to 'totalitarian forms of government', and that a wide variety of forms of property, including private ownership, was necessary if the personal liberties of citizens were to be protected. Economic life, more generally, was to be regulated through a 'socialist market', but with an improved system of social benefits to protect the disadvantaged from its worst effects. It would, finally, be a society based on the rule of law, and on universal human values such as honesty, decency and a sense of duty.⁴⁷

Scholarly thinking became still more outspoken in the early 1990s. Indeed, little of what had been unchallengeable orthodoxy since the 1920s remained untouched. The rector of the party's Institute of Social Sciences, Yuri Krasin, for instance, insisted on the continuing relevance of Marxist conceptions of social justice and equality, but accepted that the idea that commodity-money relations would be unnecessary in a socialist society had been disproved by practical experience.⁴⁸ S.S. Alekseev, chairman of the Constitutional Supervision Committee, found most of enduring value in the ideas of the early Marx, particularly his concept of alienation.⁴⁹ Georgii Shakhnazarov, head of the Soviet political science association and a Gorbachev adviser, went still further in a series of articles on the 'new model of socialism' in the party theoretical journal *Kommunist*. For Shakhnazarov, socialism would continue as long as mankind pursued a better world; but he rejected the idea of 'stages' in

human history and the primacy of economic factors, and saw communism itself as a 'hypothesis' or even a 'dream'.⁵⁰ Some were even prepared to argue that socialism was not necessarily incompatible with 'capitalist private property'.⁵¹ It was difficult, in any of this, to discover what a future socialist or communist society would be like: if there was consensus about anything, it was that it would not be based on public ownership, would not be dominated by a single ruling party, would not supersede capitalism and might not even offer an alternative to it.

Gorbachev's reforming programme, as we suggested at the outset, had been based on the assumption that the defects of the Soviet system were in no sense inherent in socialism but were rather the result of 'subjective' failings in leadership and policy formulation. What was the reason for their difficulties, he asked the Central Committee in April 1985? Natural and external factors had certainly played a part, but the main reason was that the system of management had been outstripped by changes in the wider society.⁵² For years, Gorbachev explained to the twenty-seventh party congress in 1986, party and government leaders had lagged behind the needs of the times. The faults that he identified, such as inert and bureaucratic management, were 'above all of a subjective character'; their elimination depended upon leaders bringing their methods of work into line with changing circumstances.⁵³ Speaking to the Russian party's founding congress in July 1990, Gorbachev acknowledged that the mechanical replacement of leading officials was 'not a panacea'; but people mattered more than structures, and the right appointments were of 'decisive' significance.⁵⁴ The 'root cause' of their difficulties, he told the Central Committee the following October, was the failure to respond adequately to the challenge of the times, or the 'inertia of old thinking'.⁵⁵ And in a speech in November 1990, he declared that 'the most important revolution' was 'the revolution in minds, in our heads, in us ourselves'.⁵⁶ Six years or more after his accession it was perhaps this assumption that had come under the greatest challenge of all.

Khrushchev, in the 1950s, had initiated the assault on Stalinism, but had similarly ascribed the abuses of those years to 'the cult of personality': the vanity, paranoia and other character faults of the Leader of Leaders himself. The Italian communist, Palmiro Togliatti, had at the time exposed that assumption to some searching criticism in a celebrated interview in the magazine *Nuovi argomenti*. Stalin's errors, Togliatti suggested, were not simply personal ones, but went 'deeper into the very roots of Soviet life'. To explain Stalinism in terms of character faults was, in fact, to remain within the terms of the 'cult of personality' itself, and the real question was evaded, namely why Soviet society had degenerated in the way it had. The increasing dominance in party and state life of a

bureaucratic apparatus appeared to be a necessary part of such an explanation; so were the historical circumstances – civil war, and then industrialization – in which Stalin had come to power.⁵⁷ Satisfactory or not, this was at least a diagnosis that located Stalinism within the society of which it was a part, and it took the debate beyond the issue of the personality of individual leaders to which Khrushchev – and, following him, Gorbachev – had largely wished to confine it.

One of the most notable developments in the Soviet debate of the late 1980s and early 1990s, in fact, was precisely the hesitant beginnings of a search for the answers to Soviet problems beyond the framework of Soviet socialism altogether. One of these controversies concerned the nature of the USSR itself: was it to be considered a socialist society, even a deformed one, or not? Some of these articles took as their point of departure Gorbachev's slogan of 'More socialism! More democracy!' Socialism, it was noted, had officially been established in the USSR in the late 1930s. If this was the case, how could more of it be needed in the late 1980s? And if what had been established was not socialism, how was it to be classified?⁵⁸ A related issue was the necessity of the October revolution and, intimately connected with it, the validity of the heritage of Leninism. Had the October revolution, as some were maintaining, prevented a normal pattern of peaceful and democratic evolutionary development after Tsarist rule had been overthrown? How much blame should be attached to Lenin for the repressive, over-centralized system that had succeeded him? How much, indeed, was Marxism itself to blame for the economic inefficiency and political authoritarianism that had characterized at least a substantial part of Soviet history?⁵⁹

Gorbachev, speaking to the party congress in 1990, refused to offer an answer in terms of the infamous Stalinist *Short Course*.⁶⁰ Writing in late 1989, however, he insisted that liberal democracy, whatever its merits, had not been on offer in October 1917, and that the Marxist tradition, although it had underestimated capitalism's ability to adapt, still provided a uniquely valuable insight into societies and their development.⁶¹ For a growing number of academics and publicists, by the early 1990s, these were not assumptions that could be allowed to remain unchallenged. Perhaps the most notable attack was a series of articles by Aleksandr Tsipko, formerly a member of the Central Committee's own staff, which traced the roots of Stalinism to Marxism itself. The deformation of socialism, for Tsipko, had doctrinal as well as other origins: it was pointless, for instance, to pretend that there could be firm guarantees of democracy if all were employed by the state, or of liberty if it were believed that the revolution was 'its own justification and its own law'.⁶² Another scholar, the sociologist Igor Klyamkin, argued similarly that

Stalinism was not the aberration of a single man but the logical result of Lenin's single-party system, which prized unity more than democracy and had remained largely intact ever since.⁶³

These, clearly, were more than academic debates: at least implicitly they raised the question of the nature of Soviet society and the claim of the communist party to exercise political authority within it. Lenin, in his later writings, had argued that the competition between capitalism and socialism would be won, in the last resort, by the system that provided the higher level of labour productivity.⁶⁴ It was difficult, in the early 1990s, to argue that Soviet socialism had provided higher living standards for its people than those that prevailed in the developed capitalist world: the claim was rather, as Gorbachev put it during his visit to the United States in late 1988, that it made available a better standard of social security (*zashchishchennost'*) to all its citizens.⁶⁵ Yet even this became more and more difficult to defend as the quality of Soviet health care, housing and other services came under critical scrutiny, as the commitment to full employment was gradually relinquished, and as the social benefits provided in most Western states became better known. The writer Chingiz Aitmatov, for instance, a communist member of the Congress of People's Deputies, pointed out that workers in countries like Sweden, Austria and the Netherlands earned four or five times the amount that a Soviet worker could hope to attain; not only this, their social security and welfare rights were vastly superior.⁶⁶ For economist and people's deputy Oleg Bogomolov, writing in 1989, Sweden and Austria might in fact have found 'the only realistic way to put many socialist ideas into practice in the current world context'.⁶⁷

There were many who saw these changes as 'the end of history', or in Zbigniew Brzezinski's words, a 'grand failure'.⁶⁸ It was perhaps closer to the truth to see them as the gradual return of Bolshevism to the social democratic tradition of which it had originally been part. There was certainly little popular support for a straightforward return to capitalism. Asked in late 1990 what they would do if the October revolution took place a second time, 43 per cent of a national sample told pollsters that they would actively or passively support the Bolsheviks, and only six per cent would oppose them.⁶⁹ Asked in early 1991 what kind of society should be constructed in the Russian republic, 56 per cent thought it should be a Swedish-style combination of the best features of capitalism and socialism, 29 per cent said it should be a socialist one, and only three per cent opted for undisguised capitalism.⁷⁰ After the failure of the coup in August 1991, even Gorbachev drew the same conclusion: communism, he told an American television audience, at least in its Soviet form, had clearly failed, and he identified himself more closely than ever before

with the socialism of Olof Palme and Willy Brandt.⁷¹ Before the year was out, however, Gorbachev was outmanoeuvred by his former communist colleague, Boris Yeltsin; the communist party was banned and its assets seized; the old structures voted themselves out of existence, the Soviet Union ceased to exist, and, as elsewhere in the wake of the demise of the traditional communist system, capitalism and a competitive political system became the stated goal of the new order.

This, it appeared, was the final outcome of more than 70 years of Soviet political evolution: an abandonment of the attempt to construct a communist society in isolation from the outside world, and the resumption of a dialogue with European social democracy that had been broken off by the October revolution. The evolution in thinking about 'socialism' and the attempts to introduce adaptive changes had manifestly taken place in a political environment that was not conducive to its survival. Communism as a form of rule had failed in the land of its birth; communism as an ideal society towards which the human race should direct its social and political evolution seemed by the end of 1991 to be a less realistic goal than ever.

NOTES

1. Treaty of Friendship with the Finnish Socialist Workers' Republic, 1 March 1918, in Yu. V. Klyuchnikov and A. Sabanin (eds), *Mezhdunarodnaya politika noveishego vremeni v dogovorakh, notakh i deklaratsiyakh* (Moscow, 1925–28), Vol.2, p.120. This treaty is not reproduced in the official series *Dokumenty vneshnei politiki SSSR* (Moscow, 1957 onwards).
2. P. Stuchka, *Konstitutsiya Rossiiskoi Sotsialisticheskoi Federativnoi Sovetskoi Respubliki v voprosakh i otvetakh* (Moscow, 1919), pp.74–5, 89, 19.
3. V.I. Lenin, *Polnoe sobranie sochinenii*, 5th edn, 55 vols (Moscow, 1957–65) (*Pol. sob. soch.*), Vol.35, pp.170, 247, 271, 279.
4. *Ibid.*, Vol.37, p.40.
5. *VIII s'ezd RKP(b): Stenograficheskii otchet* (Moscow, 1919), p.7; Lenin, *Pol. sob. soch.*, Vol.38, p.262.
6. Lenin, *Pol. sob. soch.*, Vol.37, pp.511 and 520, and Vol.39, p.89.
7. *Kommunisticheskii internatsional*, No.1 (May 1919), Cols.28, 38, 42–4.
8. Lenin, *Pol. sob. soch.*, Vol.40, p.31.
9. *Kommunisticheskii internatsional, Vtoroi kongress: stenograficheskii otchet* (Moscow, 1934), p.11; G. Zinov'ev, *Kommunisticheskii internatsional* (Petrograd, 1920), p.38.
10. *Kommunisticheskii internatsional*, No.10 (1920), Col.1445.
11. *Trinadtsatyi s'ezd RKP(b): Stenograficheskii otchet* (Moscow, 1924), p.42.
12. *Communist International*, June–July 1920, Col.2316.
13. *Kommunisticheskii internatsional, Vtoroi kongress*, p.28.
14. Quoted in Jane Degras, 'United Front Tactics in the Comintern', *St Antony's Papers*, No.9 (London, 1960), p.10.
15. *Materialy XXVII s'ezda KPSS* (Moscow: Politizdat, 1986), p.22.
16. M.S. Gorbachev, *Izbrannye rechi i stat'i*, 6 vols (Moscow: Politizdat, 1987–89), Vol.2, p.154.
17. *Ibid.*, Vol.4, p.110. The notion of 'humane, democratic socialism' was endorsed by the

- twenty-eighth CPSU congress in 1990: *Materialy XXVIII s'ezda KPSS* (Moscow: Politizdat, 1990), pp.77–98.
18. Gorbachev, *Izbrannye rechi i stat'i*, Vol.2, p.129.
 19. *Ibid.*, pp.152–73, esp. pp.153–67.
 20. Texts of all these editions are conveniently available in *Programmy i ustavy KPSS* (Moscow: Politizdat, 1969). For a discussion of these earlier documents and a text of the 1986 programme see Stephen White, *Soviet Communism: Programme and Rules* (London: Routledge, 1989).
 21. White, *Soviet Communism*, p.10.
 22. For a discussion see Alfred B. Evans, 'Developed Socialism and the New Programme of the CPSU', in Stephen White and Alex Pravda (eds.), *Ideology and Soviet Politics* (London: Macmillan, 1988), pp.83–113.
 23. *XXVI s'ezd Kommunisticheskoi partii Sovetskogo Soyuza, 23 fevralya – 3 marta 1981 goda: Stenograficheskii otchet*, 3 vols. (Moscow: Politizdat, 1981), Vol.1, pp.97–8.
 24. Yu. V. Andropov, *Izbrannye rechi i stat'i*, 2nd edn (Moscow: Politizdat, 1983), pp.245–6.
 25. *Pravda*, 16 June 1983, pp.1–2.
 26. *Ibid.*, 26 April 1984, p.1.
 27. Gorbachev, *Izbrannye rechi i stat'i*, Vol.3, pp.6–8.
 28. *Ibid.*, p.275; on the discussion see White, *Soviet Communism*, pp.14–17.
 29. Gorbachev, *Izbrannye rechi i stat'i*, Vol.3, p.276.
 30. White, *Soviet Communism*, pp.18–19.
 31. *Ibid.*, p.42 (and in the Rules, p.117).
 32. Gorbachev, *Izbrannye rechi i stat'i*, Vol.3, p.276.
 33. *Ibid.*, Vol.4, p.110.
 34. *Ibid.*, Vol.6, pp.395–7.
 35. *Perestroika raboty partii – vazhneishaya klyuchevaya zadacha dnya* (Moscow: Politizdat, 1989), pp.30–31.
 36. *Pravda*, 26 Nov. 1989, pp.1–3.
 37. *Izvestiya TsK KPSS*, 1991, No.2, pp.17–22. The 'Programmatic Declaration' is in *Materialy XXVIII s'ezda KPSS*, pp.77–98.
 38. *Literaturnaya gazeta*, 20 April 1988, p.2.
 39. *Moscow News*, 5 June 1988, p.13.
 40. *Ibid.*
 41. *Sovetskoe gosudarstvo i pravo*, 1989, No.8, pp.99–110. Kurashvili's thinking had evolved still further towards a 'left-centrist' position based on 'constructive multi-partyism' by the early 1990s: see B.P. Kurashvili, *Strana na rasput'e* (Moscow: Yuridicheskaya literatura, 1990).
 42. For this discussion see White and Pravda, *Ideology and Soviet Politics*, pp.14–16.
 43. A.P. Butenko, *Vlast' naroda posredstvom samogo naroda* (Moscow: Mysl', 1988), pp.168, 144, 173.
 44. *Pravda*, 8 Aug. 1989, p.3.
 45. See 'Problemy razrabotki kontseptsii sovremennogo sotsializma', *Voprosy filosofii*, 1988, No.11, pp.31–71.
 46. Hayek was described as the 'idol' of economic oppositionists in *Pravda*, 6 June 1990, p.4. For translations of his work in Russian see, for instance, *Mirovaya ekonomika i mezhdunarodnye otnosheniya*, 1989, No.12, pp.5–14, and *Voprosy filosofii*, 1990, Nos.10 and 11.
 47. *Pravda*, 14 July 1989, p.2, and 16 July 1989, p.3. An article in *Kommunist*, 'K novomu obliku sotsializma', was also influential: it called for the rebirth of civil society, obtainable only through economic pluralism (*Kommunist*, 1989, No.13, pp.3–24).
 48. *Kommunist*, 1991, No.1, p.29.
 49. *Dialog*, 1990, No.9, pp.56–64.
 50. *Kommunist*, 1991, Nos. 4 and 5.
 51. V. Ye. Guliev (ed.), *Politicheskaya reforma: tseli, protivorechiya, etapy* (Moscow: Institute of State and Law, 1990), p.30.

52. Gorbachev, *Izbrannye rechi i stat'i*, Vol.2, p.154.
53. Ibid., Vol.3, pp.181-3.
54. *Pravda*, 26 June 1990, p.2.
55. Ibid., 9 Oct. 1990, p.1.
56. Ibid., 16 Nov. 1990, p.3.
57. Henry L. Roberts (ed.), *The Anti-Stalin Campaign and International Communism* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1956), pp.119-28.
58. See Anatolii Butenko in Yuri Afanas'ev (ed.), *Inogo ne dano* (Moscow: Progress, 1988), pp.551-2.
59. See the discussion between Ambartsumov, Zdravomyslov and others in *Pravda*, 21 Jan. 1990, p.2.
60. *Materialy XXVIII s'ezda KPSS*, p.62.
61. *Pravda*, 26 Nov. 1989, p.1.
62. A. Tsipko in *Nauka i zhizn'*, 1988, Nos. 11 and 12, and 1989, Nos 1 and 2.
63. Igor' Klyamkin in *Novyi mir*, 1989, No.2, pp.204-38.
64. Lenin, *Pol. sob. soch.*, Vol.39, pp.21-2.
65. *Izbrannye rechi i stat'i*, Vol.5, p.301.
66. *Izvestiya*, 4 June 1989, p.2.
67. *Soviet Weekly*, 4 Nov. 1989, p.15.
68. The reference to the end of history is from Francis Fukuyama's celebrated article in *The National Interest*, Summer 1989, pp.3-18; Brzezinski's views are set out in *The Grand Failure: The Birth and Death of Communism in the Twentieth Century* (London: Macdonald, 1990).
69. All-Union Centre for the Study of Public Opinion, *Obshchestvennoe mnenie v tsifrakh*, No.16 (Moscow, 1990), pp.19-21.
70. *Izvestiya*, 24 April 1991, p.1.
71. *Izvestiya*, 6 Sept. 1991, p.3.

Saints and Demons: Communism, Post-Communism and Political Evolution in Poland

PAUL G. LEWIS

The terminal state of Polish communism and its failure to evolve were in most ways made evident during 1980–81, well before the communist loss of power in 1989. The analysis of politics in terms of saints and demons, decried by PCI leader Enrico Berlinguer, was virtually unavoidable in the Polish context as these were precisely the terms in which the communist period was generally understood. The failure of political evolution in Poland was most obviously reflected in the country's poor economic record and political inability to introduce effective reform measures in the face of apparatus resistance. Such obstacles to communist evolution continued to be reflected in the problematic course of post-communist development.

Evolution and development may well be contentious terms when applied to political life, but to the extent that they are relevant (and it is difficult on the face of it to escape the feeling that they do indeed make a contribution to our understanding of politics) Poland provides a prime example of communist failure in this respect. Much of this was evident in the initial weakness of communist power in Poland and its continuing erosion throughout most of the subsequent period. While the installation of Tadeusz Mazowiecki in September 1989 as the first non-communist prime minister in Eastern Europe since the 1940s was the most striking example of this, it was obvious in many other respects that the game was up in terms of the viability of the communist system and its capacity for development and persistence with, firstly, the rise and temporary survival of the Solidarity movement and, secondly, the resort to military force to cope with its consequences.

The emergence of a mass workers' movement resolutely opposed to communist rule offered a critical challenge to the formal leadership of the Polish United Workers' Party and showed its claim to authority to be the empty pretence it was in practice. The resort to military force in order to maintain the forms of communist party rule dispelled all notions about the significance of party organization and its supposed role within the

Paul G. Lewis is Senior Lecturer in Government at the Open University. He is the author of *Political Authority and Party Secretaries in Poland 1975–1986* (1989), and editor of *Democracy and Civil Society in Eastern Europe* (forthcoming, 1992).

political system. The process of renewal within the party organization had been resolutely opposed by hard-line elements and possibilities of accommodation with Solidarity persistently undermined. With the choice of a military solution, political pacification was effectively chosen in preference to strategies that might have enhanced the capacity of the system for managed change; the prospects of political evolution in communist Poland, however unlikely, were finally dispelled. The PCI (Italian Communist Party) and its perceptive leader, Enrico Berlinguer, were among the first to draw the appropriate conclusions from these developments.

They also confronted the need to explain this traumatic failure. What, Berlinguer asked at the PCI Central Committee meeting in December 1981, shortly after the proclamation of military rule, were the underlying causes of the crises in Poland? Part of his answer was the following:

Almost all the negative consequences related to the adoption of a single model – that of the Soviet type – both as regards the economy and particularly as regards the political system . . . and the obstacles put in the way of critical adaptation to changing times, to reforms and renewal. . . . We had hopes that the democratic forces in Poland, in the PUWP, in the Roman Catholic Church itself, would be able to assert themselves; this outcome was however not to be. . . . The crisis in the socialist societies of the East puts at stake détente, liberty, democracy. . . . In saying that the historical phase opened by the October Revolution in Russia is ended, we are not at all dismissing the value of achievements realized in that phase. On the other hand to dismiss everything to do with the October Revolution as a sort of original sin would be absurd. . . . Our vision of the world is not black and white, saints and demons, it is historical, it is a method of concrete analysis of reality with all its shades of difference. . . . We see in the countries of a socialist type a singular turning upside down of Marx's fundamental philosophical innovation: his critique of ideology. Above all, instead of reality and the creative transforming practice of what is new in action and in ideas, pride of place is given to ideology, a sort of ideological 'creed' which is what the so-called 'Marxism-Leninism' is, conceived as an ossified and quasi-metaphysical body of doctrine . . . unalterable in principle, it being the party's job to give it reality and to impose it.¹

It was precisely saints and demons, however, that were and had been leading actors on the stage of communist Poland. Saints were well entrenched on the Polish scene, a millennium of Polish Christianity having been celebrated in 1966 and Polish national identity later becom-

ing closely identified with the Catholic faith. Godless bolshevism wore a demonic aspect for most Poles from an early stage, and its Soviet-sponsored promotion to Stalinist sainthood after the Second World War did nothing to change this view. The religious underpinnings of the Solidarity movement formed a crucial part of its character and were far from diminished by its sponsorship of the first non-communist government in Eastern Europe during September 1989. Whatever their subsequent political and cultural differences, Prime Minister Mazowiecki and President (in his later guise) Wałęsa shared a firm commitment to Catholicism and religious values. While, too, an historical vision was not lacking it was often one that did not allow for shades of difference, retained strong elements of ideology (of various types) and was of a sort that could often blur the comprehension of contemporary realities rather than facilitate it.

Such contrasts and clashes of world-view were not unknown in other communist and post-communist countries. But the problems outlined by Berlinguer were especially strong in Poland and their implications marked for a variety of reasons. That the communist regime had weak foundations in Poland was evident at an early stage, and this had clear implications for the development of its political system and capacity for political evolution. Successive leaders had only a weak domestic base and were notably unsuccessful in formulating and following through their distinctive policies. Muddle-through and half-measures were a distinctive characteristic of Polish communist politics, and this did not facilitate the process of political evolution. It was associated among other things with the relative frequency and significance of leadership change during the communist period. The imposition of communist rule on Poland was likened by Stalin from the outset to the attempt to saddle a cow, and Stalinist repression was for this reason applied more cautiously and with somewhat more restraint in Poland than elsewhere.

This had certain benefits for Poland but also created problems for the consolidation and evolutionary capacity of the communist system there. Despite the notorious instability of communist leadership in Poland Soviet military intervention was restricted and the fate of Hungary in 1956 and that of Czechoslovakia in 1968 avoided. But there was also nothing like the 30-year-plus rule of Janos Kádár or the near-continuity of Stalinist rule by Novotný and normalized dictatorship by Husák. Poland saw a succession of party leaders whose arrival and departure were marked by political upheaval and the unprogrammed participation of popular forces in political life. The 33 years that followed the Polish October of 1956 thus saw four distinct leadership periods characterized by very different policies and styles of rule but all of which contributed, in

rather different ways, to the cumulative problems of political rule and – one of its most notable consequences – the relative decline of the Polish economy.

Evolution implies a capacity for change, the capability to devise reform measures and a commitment to carry them out. This, despite numerous promises and fresh starts in terms of policies and leadership approaches, communist Poland was particularly bad at doing. Władysław Gomułka returned to power in 1956 to the accompaniment of widespread hopes for various kinds of liberalization, democratic reform and economic change. Most of these aspirations were effectively dispelled by the end of 1957 and, at the time of his departure from office in 1970, Gomułka had become the typification of political conservatism and crabbed orthodoxy. His successor, Edward Gierek, assumed the leadership with similar declarations of intent and a commitment to political openness and reform. This approach, however, was soon shelved in favour of the resort to large-scale capital inflows as a means for sustaining growth and assuaging popular opinion.

Both periods saw the continuation of Poland's economic problems and avoidance of the reform measures that might have dealt with them. In consequence, workers in Poland during the 1960s received the lowest rise in earnings seen throughout Eastern Europe and, following the 1970–75 interval which saw the inflow of extensive foreign funds, the country had the lowest average annual growth rates in Eastern Europe throughout the period 1975–84.² The problematic establishment and development of the communist system in Poland was closely linked with its patchy reform record and inability to follow a clear evolutionary path. Political instability and persistent economic problems were, therefore, a characteristic of the communist period more marked in Poland than elsewhere, and they made their own distinct contribution to the troubled development of political life in the country. Economic indicators provide one of the clearest reflections of this record as well as indicating a specific source of political instability.

The Failure of the Economy

Economic policy in post-war Poland initially followed a pattern common to the other countries of Eastern Europe. After a relatively successful programme of post-war recovery the consolidation of communist rule was accompanied by the imposition of Soviet-style planning with excessive weight placed on high investment levels, heavy industrial development and military production. After Stalin's death in 1953 this emphasis was relaxed and wages began to rise again (averaging an annual increase

of 5.1 per cent between 1956 and 1960, having fallen by eight per cent in the early 1950s. But while peasant farmers were allowed to retain the land they had withdrawn from the collective farms and the emphasis placed on armaments and heavy industry was reduced, no programme of full-scale reform was adopted and the basic principles of central planning and administration of the economy remained in place. The consequences of this were rather more severe in Poland than elsewhere in Eastern Europe.

By the time of the 1966–70 period real wages in Poland were rising by only 1.9 per cent each year compared with a rate of over three per cent in most other East European countries. The replacement of Gomułka by Gierek as party leader in December 1970 had direct consequences for economic policy, and rapid economic growth was achieved in 1971 and 1972 with an even greater acceleration the following year, when the rise in national income was greater than at any time between 1950 and 1972. But signs of future problems were already evident. By 1972, in marked contrast to Gomułka's strategy, imports were already considerably higher than exports and this underwrote both the high rate of investment increase and the sharp rise in national income recorded. Increasing amounts of Western machinery were imported (from roughly \$100 million per annum in the late 1960s to \$1.9 billion (thousand million) in 1974) and the balance of payments deficit rose accordingly, from a minimal \$60 million in 1970 to \$2.05 billion in 1975.

By the end of 1975 Poland's total foreign debt had risen to \$6.352 billion and reached \$12 billion by the spring of 1977. This could not really be blamed on the disappearance of cheap energy supplies during the 1970s and the subsequent inflation and economic dislocation this caused, as the rapid uptake of foreign credits occurred in the early 1970s before the international recession took hold, and the Polish economy was in fact already in a precarious state by 1974. The spurt of growth thus ran out of impetus at an early stage and the consumer boom was clearly over by the middle of the decade. Gierek's attempts to gain control over economic processes and counteract growing disproportions were also unsuccessful. Proposed rises in food prices ran into worker opposition in 1976 and efforts made to restrain investment and the continuing growth of heavy industry made little headway against vested interests and strong ministerial lobbies. Agricultural production also slackened and the process of economic growth ground to a complete halt.

This led to a 2.3 per cent fall in national income in 1978. Worker incomes themselves fell the following year. The remedies imposed met with little success and the situation escalated out of control following an attempt in July 1980 to raise prices by the back door. This prompted a

sustained wave of strike action that led eventually to the formation of the Solidarity trade union and the collapse of the Gierek leadership. The period of Solidarity's legal existence, until December 1981, did not see any improvement in the economic situation although this was due not so much to the actions of the opposition or the activity of the free trade union but almost exclusively to the crisis of the command economy and the dependence it had developed on foreign inputs, which were increasingly difficult to obtain in conditions of growing indebtedness. National income continued to decline through the first year of military rule and it fell to a level 24 per cent lower than in 1978.

Some stabilization was achieved in 1983, but even the level of partial economic recovery seen then was not sustained in terms of national income growth during the succeeding years. By 1988 per capita national income was still some way off the level that prevailed ten years earlier, while 1989 saw further intensification of the economic crisis with declining production levels and galloping inflation. Signs of severe crisis were now clearly evident. Foreign debt had become an established sign of weakness which became progressively worse as the decade progressed. The level of hard-currency debt reached \$39 billion in 1987, with most of the increase since 1981 arising from Poland's inability to make interest repayments even though hard-currency exports had exceeded imports every year from 1982 to 1987. Polish debt was estimated to represent 279 per cent of the value of total exports in 1985 and 173 per cent in 1988. In relative terms Poland's trade position had weakened over successive decades. In 1987 Polish exports to the OECD countries made up only half the share they had taken in the early 1960s.³ A further symptom linked with this was the progressive decapitalization of Polish industry, partly because of the difficulty experienced in obtaining spare parts for the equipment imported from the West in the 1970s and partly because of the diversion of available funds to the consumer sector to avoid further decline in living standards. A third symptom of crisis was the growing deterioration of Poland's infrastructure and continuing underinvestment in transport, energy, water services, housing, health and education. By the late 1980s environmental damage was calculated to cost ten per cent of national income, matters not being helped by the increasing use of brown coal in Czechoslovakia and the GDR as well as in Poland, which made a significant contribution to the atmospheric presence of sulphur dioxide. Unusually for Europe and indicative of its archaic structure, in 1989 Poland still obtained four-fifths of its energy from coal, of which 82 per cent went for industrial use. During 1989 it became clear once more that persistent crisis was threatening the collapse of the economic system as a whole.

From May production in the state sector went into decline and during the first nine months of the year production was 1.6 per cent lower than in the same period of 1988; exports were down by 1.8 per cent and imports up by three per cent; average pay over the nine-month period was 177 per cent up on the previous year, with retail prices for goods and services up by 120 per cent. A shift in gear in the rate of increase in prices and wages took place from the beginning of August as the Rakowski government took measures to create a more balanced market and decided to set prices more in line with the availability of supplies. Prices of consumer goods and services thus rose by 44 per cent during the month of August and those of food products by 78 per cent, while wages increased by 67 per cent. But while food prices were raised and increased subsidies passed on to farmers, the cost of agricultural inputs rose even more, and the incoming Solidarity-led government found itself faced with spiralling inflation and increasingly insecure agricultural supplies, a combination that contributed to the aggravation of relations with peasant farmers over the coming year. This syndrome, threatening catastrophic economic decline, was brought under control only by the plan drawn up by Leszek Balcerowicz, finance minister in Mazowiecki's government and subsequently, and implemented from the beginning of 1990.

The Communist Party and Reform

This history of weak economic development, poor even in the general context of Eastern Europe, was closely linked with Poland's failure to cope with the demands of political change and the obstacles to political evolution experienced during the communist period. The hostile environment in which the PUWP operated produced formidable obstacles to the party's institutionalization and its political development – which, owing to its role as a central agency of communist rule, meant that the system as a whole had little capacity for development or evolution. The weak base of both the party and its leadership left the leaders with little room for manoeuvre, miscalculation or accident, encouraging caution in respect of both political and economic reform. Reform of the economy, it was increasingly recognized, was a matter of political decision and its prospects were critically dependent on extensive political change. But opportunities were limited by the weakness of orthodox party leadership and the further limitations placed on it by the conditions of military rule imposed in 1981.⁴

The weakness of central party leadership had led it from the early years to a strong dependence on the party apparatus, and this had major implications both for prospects of long-term political evolution and for its

capacity for economic management. Unlike Czechoslovakia, for example, the post-war Polish party had no established communist movement on which to base its rule and no pre-existing mass membership to act as a foundation for the post-war organization. Following the dissolution of the existing communist party by Stalin in 1938, the organization of the 1940s was a recent creation and its membership had grown from 1944 together with the Sovietization of the country. It had little authentic political identity and no real authority (as distinct from power) within Polish society. There was, according to one account of the origins of a regional organization, a permanent deficiency in terms of party *actif* and 'any member showing a certain degree of initiative was in general swiftly engaged for work in the party apparatus'.⁵ In the early days the situation was not so much one in which the apparatus dominated party life but rather one in which the party did not really have any political existence beyond the apparatus.

As tentative steps towards de-Stalinization were taken after the second party congress in March 1954, little progress away from this situation was seen within the local apparatus. There was scant support at local level for such moves. Attempts to return to 'Leninist norms', which meant less dictatorship and the introduction of collegiality in decision-making and political leadership, met with only 'partial success' in the view of the Central Committee Secretariat. While the new party line might have been followed in the provincial committees, it was largely ignored in local organizations.⁶ There was relatively little the central leadership could do about this, though. As developments accelerated during 1956, the picture that emerged was one of a strongly entrenched conservatism within the party apparatus that stood in growing contrast to the changing political mood in Poland as a whole. The provincial party apparatus, for example, was firmly in the hands of the neo-Stalinist Natolin faction, who were outmanoeuvred by their opponents in October 1956, so that after that date many remained anxious about the future – 'the lower-ranking party *apparatchiki* were especially fearful that Gomułka's regime would mean the end of their status and role in society'.

Changes within the top leadership, however, gave the green light to local *actif*-initiated changes in the provincial and local party organizations. In this process the party organization was considerably slimmed down and the changes persisted for some months, following the direction of regional leadership change that had taken place under the influence of the 'revisionists' who had come to the fore in the October developments. Certain 'corrections', however, were already being made in the new local leaderships before the end of 1956. By taking firm action against the revisionists, with whom he had been in apparent alliance in October,

Gomułka was able 'increasingly to make himself appear as the chief bulwark of the apparatus's interests', which had the further merit of undercutting the support of the neo-Stalinist faction in the party organization.⁷ One influential interpretation of these developments thus places considerable weight on apparatus conservatives being able to assert their interests on and through Gomułka and having the capacity to bring about the swift dissolution of all revisionist forces. Their victory was seen as being complete by the time of the third party congress (1959), which marked a shift in the balance of power away from the central authorities towards the apparatus and local organizations.⁸

The role of the apparatus was therefore considerably strengthened by these developments and the return to power of Gomułka who, while enjoying considerable support late in that year and early 1957 (largely for his ill-defined nationalist inclinations), had ambiguous relations with the central political groupings. Gomułka soon found himself in an uncertain alliance with the apparatus, which cut him off from the not inconsiderable level of popular support he had enjoyed in 1956. A further result of these manoeuvres was the virtual insulation of the apparatus from serious de-Stalinizing pressures exerted on it from above. While considerable turnover did occur between 1956 and 1958 it was those with revisionist tendencies who were most thoroughly purged. The apparatus emerged in a strong position with regard to the central leadership, a factor recognized and exploited by various political factions towards the end of the 1960s.

Having made use of such tensions in 1970, Edward Gierek introduced major changes in the structure of the party apparatus which prevented the continued development of alternative power-bases in the regions. While successful in this, however, his leadership did not increase the effectiveness of the apparatus's operation or its activities. Following the onset of another crisis of party leadership and authority, Central Committee Secretary Barcikowski was quick to direct attention to the apparatus: he observed in 1981 that the 'main source both of this crisis and of former crises has been the paralysis of intra-party democracy, of criticism and control from below, the deformation of cadres policy, and the system by which power is articulated'. The resistance of the apparatus to change and the restrictions it placed on central party leadership were a major theme of communist politics in Poland and a significant obstacle to the process of political evolution. This tendency was further reaffirmed by the proclamation of military rule in 1981 and its influence throughout the 1980s.

Poland was not alone in experiencing problems with the apparatus. It was also for the East German Bahro the 'uncontrollability of the Politburo and its apparatus' which presented the 'foremost political problem under actually existing socialism'.⁹ Much of the problem resided in the

tendency of the apparatus – particularly difficult to control in Poland owing to the absence of countervailing currents within the PUWP – towards bureaucratized political rule and routinized administration. Both of these tendencies were conducive neither to political change and evolution nor to tolerance of economic reform and the loosening of party-administrative controls over economic processes. The failure of communist party leadership and, particularly, the consequences of the administrative inclinations of the apparatus were most clearly seen in their inability to cope with the complex demands of a modern economy. An instructive light on the role and negative political influence of the party apparatus is cast by the proposal that the activities and function of the communist party-state are best understood not in the context of modern society but rather by analogy with the processes of seventeenth-century absolutism: aligning its key functions with those of the early-modern police force, preoccupied with issues of order and the detailed surveillance of virtually all forms of social activity.¹⁰

This analogy points to the profound anachronism of the Bolshevik party-state and the misalignment of the rationality it represented with the needs of modern society and, particularly, the demands of late twentieth-century economies (although the historic weakness of the modernization effort in Eastern Europe did give the communist project a temporary plausibility).¹¹ Furthermore, to the extent that the apparatus was the core of the communist party-state it represented the core of this unhistorical effort and encapsulated its basic contradiction with the tendencies and requirements of modern political evolution. This was, it must be stated, dimly perceived by Gierek and reflected in his attempted reforms of the apparatus during the 1970s. In opposition to the practice of local party officials to concern themselves with virtually any sphere of social and economic activity, under Gierek apparatus members were directed to act as political activists rather than party employees or functionaries in a general sense. However, this also tended to undermine the tenuous links they had with the local community and reduce still further the limited capacity they had to exercise authority in any sphere of society.¹² The overall forms of party rule, however, presented the leadership with little chance of effective development or political evolution in the Polish context.

Solidarity and Political Evolution beyond Communism

It was not until 1989 that this situation faced the prospect of significant change and Poland saw the possibility of developing political structures more appropriate to the processes of the modern state. As a result of

negotiations and a round-table agreement Solidarity was again legalized in April 1989 and joint decisions were reached about the reform of central political institutions. Solidarity and other independent groups were given the right to propose candidates for 35 per cent of the 460 seats in elections to the Polish parliament (Sejm) the remainder being reserved for candidates of the PUWP, two allied political parties and several official Catholic organizations. A new Senate was to be established made up of a 100 members, all of whom were to be freely elected, which would have the right to review and refer legislation back to the Sejm for further consideration. At the first round of elections held in June 1989 Solidarity-proposed candidates won 160 of the 161 seats available to them in the Sejm and 92 of the 100 Senate seats. A devastatingly low level of support for the ruling coalition was thus evident.

After run-off elections for unfilled seats were held, Solidarity-sponsored candidates had won all 161 (35 per cent of the Sejm seats open to them and 99 of the seats in the Senate). Solidarity also had an influence on the election of some of the official candidates who successfully contested the other unfilled seats. When it came to the election of the president, General Jaruzelski received only one vote more than the bare number needed to win, despite having arranged beforehand what appeared to be a comfortable official majority. The official candidate for the post of prime minister, General Kiszczak, also found it impossible to form a government and it fell to Tadeusz Mazowiecki, a noted Roman Catholic journalist and former editor of the Solidarity weekly, to form the first non-communist government in contemporary Eastern Europe. As originally formed in September 1989, Mazowiecki's government was made up of 23 ministers, 12 of whom were nominated by the Solidarity side and four of whom represented the PUWP. Two other official groups, the Peasant and Democratic parties, were also represented.

This was, broadly speaking, the parliament and government that steered Poland through the first phase of post-communism. But the fundamental changes achieved did not necessarily set the course for Poland's general reform and recovery. In view of the rate of political change during the first months of non-communist rule it should not be regarded as surprising that the 1989 Sejm and Mazowiecki government found themselves somewhat outpaced by the course of developments and often out of touch with the public mood. As the PUWP dissolved itself in early 1990, being succeeded by two much smaller parties with greatly reduced membership, the 65 per cent of Sejm deputies who received their seats through allegiance to the former communist coalition now found themselves neither representative of a public consistency nor the protégés of any real political establishment.

In the face of acute short- and long-term economic and political problems, Poland was also threatened by major instability from what appeared to be adverse social factors. Developments in contemporary Eastern Europe did not fit particularly well with established models that have aimed to chart the dynamics of political democratization or identify the sequence of events that bring democracies into existence. The collapse of the authoritarian communist regimes did not take place primarily under the pressure of internally generated forces, for example, and democratization received little impetus from agreements reached between conflicting domestic groups and national political compromise.¹³ Furthermore, how would it be possible, sociologists asked, to maintain social order and stabilize the restructured economy without a class of entrepreneurs or to consolidate parliamentary democracy in the absence of a middle class?¹⁴ Social conditions and the values of a population even in a country relatively advanced in the process of democratization did not seem particularly likely to favour the development and strengthening of groups traditionally associated with the formation of democratic institutions and pluralist structures.¹⁵ There was, in addition, extensive documentation of the weakness of Polish attachment to pluralist values.¹⁶

The economic policy of the Mazowiecki government might have been construed as a social and political programme to create a new middle class and lay the foundations of a Western-style parliamentary democracy, but it certainly could not be based on one already in existence.¹⁷ It was recognized, furthermore, that there was no indissoluble link between the adoption of these programmes of change and their realization: a failed attempt 'to implant market economics could set exaggerated extremes of wealth and poverty against the familiar background of economic decay. That would prepare the way for populist authoritarian governments of the traditional Latin American sort.'¹⁸ But the more pessimistic visions did not figure on the official agenda. The strong association between democratization and market economics that prevailed in Poland was in large measure a consequence of the political stalemate and economic stagnation of earlier years.

It may have been true, as Daniel Passent wrote well before the prospect of the Round Table talks of early 1989, that there was no direct link between democratization and economic recovery or reform in historical or theoretical terms – but lengthy experience suggested that effective economic reform would fail so long as political dictatorship was maintained, Leninist principles held sway, and central control of the economy persisted.¹⁹ These were essentially political obstacles that only democratization appeared likely to dislodge. As the pace of change quickened

in 1989, the principles of democracy and the market were fervently promoted by all groups, including those in opposition to one another. Nevertheless, currents of support for a solution combining planning with the principles of democracy could be identified, even if they were not voiced very loudly and remained part of an 'economic subconscious' rather than an ingredient of a formal programme.²⁰ Opinion polls established more ambivalence amongst Poles than among other Europeans about the virtues of capitalism.

Amongst the inhabitants of eight European countries surveyed in January 1990 Poles had the most positive response to the idea of capitalism and the lowest negative responses of all – but the latter observation was also associated with the fact that Poles produced the greatest number of 'Don't knows' in response to a question on the attractiveness of the idea of capitalism.²¹ The persistence of somewhat traditional collectivist values was accompanied by a vagueness in comprehension of the terms of the changing political situation. Sociological studies suggested a significant incompatibility between expectations of economic reform and political change.²² Poles' understanding of the concept of democracy appeared to have shifted considerably over the years and, somewhat unrealistically in terms of immediate prospects, came to be synonymous with material wealth rather than identified with a system of political institutions.²³

The abandonment of the ideals of marxist socialism seems to have been accompanied by the acceptance of an alternative utopia, but there was little serious public discussion of the major issues and myths, and confusion and misunderstanding were to the fore, 'frequently substituting for the analysis of social reality and substantive discussion of the future'.²⁴ Doubts were soon expressed about the authenticity, or at least the degree of development, of the market about which so much had come to be heard. It was pointed out at an early stage that, despite the newly prevailing rhetoric, no real market yet existed, that the newly founded companies monopolized by officials of the *nomenklatura* still formed a part of the state sector, and that the existing process of privatization had so far only taken the form of a 'political capitalism'.²⁵ A transitional situation was understood to have been established, in which the state had resigned its economic responsibility but still retained control over most of the property.²⁶ The forms of post-communist Poland were, quite understandably at that stage, by no means settled.

Prospects for Further Evolution

Investigation of the social foundations of post-communist development sheds further light on the outlook for institutional development, a critical

aspect of political evolution in post-communist Poland. A consistently sceptical view of Poland's democratization process was taken by Jacek Syski, who, even at the time of Mazowiecki's nomination as prime minister, noted the absence of mass enthusiasm at the prospect of democracy and the near-universal feelings of anxiety and insecurity in the face of future developments.²⁷ It was soon noted that organized opposition was absent from the parliament, while the social base of the Solidarity government camp and of the union itself was subject to increasing decomposition. Although coherent policy initiatives had not been lacking, there were few signs of progress in the formation of new political institutions, while substantive political and social content was absent from the deliberations of the new parliament. One major problem resided in the fact that both Solidarity and what remained of reformist groups linked with the former communist establishment appealed to what was essentially the same constituency derived from the social structure of post-Stalinist Poland.²⁸

Syski was far from alone in expressing doubts about the adequacy of the institutional framework for the course of democratization in Poland. Jadwiga Staniszkis saw the 'very arrangement of Poland's political stage' to be the major obstacle to any reasoned debate and emergence of a possible political solution to the range of conflicts that had recently been developing.²⁹ Senator Modzelewski regretted the lack of constructive opposition in the legislative body and the absence of alternatives to the government's economic programme.³⁰ Janusz Reykowski, a former Politburo member, somewhat ironically recalled that it was necessary to have a forum in which different perspectives could compete if an optimum programme were to be worked out and the government were to avoid errors in steering its way through the various dilemmas facing it: a democratic order needed to rest on democratic institutions rather than democratic phrases.³¹

Adam Michnik wondered in particular about the future form of Solidarity forces and asked whether democratic order or chaos would eventually prevail. He recognized that Solidarity could no longer remain in organizational terms just a trade union, and argued at an early stage for its development as a civic movement.³² Uncertainty about the organizational form of the Solidarity-based Citizen's Parliamentary Club persisted, and clear differences of opinion were expressed about whether it should retain its unity or break up into its constituent political groupings.³³ Equivalent disagreements and divisions could be identified in the left-wing grouping that had been based on the former United Workers' Party (that is, communists). Few of its deputies had joined the newly-formed Social Democracy, and the future of the group that had in 1989

been planned as the basis of a ruling majority looked even less well defined.³⁴ Others were more positive about the Polish situation, however. The political situation was, wrote Ernest Skalski, far from perfect – but its provisional political stability had allowed Poland to bring about ‘efficient economic change and take steps towards stabilization’.³⁵ Sociologists pointed out that there was still a high degree of public acceptance of market economy principles, although this was accompanied by a profound lack of understanding of what they meant (expressed, for example, in continuing demands for state control of prices).³⁶ This measure of confusion and uncertainty contributed to the volatility of institutional support and organizational stability. There were also signs that the atmosphere of public tolerance was changing. A general deterioration in the public mood was evident from polls taken in January 1990, the first month of the implementation of the economic recovery programme. Fewer believed that the political situation was positive, and opinions on the economic situation were also less positive.³⁷

Confidence in Solidarity fell from 74 to 60 per cent between January and March 1990, in the government from 82 to 71 per cent, and in the *Sejm* from 80 to 68 per cent, the greatest decline being recorded amongst farmers and better-educated white-collar workers.³⁸ In the month of March alone, the proportion of those who thought that the Balcerowicz plan would work fell from 55 to little more than 30 per cent. Processes of polarization associated with the strengthening of market forces could well lead, it was predicted, to the marginalization and degradation of one-third of the members of Polish society, and conditions were likely to become more favourable for the strengthening of attitudes and movements of an authoritarian, right-wing and anti-democratic character.³⁹ By the end of 1989, 40 per cent of the Polish population were already estimated to live on the brink of poverty and 20 per cent fell below the poverty line. The lack of concrete plans for a social safety net could thus be described as a glaring omission of the post-communist government’s economic programme, and this was rapidly becoming a focus of political conflict.⁴⁰

Prospects for industrial democracy and worker participation in management also declined as options for a ‘third way’ between socialism and capitalism diminished, and workers’ self-government was already stated by Balcerowicz and Industry Minister Syryjczyk to have served its purposes.⁴¹ During preparations for the local elections of May 1990, then, it was passivity that was declared to be the major political threat by Zdzisław Najder, appointed chairman of the Solidarity Citizens’ Committee in February: fewer than ten per cent of the population were active in party politics, he stated.⁴² Enthusiasm for the local elections held in

May 1990 was indeed shown to be limited and candidates proved to be difficult to find. As the public mood in Poland deteriorated and the leading political institutions lost some of the support they had enjoyed following the elections of 1989, the avenues of institutionalized participation remained limited and organizational prospects for post-communist evolution did not seem to improve.

The weakness of the new parties could be traced to a number of factors. These included:

- the dominance of symbolic representation: rather than representing interests, parties appealed to the collective memory of political traditions and the symbols of the past on which sentiment-based support could be mobilized;
- resentment-driven policy options: parties did not provide innovative solutions to current problems but tended to express negative responses;
- identification of scapegoats and the search for fall-guys: emotional and negative articulation led to the personalization of expression and further restricted the identification of policy alternatives;
- interests tended to remain unstructured for a combination of historical and topical reasons: trust (or lack of it) in symbolic figures remained dominant and structures indicating the formation of a civil society remained weak and uncertain.⁴³

As avenues of political participation remained restricted, members of the public hung back from fuller involvement in the political process. Nevertheless, although it was the Solidarity-sponsored candidates who had prevailed overwhelmingly in the 1989 elections, other political parties and groupings had been formed during the 1980s and some had survived years of unofficial or clandestine activity. As open parliamentary practices and political democracy became established an increasing number of parties came into existence: in November 1989 the press could identify 14 different political parties. In the absence of further parliamentary elections, however, the new parties were represented in the legislature only to the extent that existing deputies identified themselves with the new organizations. Although, when local elections were held on 27 May 1990, over 100 organizations and political groupings were reported to have taken part in the campaign, the results tended to confirm the existing constellation of political forces.

Candidates put forward by Solidarity and its civic committees took 43 per cent of 51,987 seats (48 per cent if the now autonomous Rural Solidarity was included), and a further 38 per cent were taken by

candidates who were independent or not affiliated to any particular party. In practice, it seemed to be the form of the social movement that continued to appeal to the Polish public rather than that of the formally constituted political party. Only the Polish Peasant Party took as many as 6.5 per cent of the seats and all others gained far fewer. Social Democracy, the reformed rump of the communist party, gained 0.2 per cent, right-wing groups 0.1 per cent, and the Independent Poland Confederation also 0.1 per cent of the available seats. The results of the local elections were in general, therefore, less than wholly encouraging in terms of institutional development. Rather than the 50 per cent or higher turnout suggested by opinion polls or the 60 per cent-plus predicted by the electoral commissioner, the final turnout was 42.3 per cent. (The turnout of less than half the electorate in the national elections of November 1991 appeared to confirm this trend.)

But the results did not signal any major upheaval, and, while no party had great cause for rejoicing, the result was less negative than many had feared. Turnout was lower than predicted, but that had been the case on most electoral occasions since the fiasco of the 1987 referendum. Solidarity received less support than it would have liked – but opposition parties proved even less attractive to the electorate and the forces surrounding Solidarity and the civic committees (whatever their contradictions and internal conflicts) showed themselves once more to be the leading political force in the country. Matters nevertheless were becoming increasingly complex within the Solidarity camp. In view of the political changes under way, the radical nature of the economic programme adopted by the new government and the severity of the consequences that it had for the working population and national economy, additional tensions were inevitable. A mass movement which at some stages had represented virtually an entire nation could hardly act both as government and as mass trade union under such conditions and retain its unity.

By late spring the political climate could be described as having grown heavier, and stormier conditions seemed to threaten.⁴⁴ But there was also considerable reluctance to accept splits in the movement and its division into a number of formally constituted political parties. Many within Solidarity had fought shy of transforming the movement into what was likely to be a diverse collection of political organizations, and the civic committees maintained their established form. There was, too, a resistance to the party domination of political life that had become strongly entrenched during the communist period. The citizens' committees set up in 1989 to organize the election of candidates remained in existence, therefore, but were not themselves subject to open scrutiny or public

control. There were also signs during 1990 of growing dissatisfaction with the Solidarity-sponsored government and its economic policies.

Railway workers and peasant farmers were the first groups to demonstrate their resistance actively, and both the established communist trade union organization OPZZ and a more militant offshoot of Solidarity joined in to support the workers. New tensions and sources of conflict were becoming evident in post-communist Poland. A critical factor here was the position of Solidarity, the status of its parliamentary group and citizens' committees, and its multiple role as a political force, as the main support of the Mazowiecki government, and as a trade union. A proposal to transform the Citizens' Parliamentary Club of Solidarity-sponsored deputies into a federation of different political orientations or associations had surfaced in February 1990. Doubts about the degree of Solidarity support for the government, particularly as expressed in the influential *Solidarity Weekly* (*Tygodnik Solidarność*), became more widespread, criticism of the more left-wing adherents of Solidarity (who were influential in the parliamentary group) grew stronger, and calls for Lech Wałęsa to make a bid for power to take over the presidency from General Jaruzelski became more strident.

Following Solidarity's second national congress in April and Wałęsa's re-election as chairman, his actions become more decisive, a notable act being the recalling of the respected parliamentary club chairman, Henryk Wujec, from his post on 1 June. Support was also withdrawn from Adam Michnik as editor of the daily *Election Gazette* (*Gazeta Wyborcza*), established in 1989 to inform and mobilize support for Solidarity candidates. The growing tensions and conflict slowly took on a more organized form. A 'Centre Coalition' was established in Gdańsk by Senator Jarosław Kaczyński, a close associate of Wałęsa, and during June a 'Citizens' Accord' was formed to provide an infrastructure to channel public support for the government. In July a Citizens' Movement for Democratic Action was founded (ROAD, following its Polish initials) with a view to encouraging the holding of new elections and mobilizing support for them. It took a stand against Wałęsa's recent pronouncements and expressed broad support for the Mazowiecki government. Divisions grew within the Citizens' Parliamentary Club, leading to the dissolution of its presidium in October (although the final split in the group did not occur until January 1991).

The Socioeconomic Context and Political Evolution

These developments took place against the background of major changes in the Polish economy. The Balcerowicz plan had considerable success in restraining inflation, achieving a surplus in foreign trade and significantly

raising foreign currency reserves. The social cost, however, was also severe as the average real wage fell and unemployment rose. The decline in production and the consequences for family budgets, moreover, were greater than envisaged, and the reduction in inflation (still 4.5 per cent during September 1990) was somewhat less dramatic than originally hoped for. In December 1990 industrial production (with the exception of the still relatively small private sector) was 24 per cent lower than the level of a year earlier. Growing unemployment (to a level of 1.089 million by the end of November 1990 and 1.370 million in April 1991) and a drop in real incomes produced major hardship for those affected, giving rise to dissatisfaction and sentiments of frustration that became more prominent in the political arena as the year progressed.

Such statistics, however, took little account of developments in the private sector, partly because an accurate picture of what was happening in largely uncontrolled sectors was impossible to obtain. Government estimates of the size of the private sector suggested, in fact, that it had grown by a half during 1990 and accounted for 18 per cent of national income by the end of the year. Private employment was estimated to have grown to between 1.8 and two million by that stage. Current employment levels, too, may have been exaggerated in a situation where previously, under the communist regime, no facilities existed for registering people as unemployed. Ministry estimates suggested that only half of those registered as unemployed at the end of 1990 had actually been laid off as casualties of the economic transformation. Further criticism, then, raised the question of whether any fundamental change was in train and whether the basic structures of the country's economy had been affected by the government's policy. Arguments in favour of the acceleration of change underlay Wałęsa's criticism of the Mazowiecki government and coloured much of the political debate from mid-1990.

The capacity of heavy industry to survive virtually intact under the new conditions raised serious doubts in this respect, and it was noted in October 1990 that, while employment in state industry had fallen by several per cent, labour productivity had dropped by over 20 per cent despite better supplies of energy and raw materials. There was a strong current of opinion that the initial phase of economic stabilization had not been followed through with policies of sufficient economic rigour directed to the pursuit of effective structural change. Despite official claims to the contrary, it was argued that greater emphasis had been placed on combatting the effects of recession and that practices of state intervention had been restored.⁴⁵ All these factors fed into the political situation of post-communist Poland and affected conditions for the stabilization and development of the new regime, tending in fact to

determine for most people the factors of greatest importance and the background against which political events and the emergence of political organizations occurred.

The movement for a more decisive confrontation between the different political currents had clearly grown stronger, and the occasion finally arrived with Jaruzelski's decision to resign from the presidency. The conflict between Wałęsa and Mazowiecki and their supporters understandably emerged as the immediate focus of the presidential campaign, but in the first round of elections Mazowiecki was defeated both by Wałęsa and by a somewhat mysterious Polish émigré, Stanisław Tymiński, who appeared to have some support from security forces and former communists. In December 1990, though, Lech Wałęsa was elected to the presidency by a decisive majority. In the new year he nominated as prime minister Jan Bielecki, a 39-year-old economist with a firm commitment to privatization and free enterprise. Jarosław Kaczyński, leader of the Centre Accord which had launched Wałęsa in his bid for the presidency and coordinated efforts to accelerate the pace of political developments, was named head of the presidential chancellery.

In January 1991 Bielecki presented his cabinet to the Sejm, where it was accepted by a decisive majority. Despite President Wałęsa's call for a significant acceleration of the pace of political change, the new government did not signal a radical departure from the orientation of Mazowiecki. A number of members of the former cabinet were retained, including Finance Minister Balcerowicz. His position was, indeed, enhanced, as he was now the sole deputy prime minister, and clearly held prime responsibility for the development of the Polish economy. Despite Wałęsa's earlier suggestions that workers needed protection from the rigours of economic transformation, the liberal, free-market wing of the government emerged stronger than before and it was in this direction that the mooted acceleration seemed most likely to occur.

The sources of political conflict had by no means disappeared, however, and the prospects of post-communist political evolution in Poland were significantly influenced by conditions of material deprivation, economic transformation and the instability of the social structure. Major tensions between president and parliament emerged. Having argued the need to hold parliamentary elections at the earliest opportunity, President Wałęsa in June 1991 vetoed electoral regulations proposed by the Sejm, although his veto was subsequently overridden by the requisite parliamentary majority. Pressures to extend religious instruction in state schools and make abortion a crime raised issues not only of public policy but also of Church-State relations and the nature of the new constitution that was being prepared. Moves were made within parliament in April

1991 to remove Bronisław Geremek from the chair of the Sejm Constitutional Committee. While the political evolution of the communist system had been critically constrained by lack of organizational flexibility and capacity for institutional change, post-communist development and the prospect of democratic evolution were dependent on extensive institutional development and the consolidation of constitutional arrangements.

NOTES

1. *After Poland* (Nottingham: Spokesman Books, 1982), pp.36–7.
2. Karen Dawisha, *Eastern Europe, Gorbachev and Reform* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988), p.135.
3. *Tygodnik Solidarność* (Warsaw), 22 Sept. 1989.
4. 'The Long Goodbye: Party Rule and Political Change in Poland since Martial Law', *Journal of Communist Studies*, Vol.6, No.1 (1990), pp.27–9.
5. W. Raczkowski, *Rozwój organizacyjny PZPR w regionie krakowskim w latach 1948–1959* (Warsaw: Państwowe Wydawnictwo Naukowe, 1981), pp.151–61.
6. Z. Kozik, *PZPR w latach 1954–1957* (Warsaw: Państwowe Wydawnictwo Naukowe, 1982), p.49.
7. Zbigniew K. Brzezinski, *The Soviet Bloc: Unity and Conflict* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1967), pp.255–64, 352.
8. W. Bieńkowski, *Socjologia klaszki* (Paris: Instytut Literacki, 1971), p.49.
9. Rudolf Bahro, *The Alternative in Eastern Europe* (London: New Left Books, 1978), p.246.
10. A. Horvath and A. Szakolczai, 'The Discourse of Civil Society and the Self-Elimination of the Party', in Paul G. Lewis (ed.), *Democracy and Civil Society in Eastern Europe* (London: Macmillan, 1991).
11. It was an aspect of life that struck party activist Adam Rayski on his return to Poland from France in the early 1950s: 'Man was degraded. The harshness of the everyday battle for life carried him back several centuries. ... An egocentrism which had nothing in common with the individualism of bourgeois society and was rent by the laws of competition dominated everyday relations': see his *Nos Illusions perdues* (Mesnil: Balland, 1985), p.240.
12. P. G. Lewis, *Political Authority and Party Secretaries in Poland, 1975–1986* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1989), pp. 63–5.
13. P. G. Lewis, 'Democratization in Eastern Europe', *Coexistence*, Vol. 27, No.2 (1990), p.254.
14. *Zycie Warszawy* (Warsaw), 22 Dec. 1989.
15. Zigmund Bauman, 'Poland: On Its Own', *Telos*, No.79 (1989), pp.55–7.
16. E. Morawska, 'On Barriers to Pluralism in Pluralist Poland', *Slavic Review*, Vol.47, No.4 (1988); Jane Curry, 'The Psychological Barriers to Reform in Poland', *Eastern European Politics and Societies*, Vol.2, No.3 (1988).
17. *Polityka* (Warsaw), 9 Dec. 1989.
18. *The Economist*, 28 April 1990.
19. 'Widmo demokracja', *Polityka*, 26 March 1988; also 11 June 1988.
20. L. Kolarska-Bobiński and A. Rychard, 'W którą stronę', *Tygodnik Solidarność*, 9 June 1989.
21. *Libération* (Paris), 19 Feb. 1990.
22. G. Ekiert, 'Democratization Processes in East Central Europe: A Theoretical Reconsideration', *British Journal of Political Science*, Vol.21, No.3 (1991), pp. 311–13.
23. 'The Human Face of Democracy', *The Warsaw Voice*, 24 Sept. 1989.

24. *Polityka*, 9 Dec. 1989.
25. *Tygodnik Solidarność*, 15 Sept. 1989.
26. *Rzeczpospolita*, 3–4 March 1990.
27. 'Gra w demokrację', *Polityka*, 26 Aug. 1989.
28. *Polityka*, 3 Dec. 1989.
29. *Tygodnik Solidarność*, 15 Dec. 1989.
30. *Rzeczpospolita*, 30 Jan. 1990.
31. 'Dylematy władzy', *Polityka*, 17 March 1990.
32. *Gazeta Wyborcza*, 6–8 Oct. 1989.
33. *Polityka*, 17 March 1990.
34. *Rzeczpospolita*, 12 March 1990.
35. *Tygodnik Powszechny*, 21 Jan. 1990.
36. *Polityka*, 24 Feb. 1990.
37. *Uncensored Poland*, 16 Feb. 1990.
38. *Polityka*, 31 March 1990.
39. *Polityka*, 9 Dec. 1989.
40. A. Brumberg, 'Poland: The Demise of Communism', *Foreign Affairs*, Vol.69, No.1 (1990), p.86.
41. *Polityka*, 3 March 1990.
42. *Rzeczpospolita*, 7 March 1990.
43. W. Lamentowicz, 'Political Culture and Institution-Building: Democratic Evolution at Work', in *Eastern Europe and Democracy: The Case of Poland* (Special Report for Institute for East–West Security Studies) (Boulder, CO: Westview 1990), p.13.
44. J. Syski, 'Realia demokracji: pożegnanie z mitem?', *Polityka*, 16 June 1990.
45. *Polityka*, 12 Jan. 1991.

China's Interrupted Evolution

SHAUN BRESLIN

Virtually the only consistent factor in Chinese politics since 1949 has been inconsistency. Leadership conflicts at the centre have been manifest in radical policy shifts that have affected the entire Chinese population at alarmingly regular intervals. When Deng Xiaoping took over the reins of power in 1978, there was great hope that China was entering a period of certainty and stability that would facilitate the long march to achieving the Four Modernizations – a policy of deliberately induced evolution. This has not been the case, however. Instead, the reforms implemented in the 1980s gave rise to a plethora of social and economic problems. Unable to dominate events, the party and state elites squabbled over the causes and potential remedies, while intellectuals and students rapidly lost patience with their leaders. The economic retrenchment policies of 1988 and the repression of the democracy movement in 1989 may have stabilized the situation in the short run, but much remains to be resolved before the CCP can face the twenty-first century with any certainty and confidence.

The evolution of communism has long been a key concern of the leaders of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP). The search for a distinctive 'Chinese Road to Socialism' has shaped the development of the PRC. In particular, the lack of consensus over the vision for the future and Mao's inability to accept that there could be more than one true road – his road – became a fundamental cause of intra-elite conflict.

Unlike in the Soviet Union under Stalin, Maoism never really had the chance to become embedded within the system. However, because Mao refused to accept that his ideas were flawed, the political, social and economic policies of Mao's opponents were also denied a clear run. As a result, a key characteristic of Chinese politics has been the continual and often radical changes in policy with a reversal occurring, on average, every four to five years. Certainly, between 1956 and 1976 the Chinese political system did not so much evolve as oscillate between different lines. The CCP ran into a crisis of development almost as soon as the initial reconstruction programme had been completed. With the accep-

Shaun Breslin is a lecturer in Chinese Politics at the University of Newcastle upon Tyne. He is author, with Rod Hague and Martin Harrop, of *Comparative Government and Politics: An Introduction* (third edition, 1992).

tance that continued reliance on the Soviet model was not appropriate for China, consensus on the way forward began to break down. Once Mao took the decision to push ahead with his plans for agricultural collectivization against the wishes of many of his colleagues, the pattern of conflict was set.

The intra-elite conflicts that characterized Chinese politics under Mao have often been explained in terms of a 'two-line struggle'. Such an approach was employed by some of the protagonists in the conflict as a way of justifying the extreme actions taken against opponents. There was a correct way and a wrong way, and if the correct path was not followed, then the counter-revolutionaries would usurp the revolution.¹ Had this occurred, then the defeat of the Maoist line by 1978 would have meant, in Francis Fukuyama's terms, the end of Chinese history. Subsequent events have shown that this was not the case.

Deng's ascendancy in 1978 did not mark a final victory for one line over the anti-Maoist line. It was a defeat for the Maoist path, but it was defeated by a broad alliance of groups and people who wanted to reform the system. Exactly how it should be reformed and the direction of its evolution were not a matter of unanimity. By 1985 Chen Yun (one of the key architects of the reforms in 1978) had become one of the fiercest and most vocal critics of the way the reforms were going.² This was a conflict not only over means, but also over ends: was China under the CCP still moving towards communism?

In the post-Mao era, the leadership has attempted to overcome the failures and shortcomings of previous policies, particularly those related to the excessive radicalism of the Cultural Revolution. Despite initial successes, by the autumn of 1988 China was faced with severe economic and political problems. The party leaders found that they could not control the scope and direction of developments, both political and economic, that they had set in motion. The policies implemented in an attempt to rectify past ills had generated their own problems – problems that the leadership were ill-equipped to deal with. The demonstrations in Tiananmen Square and in other towns and cities during the spring of 1989 were the most spectacular and widely reported manifestation of the popular pressure for change. However, on the economic front, there were clear signs that the leaders had lost control of the reforms before the protesters brought their grievances on to the streets of Beijing. Bank runs and panic buying had been the cause of great concern for China's leaders throughout the previous autumn.

Acrimonious debates on the solution to the emerging economic crisis had dominated the Beidaihe meeting of the party elite that preceded the third plenum in September 1988: Zhao Ziyang and Li Peng clashed over

economic policy with the result that Zhao's proposals for price reform were pushed into a back alley. Not for the first time in the PRC's history, it proved impossible to find compromise between competing views. Neither was Zhao's subsequent removal from power the first occasion on which the loser in the conflict also lost his job.

China since 1978 has faced the same fundamental problem faced by China before 1976; a lack of consensus regarding the way forward for the country has prevented the occurrence of a smooth evolutionary process. Conflicts have prevented policy changes from running their 'natural' course as refinements and changes are continually made to the reforms. The changes and disputes may not be as violent or radical as before (at least until the spring of 1989) but they remain the key obstacle to the development of the Chinese state. Furthermore, the reforms have brought with them serious side-effects in the form of new economic and social pressures. The party elite has found itself one step (at least) behind the rest of China – as witness both the size of the protest movement in 1989 and the way in which the party responded to the challenge.

Maoism: An Evolutionary Ideology and a Brake on Evolution

Even if Mao had been struck down as he climbed the steps of the Gate of Heavenly Peace on 1 October 1949, conflicts over the correct (or best) course of development would still have occurred. However, without Mao, the way in which those conflicts were aired would have been very different. There is much debate over the extent of the power that Mao held. Parris Chang argues that Mao was not in complete control after 1949.³ Oksenberg suggests that his power waxed and waned over the years.⁴ But as Teiwes argues, whether in power or temporarily forced to take a back seat, he could never be ignored by his colleagues.⁵ Whatever they did, they always had to take his views and reactions into consideration. Certainly, Mao did more than any other individual to prevent the smooth evolution of politics in China. In this sense, the period between 1949 and 1976 was very much a Mao-centric era.

Writers such as Simon Leys explain Mao's continual intervention into the political system in terms of his personal power ambitions – his megalomania.⁶ Such an approach plays down the impact of Mao's revolutionary goals to an unacceptable extent. Of course Mao wanted power, but not just for its own sake. He was utterly convinced that his vision of China's future was the correct vision, and this conviction had a profound impact on communist political evolution in China.

What exactly constituted Mao's version of Marxism is difficult to pin down. Any attempt to define Maoism or Mao Thought in simple terms

falls into the trap of neglecting or playing down the massive changes in his political thinking that resulted from his experiences in the revolutionary struggle. Stuart Schram has attempted to trace the evolution of Maoism by dividing the development of Mao's thought into six main phases.⁷ Although the process of defining terminal dates for such a periodization is fraught with difficulties, Schram demonstrates the fluidity of Mao's ideas over time. From Liberal to Leninist to Radical; from urban to rural-centred perspectives; from concern with taking power to concern with using that power – throughout these vicissitudes, Mao's attitudes and opinions were shaped by the historical experiences of the revolutionary process.

Mao's concern with applying Marxism to the actual conditions of China inevitably place him closer to Leninism (or rather Stalinist interpretations of Leninism) than to Marx himself. His 'Sinification of Marxism' could not and did not end at Yanan in 1942. Mao was forced to respond to the way in which he perceived others were taking the revolution – down a path that would not and could not result in achieving communism.

Furthermore, he had concrete evidence from other communist party states of the dangers of choosing the 'wrong' path. After all, communist political evolution in China was not hermetically sealed, and the example of the Soviet Union after Stalin had a profound impact on Mao. The deradicalization of the revolution not only could become a feature of post-revolutionary communist society but had done so: deradicalization of the revolution in the Soviet Union had a potent impact on Mao.⁸ Events in Hungary and Poland in 1956 further contributed to Mao's understanding of the potential problems for the party – most clearly in terms of the party's relations with the masses, and the dangers (as Mao saw them) of individuals or groups within the party attempting to usurp the revolution and put it on a road towards 'capitalist restoration'.

Having spent much time and energy on the problems of winning power in China, the CCP's victory in 1949 inevitably required a change in the style and content of politics. Harold Lasswell suggests that a successful revolutionary movement requires two distinct and different types of leaders: agitators to lead the revolutionary struggle, and administrators to organize the post-revolutionary society.⁹ The skills that are needed to wage a successful revolutionary struggle are no longer required once the revolution is won, and a leader successful in seizing power lacks the necessary skills to be an effective leader in the post-revolutionary society. This dichotomy between agitators and administrators draws too sharp a distinction, since individuals can have more than one string to their revolutionary bow. Nevertheless, it highlights an important factor in the development of communism: the evolution from a revolutionary party

attempting to seize power to a government charged with exercising power. Of all the great non-anarchist revolutionaries, only Che Guevara seemed happy to confine his activities to revolutionary struggles rather than post-revolutionary administration.

For Mao, this dichotomy was anathema. Whether or not he had the skills required to 'administer' is beside the point. The revolution should not, he believed, simply fall into a routinized existence: the revolutionary zeal had to be continued. Faced with the spectre of the deradicalization of the revolution (or its bureaucratization) in the Soviet Union, Mao moved to prevent a similar process occurring in China. Unable to push his ideas through the established process of policy formulation, Mao was prepared to by-pass the system, which he did with spectacular results in the launching of both the High Tide of Agricultural Collectivization and the Cultural Revolution.

Maoism, as it emerged after 1956, simultaneously was an evolutionary ideology itself and was intended to act as a brake on evolution. The typical Maoist explanation for the path of the revolution was based on an over-simplified 'two-line struggle'. The revolution could evolve along one of two lines: either the correct line towards socialism, or the wrong road towards capitalist restoration. That there could be more than one road to socialism in China was not recognized by Mao: things were done either his way or the wrong way. Therefore, Mao's interventions prevented evolution towards what he perceived to be dangerous and wrong paths. However, the problems caused by his radical initiatives meant that Mao's own campaigns were forced into retreat. The result was two decades of policy vacillation: the High-Tide and the Great Leap Forward gave way to stabilization and reconstruction under the tutelage of Liu Shaoqi and Deng Xiaoping; however, this phase was brought to an abrupt end with Mao's launching of the Cultural Revolution, which in itself contained cycles of radicalism and retrenchment; this in turn gave way to the political impasse or balancing act between competing groups that characterized Chinese politics in the mid-1970s.

When in the ascendancy, Mao's opponents were faced with clearing up the problems of the immediate past before they could attempt to move forwards. However, it proved difficult for them to get much further than the process of recovery and rebuilding. For example, after getting the country back on its feet after the disasters of the Great Leap Forward,¹⁰ the leadership of Liu and Deng was ousted from power by the Cultural Revolution. An example of this process is the way in which Chen Yun's economic principles have been returned to time and time again to solve the pressing problems of the day. His 1956 plans for economic development were revived at the ninth plenum of the eighth Central Committee

in 1961; again (briefly) in 1971; and then again by the reformist leadership after Mao's death.

In many ways, the conflicts over development that began in 1956 were not to be resolved until after the death of Mao. Robert Ash has noted that despite the different political climates of 1961 and 1978, many of the initial reforms were not new, but a continuation of the ideas put forward in 1956 and carried out during the readjustment period after the failure of the Great Leap:

It is certainly no coincidence that one of the earliest decisions of the Third Plenum was to endorse a revised version of the 1961 'Regulations on the Work of People's Communes' – the very document which epitomised the pragmatism of agricultural policy in the early 1960s.¹¹

The year 1956 was also taken as the benchmark for all that was 'good' about CCP rule in the ideological sphere. The 1981 Resolution on Party History defined Mao Zedong Thought not as what Mao Zedong thought, but instead as a body of Thought 'which came into being through the collective struggle of the party'.¹² Mao Zedong Thought was epitomized by the 'correct' policies of the Second Five Year Plan adopted at the eighth party congress of September 1956. When Mao launched the High Tide of Agricultural Collectivization over the heads of his colleagues, he negated the principle of collective leadership. As a result, the post-1978 leadership managed to contrive a version of history in which Mao Zedong abrogated Mao Zedong Thought.

The resolution asserted that the policies of the eighth party congress of 1956 were 'correct, and charted the path for the development of the cause of socialism and for Party building'.¹³ Although the Gang of Four took much of the blame for the excesses of the Cultural Revolution, 'Chief responsibility for the grave "left" error of the "cultural revolution" ... does indeed lie with Comrade Mao Zedong.'¹⁴ Great care was taken to ensure that the overall verdict on Mao stressed his achievements. The resolution was, after all, part of the process of rebuilding the party's legitimacy, so it was necessary to emphasize that the CCP had brought great benefits to the Chinese people. However, it was made clear that had it not been for Mao's interventions, greater progress would have been made.

Although many old policies were revived after 1978, changes did take place between 1956 and 1976. The Maoist system evolved in response to events in the rest of the world, and in response to the relative strength and position of its opponents. Similarly, the anti-Maoist system also evolved in response to the same imperatives. Thus, different approaches to

China's future were evolving not only as circumstances changed, but also in response to each other. The competing policy strategies were often forced to evolve 'in opposition' – both in the sense of the proponents not holding the reins of power, and in the sense that the main priority was often opposing the policies and power bases of rivals.

Post-Mao Evolution

As China entered the final decade of the twentieth century, not for the first time since 1949 (indeed not for the first time since 1976) it found itself at a crossroads. The future direction of the reform process and indeed the future of the CCP itself was far from clear. In essence, the fundamental problem that faced China in the 1980s was the same that caused the instability before 1976: there was a lack of consensus within the party elite. There was a broad and general agreement over what should be left behind, but even then, some leaders were keener than others to retain some of the features of the old society. On the question of the way forward, the areas of agreement were even less clearly defined.

As the 1980s progressed, new areas of conflict emerged. Not only was there a lack of consensus over the means, but increasingly questions were raised over the end: were the reforms taking China towards communism? To compound these intra-elite conflicts, the party leadership found itself out of step with the social changes that the reforms had unleashed. Unable or unwilling (or both) to respond to popular pressure for further change, in 1989 the leadership turned to force and repression to restore a façade of stability.

An overview of China's development since 1978 demonstrates that the policy changes that characterized the pre-1976 period did not die with Mao Zedong. The reversals may not have been as dramatic or cataclysmic as the launching of the Great Leap Forward or the Cultural Revolution; neither did they stop developments in their tracks in the same way as Mao's radical adventures had done. Nevertheless, they have prevented the economic and political systems evolving along a smooth path.

One of the features of Chinese politics is that consensus can usually only be defined in negative and not positive terms:¹⁵ that is, leaders agree on what they are rejecting, but cannot find agreement on what should replace it. Thus, from around 1954, there was agreement that the Soviet model should be replaced, and in 1978 agreement that the Maoist model of development (including Hua Guofeng's variation on the theme) should be replaced. However, in both cases, it soon became apparent that there was no consensus over the correct way forward. The leadership conflicts of the 1980s demonstrate the inadequacy of the 'two-line

struggle' model for explaining pre-1976 political conflicts. Differences between the strategies of leading 'opposition' figures such as Chen Yun and Liu Shaoqi have often been played down or ignored. The main source of identity was those who opposed Mao: for Mao, if you were not for him, then you were against him. This view helped to shape the view of many foreign commentators, and – presumably for reasons of self-survival – had some impact on shaping the formation of alliances within the Chinese elite. The force and intensity of this struggle against Mao was such that the people who opposed him for a variety of reasons became lumped together as a group.

What has become clear in the 1980s is the extent of divisions within the reformers themselves. Chen Yun and Yao Yilin were both hailed as reformers during the early phase of reform, but by the end of the 1980s both were being characterized as 'arch-conservatives'. This in no way implies that what they want to conserve is the old Maoist system: indeed, Chen Yun spent a large part of his political career opposing Mao's policies. Rather, they are more conservative than others: they disapprove of the pace, scope and direction of the reforms. Policy has evolved and left the likes of Chen Yun and Yao Yilin behind. Not for the first time, Chen's policies were adopted for the process of recovery and rebuilding; this time, however, once recovery was complete there was not a radical shift back to Maoist policies, but a move forward.

What occurred in 1978 was not the victory of one side over another, but the rejection of one of many competing views. The anti-Mao consensus of 1956 has now had the chance to proceed free from the constraint of Maoist interventions. In the process of this development, distinct differences in policy and strategy have emerged. As a result, the post-Mao political system has, like the pre-1976 era, been characterized by elite conflict and policy vacillations. Economic reforms stuttered and underwent periods of retraction and retrenchment in 1981–82, in 1985, and again after the third plenum of the thirteenth Central Committee in the autumn of 1988. Furthermore, periodic campaigns against creeping bourgeois liberalization and spiritual pollution have been a feature of Chinese politics in the 1980s.

Policies of readjustment and retrenchment and ideological campaigns aimed at dealing with specific and immediate concerns may have an impact in the short run, but rarely (if ever) solve the problem once and for all. Furthermore, the remedies implemented to solve specific problems have often had unforeseen side-effects: they spawn their own problems which then have to be remedied. At times, Chinese political evolution in the 1980s gave the impression of a system that was based on short-term expediency and reactions rather than following any clear path towards

development. As Barry Naughton commented in 1985: 'Unable to dominate events, the government has had to scramble to "put out fires" and prevent disastrous outcomes.'¹⁶

The key phrase in Naughton's analysis is 'unable to dominate events'. This is as true of the political and social sphere as it is of the economy: the elites have simply not been able to control the social and economic forces that they have unleashed. To a large extent, the initiative for change has passed out of the hands of the central elite, and instead they are forced to react and respond to pressure for change from below. This environment provides ample opportunity for those in the party who oppose either specific policies or even the wider orientation of policy to challenge the direction of change. At the heart of the system there are a number of fundamental areas of disagreement which are reflected in the composition of the party's leading organs. Oksenberg referred to the leadership elected at the thirteenth party congress as 'a political balancing act': a leadership that balances out the various conflicts that exist within the elite.¹⁷ He outlines three underlying areas of conflict:

- (1) Economic reforms: how fast and how far should they go? Should prices be further deregulated and the market expanded or not? Have the reforms gone too far, or not far enough?
- (2) Political reforms: what is the relationship between economic and political reform? Is political reform necessary for any further reform?
- (3) Opening to the outside world: what are the risks, and are they worth encountering?¹⁸

John Burns notes that in addition to these disputes at the very top of the system, the reforms have generated conflicts throughout the party-state administrative machinery: centre-local disputes, regional tensions (that is, locality-locality disputes), and bureaucratic disputes.¹⁹

That there are conflicts amongst the elite is not open to question. How the elite breaks down into coherent and identifiable groups is much less clear. However, the popular attempt by the Western mass media to split the elite into two neat and distinct groupings of 'conservatives' and 'reformers' does not facilitate an understanding of Chinese politics.

If one of the characteristics of Chinese politics in the 1980s was the lack of consensus, then one of the characteristics of China-watchers during this period has been the attempt to place some clarity on this situation. Dittmer suggests that after 1982, the Chinese leadership can be roughly divided into three groups: palaeo-Maoist conservatives, moderate descendants of the Liu Shaoqi-Deng Xiaoping policies of the early 1960s, and radical reformers who want sweeping modernization and privatiza-

tion.²⁰ Hamrin has attempted to delineate the various policy packages presented by competing groups,²¹ while Bachman has similarly analysed the different economic ideas and strategies of Chen Yun, Deng Xiaoping and Zhao Ziyang.²² In a later study, Bachman tentatively identifies no fewer than seven 'varieties of Chinese conservatism', Deng Xiaoping's role being to prevent those who hold these views from coalescing into a unified and coherent movement of opposition to the reforms.²³

While identifying policy packages may be relatively easy, discerning those who adhere to the packages is definitely not. Indeed, the search to find distinct groupings may be a self-defeating objective. The evidence of the pre-1976 period shows that the same people did not unite on every issue. Domes argues that after the Cultural Revolution, the Chinese political system moved from factionalization (where the leadership is divided on various issues but no coherent and stable group formations exist) to factionalism (where stable groups do form and push a common platform).²⁴ While this may have been true during the period of the succession struggle – both before and after Mao's death – this system broke down after the initial power struggle had been completed. It is difficult to identify groups or factions, precisely because those groups do not exist. It is a fluid situation in which people do not necessarily join together along the same lines on every policy issue. Definable groups may well form during the scramble to succeed Deng Xiaoping. However, there is no reason to expect that these groups will remain intact and unified once the struggle is won.

The broad consensus of the 'reformers' was only based on a number of general and essential aims. Over a fairly long period, leadership changes at both the central and provincial levels removed the majority of the remnants of the Cultural Revolution. Once the common enemy was removed, then the glue that bound the 'reformers' together dissolved, and the points that divided the leaders emerged. It is important to note that, as Gordon White says, 'In spite of the plethora of policies, there appears to have been no overall programme which mapped out in advance the scope, pace and phasing of policy implementation'.²⁵ There are perhaps two main reasons for this lack of a clear policy line for the reform process. First, policy-making for the most part has been reactive: unable to dominate events, the party elite has found that the pace of change has often been forced from below rather than dictated from above.

In his analysis of agricultural policy in the first decade of reform, Robert Ash paints a picture of a leadership that was somewhat swept along by the tide of events that it had unleashed (not unlike the process of collectivization and communization in the 1950s). He concludes:

There is an evolutionary logic that runs through both stages [December 1978–1985 and 1985–88]. Frequently, however, it appears to have been born of necessity and shaped by the inexorability of developments in the countryside. As often as not, the planners have followed events rather than anticipated them.²⁶

Secondly, to come out with a clear line can be politically dangerous and lead to instability within the elite. A definitive policy statement would run the risk of providing something around which opposition groups could coalesce. If consensus is generally based on negative points of common interest, and for the most part conservative groupings are fluid and not rigid, then the dangers can be seen. It would be extremely difficult for any outline of future plans not to have something in it that virtually every group could oppose.

If the leadership coalition is to be kept relatively intact, the alternative is to resort to general and vague hopes and aspirations. In essence this is what espousal of the Four Modernizations is. Referring to achieving the Four Modernizations is a useful tool for the party elites, as it means different things to different people. All agree that they want modernization, but exactly how this should be achieved was never really explicitly stated.

The combination of these two factors has resulted in a situation in which policy has often been made on the hoof. Virtually any problem that has emerged in the process of reform has been seized upon by conservative elements to restrict the pace and scope of change. In order to prevent the criticisms becoming too vociferous, the reformists respond by addressing specific problems pinpointed by opponents. For reasons of maintaining the stability of the wide coalition of interests and ideas in the leadership, therefore, policies have not been allowed to follow their 'natural' course. Thus, long-term evolution has been interrupted by short-term political elite considerations. After successfully completing the early stages of agricultural reform, You Ji argues that in 1984 the conditions were ripe for a thorough reform of the pricing system. Yet Zhao Ziyang and Tian Jiyun declined to take the risk for fear of antagonizing important sections of the leadership. Instead, they went for a less politically sensitive policy of decentralizing administrative controls to local administrative units: 'While the choice, at the time, of a less controversial reform probably reduced the resistance from the conservatives, it also led the reform to a near impasse, the impact of which is strongly felt today [January 1991].'²⁷

Not only was the decision to decentralize shaped by the potential opposition to the reform process, but it can also be seen as a way of

undermining the power of those opponents. By taking powers away from the central planning authorities where opposition was perceived to lie, the potential for those more conservative elements to impose control was diminished. Unfortunately, in removing this obstacle the reformers created new, perhaps even greater, problems for themselves.

The decentralization of power to lower level administrative units has had a crucial impact on the way in which the reform process has proceeded. It has itself created great problems for the reforms that have had to be addressed. The implications of decentralization without the introduction of the necessary mechanisms to enforce control were either not thought through, or deemed to be a necessary evil in the process of creating a reform dynamic.

But by the summer of 1988, it was clear that the central authorities believed that the loss of central control was a factor that had to be addressed.²⁸ Many of the economic retrenchment policies that emerged after the third plenum of the thirteenth Central Committee (September 1988) were aimed at pulling back the powers of the provinces. The fact that one of the central concerns of the protracted debates that surrounded the formulation of the Eighth Five Year Plan was how to overcome the problems created by the semi-autonomous policies of some of the provinces (most notably Guangdong) shows that it remains an important problem. It also demonstrates just how difficult it is for the central authorities to reverse policy and take back powers that have been given away.

Quite simply, the party planners lost control of the economy. The changes that they set in motion gained a dynamic and momentum that proved extremely difficult to control. When the economy became so overheated in the autumn of 1988 that something had to be done, the chosen remedy demonstrated an almost complete failure to address the underlying problems. The retrenchment policies took the heat out of the economy in the short run, but in themselves could not possibly hope to provide a long-term solution. A World Bank study in 1990 noted:

The reform program is, at heart, an attempt to correct the mistakes of the old central planning system ... The program adopted at the Fifth Plenum suggests that the problems that have emerged during the course of reform can now be solved by the very same mechanisms ... responsible for the distortions that the reforms were designed to correct.²⁹

Faced with a loss of control over the economy, Li Peng and his colleagues resorted in the only way they knew: they returned to tried (but not trusted) policies from the past, a remedy that had no hope of curing

the patient. The retrenchment policies may be successful in the short run in damping demand and reducing inflation, but the underlying problems remain.

Although these policies may be acceptable in the short run, they should not be kept in place for too long. The danger is that short-term security and success will blunt the desire to make the fundamental changes that are needed to rectify the underlying problems. The longer the stabilization policies are kept in place, the greater will be the problems when they are removed.

For example, at the present time, every day that price controls are kept on goods, the difference between the state-controlled price and the free market price increases. If the leaders eventually decide to push ahead with price reform, the required price adjustment will be much greater than in the past. The way to get round this is to raise the state-controlled prices – an exercise that in the past has led to bank runs, stockpiling and panic buying, not to mention the inflationary pressures that the set prices are intended to help eliminate.

Similar trends and responses are also evident in the social and political spheres. Goodman argues that Deng Xiaoping's aim has always been to promote reforms that would expand the productive forces of the economy whilst restricting political freedoms and maintaining the party's dominance in society.³⁰ But as all good Marxists know, economics determines politics. Many of the changes introduced in the 1980s aimed at promoting economic reform have unleashed powerful pressures for change.

The Chinese have a keen sense and knowledge of their own history, and one does not have to go too far back in time to find pertinent examples and warnings for the party leadership. In the final years of the imperial system, the Qing government sent many of the nation's bright young prospects to study abroad, but this policy, aimed at strengthening an ailing political system, ultimately proved to be counterproductive as the young intellectuals gained access to new ideas and political creeds that proved much more appealing than the traditional Chinese imperial system. It is notable that Sun Yatsen's revolutionary ideals found fertile ground among Chinese studying abroad – indeed, the Revolutionary Alliance was established in exile in Japan.

It is too simple to say that the party's economic reforms created the bourgeois liberalization and spiritual pollution that the party is so fearful of. Desires for greater personal and political freedoms did not arise from nowhere in the 1980s: such demands were aired during the Hundred Flowers campaign in 1957 and during the Democracy Wall Movement of 1978. But what the reforms of the 1980s have done is increase both the

access to the West (and Western ideas) and the aspirations of the population.

In order to facilitate economic development, the CCP leadership has undertaken a re-evaluation of the West. This process began in the 1970s with the move towards rapprochement with the United States. From being the greatest threat to the Chinese people in the 1950s, by the start of the 1970s America was well on the way to becoming China's key ally in resisting the threat of the Soviet Union. But in the 1980s, this reappraisal moved on to a new phase. The West is no longer perceived simply as being a potential strategic ally – in fact, with developments in Sino-Soviet relations during the decade, the importance of the United States as a strategic ally has declined. As China strives to develop a modern economic system, Western economic forms and practices have become an appealing model. Foreign companies have been encouraged to invest in China, initially in the Special Economic Zones, but later throughout China; Western businessmen have been brought in to increase efficiency in Chinese firms; and the market system has grown in scope and importance, as witnessed by the opening of a stock market in Shanghai. From being told that the West is bad, the Chinese people are now being told that the West is good – or more correctly, certain aspects of the West's economic practice are good and should be copied, but the political orientation of the West is still bad. Unfortunately for the Chinese elite, it has proved very difficult to determine just how far admiration for the West should go.

Furthermore, after the death of Mao, the CCP moved away from a position of seeking ideological legitimacy, towards an increased emphasis on economic legitimacy. The two are not mutually exclusive, and the transition was not absolute, merely a question of degree. However, there can be little doubt that the post-Mao leadership recognized that the Maoist emphasis on mass political campaigns (and, in particular, the Cultural Revolution) had damaged their prestige. In an attempt to regain lost legitimacy, the CCP committed itself to putting its house in order. In short, the arbitrary government of the past was to be replaced by institutionalized government. There would be a clear separation of powers, and the strengthening of legal forms and collective decision-making was to replace the domination of politics by one man.

At the same time, promises of future economic rewards were made. The Chinese press was full of stories of rich peasants – 10,000-yuan households – who had prospered under the reforms. To grow rich was now a glorious aspiration, and it was the party's correct leadership that was going to create the right conditions for future individual wealth.

Having promised a period of political certainty and reliability and a

vastly improved economic environment, the party elite failed to come up with the goods. For many students and intellectuals, the political campaigns of the 1980s were evidence that the locus of power had not been fundamentally altered. Power remained in the hands of a few, and – as the ousting of Hu Yaobang showed – collective leadership counted for nothing when the pressure was on.

Furthermore, many students perceived that they had not reaped the benefits of the reforms they had been promised. 'Wide-boys' were making a killing acting on (and beyond) the fringes of legality, and party and state officials were corruptly using their power and influence to line their own pockets. But the students were living six and seven to a room, the quality of the food in the canteens was poor, and the prospects of a well-paid job were limited to the select few. The majority faced a job with a fixed salary, and the impact of inflation on their potential purchasing power was a further contributory factor to feelings of discontent.

As Tocqueville noted, the most dangerous time for an oppressive ruler is to embark on reform and hold out the prospect of improvement.³¹ Grievances patiently endured become intolerable once the possibility of a brighter future crosses the population's minds. The most hazardous time is when a period of rising expectations is followed by a decline in the regime's ability to meet those demands. This tension is intensified if the government has attempted to gain legitimacy by making promises of future well-being that it finds it cannot keep.

Davies utilized these ideas in his 'J-curve' theory of the role of relative deprivation in creating revolutionary tendencies in societies: 'revolutions are most likely to occur when a prolonged period of economic and social development is followed by a short period of sharp reversal'.³² This concept provides a useful approach to explaining the popular discontent with the party leadership that led to the Tiananmen demonstrations of 1989. The hope and good will towards the party elites that had been evident at the start of the 1980s had dissipated by the beginning of 1989. On virtually all fronts, students and intellectuals felt that insufficient progress had been made. The party had been given a chance to reform itself from within. It failed, and the time came for the students and intellectuals to force the issue: in the spring of 1989, therefore, the party leadership found itself in the middle of a crisis of its own making. With the resolution of the power struggle within the party elite, the military was used to clear the demonstrators from Tiananmen Square with the now well-documented consequences.

As with economic policy, the leadership resorted to old policies to try to rectify the problem.³³ As a result, dissent has been silenced in the short run, but the causes of the discontent will not simply go away. Policies

have been implemented to deal with specific problems: for example, work teams have been dispatched across the country to try to check the corrupt practices of officials. However, many of the fundamental concerns of the protesters remain – only now the discontent has been sharpened by the way the demonstrators were cleared from Tiananmen Square.

Sun Suyi has argued that the impact of the 1989 Tiananmen incident has been exaggerated in the West. He argues that 'A dissident movement lacking popular support cannot easily develop on a large scale or last very long.' In Sun's view, the majority of the population desire political stability in order to promote economic development, and this factor will work in the party elite's favour: the majority would prefer to see the party 'grow and improve' rather than face the instability and chaos that would follow the party's overthrow.³⁴ While it is undoubtedly true that the demonstrators constituted a tiny proportion of the entire Chinese population, the young urban intellectuals constitute an important and influential sector of society. The party's policies in the 1980s have created new pressures and challenges from society, but so far its leaders have proved unable or unwilling (or both) to respond effectively to the challenge.

The transition to communism remains central to the party's claims on legitimacy. Mao may have spun in his mausoleum on the publication of Deng Xiaoping's and Zhao Ziyang's theoretical works on the future of the revolution, but they all shared a common concern: Deng's 'Building Socialism with Chinese Characteristics' and Zhao's 'Primary Stage of Socialism' can be seen as continuations of the process of 'sinifying' Marxism. The struggle to adapt the works of Marx and Lenin to the actual circumstances of China has been a continuing process.

However, this view is not shared by all – and importantly, not shared by all in China's political elite. Post-Mao China has seen a number of reforms that do not immediately appear to be moving China towards the communist utopia. Although the ultimate goal remains stated, it has been pushed back into a distant future so that immediate concerns can be dealt with here and now.

At the onset of the Great Leap Forward, Mao talked of overtaking Great Britain within 15 years – the transition to communism was an achievable target that was just around the corner. Hua Guofeng later set the year 2000 as the target for modernization. By 1987, Zhao Ziyang in his Primary Stage of Socialism thesis was suggesting that the initial stage of modernization would not be completed until 2050.³⁵

For Zhao, developing the economy was a prerequisite for any further evolution towards communism in the long run. It was not only permissible but necessary for a socialist society to concentrate on the immediate

aims of developing the economy. Anything that helped expand the productive forces was therefore a legitimate policy in terms of ultimately leading towards communism. Thus, private and even foreign ownership of the means of production became legitimate in his eyes. However, this vision or expediency is not shared by all in China's elite.

China faces the future without any certainty about what that future should be, let alone what it will be. Michael Swaine has identified two conflicting views of the future. On the one hand there is the totalitarian revival paradigm which suggests a return towards old style monolithic party control. On the other is the irresistible reform paradigm which argues that the current system is merely marking time awaiting the death of Deng Xiaoping after which the events of the last few years will be seen as an interregnum in the inevitable reform of the old planned system.³⁶ To go back at this stage would appear to be an impossible scenario. Standing still may be an appealing short-term option, but will create its own problems in the future. Perhaps the main cause of the economic problems that beset China in the late 1980s was the halfway-house economy. In particular, the coexistence of state-set and market-determined prices (for the same goods as well as for different goods) has created much of the distortion in the economy.³⁷ In particular the lagging behind of price reform for energy, transport, basic materials and so on has severely distorted the whole price and costing procedure in China.

The logical evolution of the reform process to date seems to have created a situation where market forces will continue to be further introduced, and makes a full-scale price reform inevitable. Delaying the process only makes the transition when it comes even more dangerous in terms of the impact that it will have on price rises and inflation. The longer the current impasse continues, the more difficult will be the transition when it eventually occurs.

Conclusions

In 1986, writing on the impact of policy changes on the CCP's base of support, David Goodman commented: 'For more than twenty years, political instability had hindered economic progress, alienated the CCP's natural constituencies of support and threatened its authority. ... the various changes in line ensured that the CCP lost the active support of almost every large sector of the population.'³⁸ Despite initial appearances to the contrary, the erosion of support for the CCP continued in the 1980s. The first wave of reforms did help rebuild the party's legitimacy and popular support, but by the start of the 1990s much of the hope was

gone, and much of the rebuilt legitimacy had been lost. For many Chinese, the CCP had not seized the opportunity to reform itself. In terms of legitimacy, trying and failing is probably more dangerous than not trying in the first place. Certainly any future promises of reform and a brighter future will be met with scepticism by important sectors of the Chinese population.

Political evolution in China has been characterized by a lack of consensus over the way forward. But political systems where there is total consensus are rare (if not totally absent) in the world. The fundamental question therefore is not why there is a lack of consensus, but why it has proved so difficult for competing ideas and groups to find an acceptable compromise.

The most obvious explanation is the Mao factor. It really does not matter if consensus or a majority can be found in favour of one policy or another if Mao is simply going to by-pass the institutional framework of power and implement his own policies in any case. The Cultural Revolution would have been inconceivable without Mao to launch it. Mao's great legacy for Chinese politics is the dominance of individuals and personal relations over institutions in the political system. Power has become almost institutionalized into a non-institutionalized system.

Furthermore, occupying a formal position of authority in China does not necessarily equate with the possession of political power. There exist two separate but interlinked tiers of leadership in China: there are leaders who have positions but no real power, and those who have power but no positions.³⁹ Dittmer refers to the two groups as the 'Standing Committee' and the 'Sitting Committee', and argues that the Sitting Committee is able to overrule the Standing Committee on any given policy issue.⁴⁰

Through attendance at enlarged conferences and preparatory meetings, these old leaders can express their interests in the policy-making process. Furthermore, Dittmer argues that the influence of the old guard is strengthened through their contacts with official power holders – as a condition of accepting retirement the old generation were given the power to appoint their successors. As a result, the old guard, not just Deng Xiaoping but also Chen Yun and Deng Yingchao, is able to dominate events from behind the scenes. This situation undermines the authority and efficacy of the formal institutional decision-making process, and places a premium on informal alliances among individuals and groups. As these alliances are fluid and often based on common opposition to a policy or another group, they tend to break down once they have been successful in pursuing their immediate objective.

A political system where power is vested in the hands of individuals is always going to be thrown into turmoil by the loss of dominant per-

sonalities. Much is made of the fact that the Chinese political system is waiting for Deng to die before a decisive step is taken one way or the other. More correctly, it is a question perhaps of who dies first – Deng Xiaoping or Chen Yun. The argument is that if Deng dies before Chen, then the latter's protégés in the political system will be able to bed down their power free from the constraints of Deng and his protégés. Parallels can easily be drawn between the period at the end of Mao Zedong's life, when potential leadership groupings appeared to be waiting in the wings, jostling for position as they waited for the starting gun to go off. While these parallels do exist, it should be noted that who died first in 1976 did affect the immediate fate of clients, but proved to be only a short-term consideration. When Zhou Enlai died, Deng Xiaoping's fortunes took a turn for the worse. Yet his 'purge' in 1976 did not prevent him from returning to power by 1978. The logic of the irresistible reform paradigm is that even if Deng's death turns the tide in favour of the more conservative, this will be only a short-term gain.

If the parallels with the previous succession struggle are taken one stage further, then another crucial factor emerges: Deng's support from (or alliance with) important military figures, notably at the Military Region level, were an important element in his rise back to power. Similarly, any scenario for future developments that does not take into account the role to be played by the military will be a flawed one. In China, it is not necessary to have a hand on the gun in order to gain power, but at least it is necessary to hold the hand of the man who has his hand on the gun.

After over 40 years, communist party rule in China has created its own dynamic. Maintaining party control has become an end in itself, not merely a means to achieving the end of creating a communist society. Perhaps this is one of the key features of communist political evolution the world over. In Eastern Europe, the ruling parties' failure to build a popular base of support in society contributed to the dramatic collapse of communist party rule in 1989. Does the same fate await the CCP?

It is important to note that the political culture of East Asia is not the same as that of Europe. If one is to look for a 'model' for China in the future, then one would be wise not to look to Eastern Europe, but further east to Asia. A neo-authoritarian political system where economic gains are made with a market system under the tutelage of a government unrestrained by the inconvenience of a competitive political system is an attractive concept to many within the CCP. The reforms implemented to date appear to be moving inexorably towards an increasing role for the market in China. The examples of development in close neighbours such as Taiwan and the Republic of Korea may yet prove to be irresistible.

With the economic developments that are occurring in Vietnam, 'Communist NICs' are perhaps the inevitable conclusion of the recent evolution of communism in East Asia.

NOTES

1. Lin Biao explained the need for a Cultural Revolution in this way at his speech to the ninth party congress in 1969.
2. Chen Yun outlined his criticisms in his speech to the closing session of the National Conference of CCP Delegates in September 1985; the speech is reprinted in *BBC Summary of World Broadcasts*, FE/8065/C/1, 25 Sept. 1985.
3. Parris Chang, *Power and Policy in China* (University Park, PA: Pennsylvania State University Press, 1975).
4. Michael Oksenberg, 'Mao's Policy Commitments 1921-76', *Problems of Communism*, Vol.25, No.6 (1976), pp.1-26.
5. Frederick Teiwes, *Leadership Legitimacy and Conflict in China* (London: Macmillan, 1984).
6. Simon Leys, *The Chairman's New Clothes: Mao and the Cultural Revolution* (London: Allison & Busby, 1977).
7. Stuart Schram, *The Thought of Mao Tse-tung* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1989), pp.13-94.
8. According to Tucker, there is evidence that this process had begun long before Stalin's death and Khrushchev's secret speech in 1956: see Robert C. Tucker, *The Marxian Revolutionary Idea* (London: Allen & Unwin, 1970), pp.173-81.
9. Harold Lasswell, *Psychopathology and Politics* (New York: Viking, 1960), Chs. 6-8.
10. It is unclear just how great a disaster the Great Leap was: estimates of the number of deaths in the resulting famine range from 16.5 million between 1958 and 1961 to 30 million in 1960 alone. For a summary of the various estimates, see Penny Kane, *Famine in China, 1959-61: Demographic and Social Implications* (London: Macmillan, 1988).
11. Robert F. Ash, 'The Evolution of Agricultural Policy', *The China Quarterly*, No.116 (Dec. 1988), p.532.
12. 'Resolution on Certain Questions in the History of our Party Since the Founding of the People's Republic of China', Article 5: text in English in *Beijing Review*, No.27 (6 July 1981). For an assessment of the resolution's importance, see David S.G. Goodman, 'The Sixth Plenum of the 11th Central Committee of the CCP: Look Back in Anger?', *The China Quarterly*, No.87 (Sept. 1981), pp.518-27.
13. 'Resolution on Certain Questions in the History of our Party Since the Founding of the People's Republic of China', Article 15.
14. 'Resolution on Certain Questions in the History of our Party Since the Founding of the People's Republic of China', Article 32.
15. See Shaun Breslin, 'China in Crisis', *The Pacific Review*, Vol.2, No.3 (1989), pp.152-255.
16. Barry Naughton, 'False Starts and Second Wind: Financial Reforms in China's Industrial System', in Elizabeth Perry and Christine Wong (eds.), *The Political Economy of Reform in Post-Mao China* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1985), p.224.
17. Michael Oksenberg 'China's 13th Party Congress', *Problems of Communism*, Vol.36, No.6 (1987), p.9.
18. Ibid.
19. John P. Burns, 'China's Governance: Political Reform in a Turbulent Environment', *The China Quarterly*, No.119 (Sept. 1989), pp.484-5.
20. Lowell Dittmer, 'Patterns of Elite Strife and Succession in Chinese Politics', *The China Quarterly*, No.123 (Sept. 1990), pp.405-30.

21. Carol Hamrin, 'Competing Policy Packages in Post-Mao China', *Asian Survey*, May 1984, pp.487-518.
22. David Bachman, 'Differing Visions of China's Post-Mao Economy: The Ideas of Chen Yun, Deng Xiaoping and Zhao Ziyang', *Asian Survey*, March 1986, pp.292-321.
23. David Bachman, 'Varieties of Chinese Conservatism and the Fall of Hu Yaobang', *The Journal of Northeast Asian Studies*, Spring 1988, pp.22-46.
24. Jürgen Domes, 'The Gang of Four and Hua Kuo-feng: Analysis of Political Events in 1975-76', *The China Quarterly*, No.71 (Sept. 1977), pp.473-97.
25. Gordon White, 'Changing Relations Between State and Enterprise in Contemporary China: Expanding Enterprise Autonomy', in Neville Maxwell and Bruce McFarlane (eds), *China's Changed Road to Development* (Oxford: Pergamon, 1984), p.47.
26. Ash, op.cit., p.554; emphasis added.
27. You Ji, 'Zhao Ziyang and the Politics of Inflation', *The Australian Journal of Chinese Affairs*, No.25 (Jan. 1991), p.70.
28. The central authorities went on the offensive against provinces that were ignoring central orders in the late summer and autumn of 1988. Numerous examples can be found in speeches by central leaders. The centre's grievances were outlined in two articles in *Liaowang* during the autumn: Xia Yang and Wang Zhigang, 'Difang Fenquan Yu Hongguan Diaokong (Local Independence and Macroscopic Control)', *Liaowang*, No.39 (26 Sept. 1988), and Xia Yang and Wang Zhigang, 'Biantong Yu Shiheng (Flexibility and Lack of Balance)', *Liaowang*, No.40 (3 Oct. 1988).
29. World Bank, *China: Between Plan and Market* (Washington, DC: World Bank, 1990), p.102.
30. David S.G. Goodman, *Deng Xiaoping* (London: Cardinal, 1990).
31. Alexis de Toqueville, *The Ancien Regime and the Revolution in France* (London: Fontana, 1966); first published in 1856.
32. James C. Davies, 'Towards a Theory of Revolution', *American Sociological Review*, Vol.27 (1962), pp.5-18.
33. For information on the continued repression of known and suspected activists, see *Echoes From Tiananmen* (Hong Kong: Friends of Chinese Minzhu), various issues.
34. Sun Siyi, 'The Current Situation in China', *Politics*, Vol.10, No.2 (Oct. 1990), p.39.
35. Zhao Ziyang, 'Advance Along the Road of Socialism With Chinese Characteristics', in *Documents of the Thirteenth National Congress of the Communist Party of China (1987)* (Beijing: Foreign Languages Press, 1987).
36. Swaine cites Edward Gargan (*Los Angeles Times*, 12 Nov. 1989) as a proponent of the Totalitarian Revival Paradigm, and Winston Lord ('China and America: Beyond the Big Chill', *Foreign Affairs*, Fall 1989, pp.1-26) and Huan Guocang ('The Events of Tiananmen Square', *Orbis*, Fall 1989, pp.487-500) as proponents of the Irresistible Reform Paradigm: see Michael D. Swaine 'China Faces the 1990s: A System in Crisis', *Problems of Communism*, Vol.39, No.3 (1990), p.20.
37. The impact of the dual price or double track system has been discussed at length: see for example Jan Prybyla, 'China's Economic Experiment: From Mao to Market', *Problems of Communism*, Vol.35, No.1 (1986), pp.21-38, and Jan Prybyla, 'China's Economic Experiment: Back from the Market?', *Problems of Communism*, Vol.38, No.1 (1989), pp.1-18.
38. David S.G. Goodman, 'Power and Policy', in David S.G. Goodman, Martin Lockett and Gerald Segal, *The China Challenge: Adjustment and Reform*, Chatham House papers No.32 (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1986), p.9.
39. On the interference of the old guard of leaders see Ian Wilson and You Ji, 'Leadership by "Lines": China's Unresolved Succession', *Problems of Communism*, Vol.39, No.1 (1990), pp.28-44.
40. Dittmer, op.cit., and Lowell Dittmer, 'The Tiananmen Massacre', *Problems of Communism*, Vol.38, No.5 (1989), pp.2-16.

The State: Has the 'Withering Away' Thesis Finally Withered Away?

JOHN HOFFMAN

Logical and historical objections to the classical Marxist thesis of the withering away of the state are not as compelling as they seem. The thesis presupposes a contradictory relationship between abstract notions of self-government and the hierarchical social and political institutions of liberal capitalism. This contradictory relationship cannot emerge as long as Marxists embrace political models like the commune state which have an ambiguous relationship to the liberal tradition. It is only with the disintegration of an authoritarian Soviet state under the liberalizing impact of Gorbachev's reforms that the withering away thesis can become theoretically plausible and practically interesting.

Marxism appears to be equivocal about the state. On the one hand it rejects the anarchist contention that the state should be spontaneously swept away by insurgent masses. On the other hand it emphasizes (more or less consistently)¹ that the state itself is a barrier to human emancipation and must ultimately disappear. Hence it also distances itself from those varieties of socialism that seek merely to see the state 'reformed'.

The problem of the state lies at the heart of Marxist theory and is central to any assessment of communist political evolution. As far as Marx and Engels were concerned, the very existence of the state pointed to a society riven by the kind of conflicts that made a peaceful and consensual resolution of its problems impossible. The role of the state in the societies of 'existing socialism' has always therefore been seen by Marxists as furnishing the critical yardstick to an evaluation of just how far these societies have actually travelled along the road to emancipation.

It is true that it was Engels who specifically referred to the 'withering away of the state' whereas Marx spoke of the abolition, the dissolution and the 'transcendence' of the state, but in our view the differences were stylistic rather than substantial.² Both Marx and Engels sought to

John Hoffman is Senior lecturer in the Department of Politics, University of Leicester.

elaborate a theory that coherently combined statism and anti-statism. Thus in *The Communist Manifesto* (a text actually written by Marx), for example, the state is necessary to the birth of the new order – the working class must become a ruling class able to win the battle of democracy. At the same time it has only a transitional role to play. The public power will lose its 'political' quality as a society emerges that is both classless and stateless in character.

Two objections in particular can be raised to this classical Marxist position. The first is primarily a logical objection: that there is no way in which both support for the state and opposition to the state can be consistently linked within a coherent theoretical framework. For this reason, the argument runs, both the anarchist and the conservative critics of Marxism (in their diametrically opposed ways) are correct: either the state is a barrier to emancipation, in which case it needs to be abolished immediately; or it is necessary for social order, in which case it is here to stay (albeit as a reformed institution).³ It is logically untenable to present the state as a 'transitional' institution that is both necessary for and yet an obstruction to human emancipation.

The second objection is basically historical in character. The Marxist view of the withering away of the state is (whatever its logical merits) merely a pious utopia forever destined to fall foul of political reality. Everything that has happened since the development of the theory bears this historical objection out. Whenever Marxists have come to power, they have enthusiastically embraced the state and engaged in an authoritarian politics that has shown not the slightest sign of withering away. Given the fact that Marxists have always argued for the unity of theory and practice, they are therefore highly vulnerable to the fact that the 'withering away' thesis has had a dismal historical record since 1917.⁴

Indeed, in the circumstances confronting the former USSR, the 'withering away' thesis might be considered a particularly cruel historical and conceptual irony since the Soviet state under Gorbachev seemed more likely to 'dissolve' into economic and political chaos than to transform itself into the self-governing organizations of a higher communist society. The case against the withering away thesis is certainly a powerful one but it is by no means overwhelming. On the contrary, I will try to show first that the thesis is much more logical than it seems, and secondly that as part of the wider logic of Marxist theory, a plausible explanation can be offered as to why Marxists have often found themselves in the impossible position of having to identify with and defend authoritarian regimes. With the collapse of communist party states in Eastern Europe in 1989 and the profound crisis that confronted Gorbachev's USSR, it might even be argued that circumstances are now

developing in a 'post-communist' world that give the classical Marxist theory of the state a cogency and a relevance that it has lacked since the fateful events of 1917.

The Post-Liberal Logic of Marxist Political Theory

The comment is often made that Marx took the idea of the withering away of the state from French socialists like Saint-Simon,⁵ but in fact the thesis is much more central to Western political thought than it appears. Its roots lie, in my view, in what I have called elsewhere the 'subversive abstractions' of the liberal tradition.⁶

The liberal tradition is subversive because in contrast to ancient Greek and medieval political theory, it insists that statist hierarchies are not 'natural' but artificial and that (as even Thomas Hobbes, a somewhat 'authoritarian liberal' argued),⁷ self-government is natural to the human condition. What makes these subversive premises *abstract*, however, is the fact that in practice liberals also see human activity as 'naturally' expressed in capitalist market relationships that are socially divisive in character and in this way generate the need for a state, albeit as a 'necessary evil'. These subversive abstractions constitute the paradoxes that Marx referred to in the 1840s as he and Engels turned to communism as 'the riddle of history solved'.⁸

It is important to remember that the young Marx began his political career as a liberal for whom the philosophy of the Enlightenment furnished the 'weapons of criticism' he levelled against Prussian autocracy. Marx initially embraced Rousseau's ideal of a 'rational' state as the 'great organism' where people would obey the laws they had prescribed to themselves.⁹ However, by 1843 Marx had concluded not only that such an ideal could be realized only through democracy, but that democracy could be understood only as a form of the state that looked beyond the state – as a process of self-government that required both electoral reform and the dissolution of a civil society riven by conflicting private interests. This idea of democracy as the state that looks beyond the state – Marx called it a 'true' state – is extremely significant because it demonstrates how Marx had found a way of coherently linking statism with anti-statism. To realize the 'abstract' liberal polity is, he argued, to transcend it so that the specifically 'political state' – the state that stands apart from and outside of society – is thereby 'annihilated'.¹⁰

Marx's argument is rooted in the 'subversive' premises of the liberal tradition: humans can and should govern themselves. At the same time he finds these premises 'abstract' since political emancipation on its own leaves the division between state and society intact (along with all the

attendant hierarchies that make this division necessary). The subversive premises can become 'concrete' only when society itself is emancipated under communism. In other words, to realize the 'abstractions' of the liberal tradition, repressive political and economic hierarchies must 'wither away'. Presented in these terms, the 'withering away' thesis does, it seems to me, have a logical coherence, and this logic derives from the fact that the thesis presupposes not an anti-liberal but what should be called a post-liberal view of the state. The liberal state is not rejected: it is to be transcended and this transcendence requires (as Hunt's detailed analysis of Marx and Engels's political ideas makes clear)¹¹ a positive rather than a negative view of the liberal tradition.

Indeed, not only are the classic liberal freedoms – of speech, assembly and movement – taken for granted by Marx and Engels, but *The Communist Manifesto* presents a veritable hymn of praise for capitalism as the system whose contradictory premises are embodied in the subversive abstractions of the liberal tradition. It is capitalism and capitalism alone that provides workers with their communist 'weapons'. A negative attitude towards capitalism (and its liberal ideology) would therefore rob workers of the material development, political culture and theoretical enlightenment that make communism conceptually and historically possible as a classless and stateless society.¹²

On this reading, the 'withering away' thesis can be plausibly and coherently presented only when it is seen as essentially post-liberal (and post-capitalist) in character. It implies that workers derive their political education from the stern and steeling school of capitalist circumstances as the inheritors of a contradictory liberal tradition that projects emancipatory ideals while sanctioning repressive hierarchies. In this way liberal capitalism itself furnishes (without of course intending to do so) the inspiration for the post-liberal society that is communism. Statism and anti-statism are coherently linked. The liberal state (and its dynamic capitalist economy) constitutes the necessary precondition for the egalitarian anti-statism that transcends it.

The 'Circumstances Argument' and the Commune State

The 'post-liberal' logic of Marxist political theory implies what I shall call a 'circumstances argument'. People learn only through circumstances: workers turn to communism only when they have experienced capitalism for themselves. Revolutions are (as Engels once put it) the 'necessary outcome of circumstances quite independent of the will or the guide of particular parties'¹³ and this suggests that the role of communists is simply

to help workers and popular movements to help themselves. Impersonal *circumstances* rather than commissars and party cadres provide the politicization.

It is not difficult to see, however, why this 'circumstances argument' has a contradictory character. It implies that inevitably people will from time to time find themselves in circumstances that are not of their choosing. This point – that people enter social relations that are independent of their will – is central to Marxist social theory and it is a 'predicament' that affects Marxists along with everybody else. If Marxists – like people in general – are to be ultimately educated by circumstances (and not through the dictates of paternalist leaders from on high), then they may often experience situations where they feel obliged to say and do things that are in tension with the logic of their own theory. As Engels told the German socialist Weydemeyer, 'we shall find ourselves compelled to make communist experiments and leaps which no-one knows better than ourselves to be untimely'.¹⁴

The question has a radical bearing on the historic fate of the 'withering away' thesis. Untimely communist experiments, premature revolutions and indeed the pressure of political circumstances in general make it likely that Marxists will 'find themselves' embracing from time to time authoritarian and illiberal political stances. Indeed, in a polemical response to the anarchists, Engels even declared that a revolution is the most authoritarian thing there is.¹⁵ But if revolutions inevitably concentrate state power and create authoritarian political institutions (as Engels was provocatively suggesting), will they not also obstruct rather than facilitate the withering away of the state?

Certainly it is not difficult to find in Marx and Engels's writings on the revolutions of 1848 invocations of terror, panegyrics to violence and, perhaps most significant of all, a version of the theory of 'permanent revolution' that dramatically anticipates the events of 1917 by suggesting that a proletarian revolution may 'immediately' follow a bourgeois revolution in a backward country.¹⁶ Positions like this appear to condone an authoritarian politics and they have provided a fertile source for later handbooks on Marxism-Leninism and short histories of ruling communist parties. Polemical exchanges with anarchists and reformists in 1860s and 1870s suggest further support for what appears to be an *illiberal* rather than a post-liberal view of revolution and dictatorship.

Marx and Engels were, it seems, only partially aware of the problem. They suffered from what Hunt has called a 'moral constipation':¹⁷ a reluctance to elaborate or endorse moral principles. As a result, the post-liberal character of their theory seldom received the emphasis that in retrospect it deserves. Yet the logic of the Marxist position is clear.

Communism, Marx declared in 1845, 'presupposes the universal development of productive forces': without it '*want* is merely made general', 'and all the filthy business would necessarily be restored'.¹⁸ Just as a dynamic capitalism provides for the 'universal development of productive forces', so the anti-authoritarianism of the liberal tradition underpins the struggle for a free society in which statist and (repressive) social hierarchies ultimately wither away.

While Marx never directly alluded to the fact that a self-styled 'workers' state' might itself be authoritarian (and therefore pre-liberal rather than post-liberal in character), what we do have nevertheless are the methodological self-criticisms that Engels made towards the end of his life. He and Marx, Engels confessed, had created serious misunderstandings in the minds of their followers by presenting their theory in a mechanistic and one-sided way. There can be little doubt that a simplistic economic determinism will engender a dismissive attitude towards liberal culture and its institutions. Marx (according to Engels) proclaimed that he was not a 'Marxist', and this comment suggests that he was at least implicitly critical of all the forms of anti-liberalism ('political' as well as 'methodological') that he and Engels appeared to endorse when, as the consequence of polemical and partisan pressures, they felt obliged to dramatize the discontinuity of their own theory with the past.¹⁹

Circumstances not only liberate, therefore: they also imprison and constrain. The gulf that frequently arises in Marx and Engels's own writings (not to mention their followers) between a post-liberal logic and authoritarian-sounding statements in particular texts can be coherently explained in terms of Marxism's own 'circumstances argument'. People have to learn from their own mistakes (Marxists included!) and therefore they will be compelled (as Engels had predicted) by particular circumstances to say and do things that are incompatible with the general logic of their own position. Perhaps the most dramatic (and certainly the most relevant) example of the contradictory logic of this 'circumstances argument' can be seen in relation to Marx and Engels's analysis of the Paris Commune.

In *The Civil War in France* Marx presented the Commune as a working-class government – the appropriate political form under which to secure 'the economical emancipation of Labour'. Marx emphasized in particular the fact that, during the short-lived Commune, the entire public service including the police, magistrates and judges was to be elective, responsible and revocable. The Commune was to be a working, not a parliamentary, body, – 'executive and legislative at the same time' – and the first decree of the Commune had been the suppression of the standing army and its replacement by the people in arms.²⁰

The analysis is celebrated for its militant anti-statism – so much so that it has even been argued that for Marx the Commune had ceased to be a form of the state at all. The text formed the basis for the model of commune state that Lenin presented in 1917 as the blueprint for the new Soviet system, and those who believed that the Russian Revolution might bring about the withering away of the state based their anti-statism on the success of this commune model.

Yet Marx's defence of the Paris Commune in *The Civil War in France* stands in some tension with the post-liberal logic of Marxist political theory. The text extolled the heroism and virtues of an event that Marx and Engels privately regarded as a 'desperate folly', and the uprising hardly received a mention at the Hague congress of the International a year later. It is clear that Marx saw the Commune as significant less for what it was than for what it might have been *under very different circumstances*, and we may pinpoint at least three areas in which the analysis of the Commune in 1871 cannot really be squared with the overall logic of Marx and Engels's theory.

The first and most obvious point is the fact that the isolation of the Commune meant that its attempts to dissolve the state into society could only be futile and self-defeating. Revolutions might be national in form (the Commune was even more confined than this) but, as *The Communist Manifesto* had insisted, they were necessarily 'international in substance'. Capitalism is a global system and if communism is to transcend it, it must arise as the result of a revolutionary process that can forge cohesive common interests between nations as well within them. The idea that revolutionaries in a single city could transcend the state by abolishing the standing army as its first decree, institute an egalitarian public service 'at workmen's wages', and destroy the 'parasitic excrescence' of state power all within the compass of a single event runs counter to the entire logic of Marxist theory.

This anticipates my second point – the importance of material conditions that would actually make it possible for educated and politicized populations to begin to take on the governmental responsibilities traditionally shouldered by a privileged caste of bureaucrats. There is nothing in Marx's analysis to suggest that these conditions existed in Paris in 1871, and indeed Marx was later to comment that the leadership of the Commune was 'in no wise socialist, nor could it be'.²¹ Their radicalism derived from anarchist and Jacobin traditions – not from Marx's concept of a communism that transcends capitalism.

It is not surprising therefore that the post-liberal credentials of the communal system of government as analysed in *The Civil War in France* are laced with ambiguity. It is true that the Commune (to its cost) sought

to observe the 'decencies of liberalism' and different political parties were allowed to organize. But Marx's approving reference to the Commune as a 'working' (rather than a parliamentary) body that combines executive and legislative activities and divests judicial functionaries of their 'sham independence' certainly creates the impression that the Commune was hostile to liberal constitutional traditions.

Avineri has suggested that these passages need to be read with caution since Marx identified parliamentarism with 'the limited parliamentary rule of the nineteenth century' and not with what came to be called 'parliamentary democracy' – a term that never really appears in Marx's writings.²² In similar vein Hunt has contended that Marx's description of the Commune as a working body implied not 'some novel fusion of governmental powers' but the standard European practice of parliamentary rule. Executive authority was delegated to groups within the communal assembly and these groups constituted committees of the 'House'. Marx was indeed concerned to see the power of the executive limited to an even greater extent than the liberal tradition normally allows.²³

Nevertheless his comments as they stand do appear to reject rather than transcend liberal constitutionalism, and the argument for a separation of powers is not clear. The point is that if (as Polan comments) administrators are themselves elected politicians directly involved in policy making and subject to immediate recall (as Marx's analysis seems to imply), then this is likely to accentuate the problem of 'careerism' and arbitrariness rather than diminish it. The 'collapse' of politics into administration would also render problematical the role of an opposition able to judge executive performance critically. It reflects 'an unsophisticated anti-bureaucratism' that in practice ends up 'conspiring with the bureaucracy in the maintenance of its power'²⁴ since any blurring of distinct and differentiated roles – between executive, legislature, administration, government and opposition – actually makes it *more* difficult to subordinate the state to society.

Marx and Engels may not have had occasion to reflect on this problem but there is strong evidence to suggest that in general they supported the rule of law and positively identified with liberal constitutionalism. Engels, for example, would later criticize the German socialists for not emphasizing 'the first condition of all freedom: that all officials should be responsible for all their official acts to every citizen before the ordinary courts and according to common law'.²⁵ It is therefore reasonable to suggest that *The Civil War in France* was essentially a 'solidarity text' in support of an event whose weaknesses (as well as its heroism) Marx believed would be instructive for socialists in the future. In the circumstances we would expect the political analysis of an untimely 'experiment'

that ended so tragically to be idealized and utopian, and in this way to understate the post-liberal logic of Marxist theory.

1917 and the Authoritarian Trap

The Russian Revolution itself stands as a particularly dramatic example of an 'untimely' event as a result of which Marxists found themselves 'compelled' to embrace a practice in radical tension with their theory. It is surely significant that Rosa Luxemburg was to defend the revolution in the same way and for the same reasons that Marx and Engels had praised the Commune. The Bolsheviks had acted, she argued, with heroism in circumstances in which they were bound to fail.

However, unlike the Commune which did not resort to any unambiguously authoritarian measures, the Bolsheviks, as Rosa Luxemburg pointed out, had made 'a virtue out of necessity' by presenting the suppression of the Constituent Assembly and the limitations they imposed on political freedom as expressions of a 'higher form of democracy'.²⁶ By 1918 Lenin had adopted an unequivocally hostile attitude towards liberal institutions so that universal suffrage, for example, which had been seen by Marx as providing the basis for the transcendence of the state, was treated in a dismissive manner reminiscent of the anarchist tradition.²⁷

The groundwork for this slide towards authoritarianism was laid after February 1917 when Lenin and the Bolsheviks began to argue for a revolutionary state significantly different from the democratic republic. Indeed, the 'democratic republic' was now presented as a quintessentially bourgeois creation. In 1905 Lenin had criticized the Paris Commune for confusing 'the tasks of fighting for a republic with those of fighting for socialism'.²⁸ This implied that it was an uprising that embodied Jacobin radicalism rather than Marxist politics. In 1917, however, the Commune was now presented as a model for the future socialist state and contrasted not simply with parasitic Bonapartism (as Marx had done) but with 'bourgeois democracy' itself.

Particularly noteworthy here is the fact that Marx's strictures on the limited parliamentarism of his day are presented in *The State and Revolution* as applying to democratic republics in general. All the implicitly illiberal features of the Commune model (as elaborated by Marx) are exacerbated by Lenin. In Lenin's account the Commune served as a substitute for a 'venal and rotten parliamentarism'²⁹ in a way that obliterated the distinction between the legislative and executive, and the problem of conflating the role of civil servant, minister and representative (implicit in Marx's account) is radically aggravated as a result.

In other words, even before the Bolshevik revolution itself (and the civil war and repression that followed), a version of the commune model had been adopted that would make the prospects for dissolving the state back into society even more problematical than they were before. Lenin's contention that the tasks of administration had become increasingly simplified in the era of monopoly capitalism³⁰ appears in retrospect to be almost the exact opposite of the truth, and it helped to promote the kind of naive anti-bureaucratism that in practice makes it more rather than less difficult to hold bureaucrats accountable and limit executive authority. By denying a legitimate role for administration as a separate and distinct function within government, the Bolsheviks unwittingly encouraged bureaucrats to act secretively and conspiratorially in order to protect themselves in a hostile populist environment. As Polan has argued, Lenin's version of the commune state was underpinned by what he calls a 'subterranean authoritarianism' that could only frustrate its anti-statist aspirations.³¹

The one-party state that emerged after 1917 was justified as a 'higher form' of proletarian democracy requiring a (vaguely defined) 'bourgeoisie' to be violently suppressed, even to the point of stripping the latter of their political rights. The new state was essentially anti-liberal in character, and it increasingly betrayed the hallmarks of what Marx and Engels in *The Communist Manifesto* had called 'reactionary socialism' – a form of socialism even further removed from stateless communism than the societies of liberal capitalism. If the post-liberal credentials of the Commune model were ambiguous in 1871, they disappeared altogether in 1917, and it is hard to dispute Polan's view that the Soviet state that emerged bore the stamp of *The State and Revolution* in all its subsequent phases, 'before and after the Bolsheviks secured the monopoly of power, before and after the decline of the Soviets as significant institutions, before and after the rise of Stalin'.³²

The gulf between the libertarian promise of the commune state and the harsh political and social realities that *apparently* contradicted it³³ were ascribed at the time to the isolation of the revolution, the devastation wrought by civil war and the general backwardness of Russian society. But if it is true, as Lenin later commented, that unpropitious circumstances had bequeathed a 'bureaucratic twist' to the workers' state,³⁴ it is no less true that unpropitious circumstances had also led to the adoption of a political model whose anti-liberal character made it inevitable that power would become more rather than less concentrated in conditions of isolation and civil war. Nevertheless, despite its relatively authoritarian character, the commune state was widely seen as the political form through which the state would begin to wither away. Both the Soviet

constitution of 1918 and the Comintern recognized the transience of the state, while the party statutes declared a year later that once the 'Soviet class government' had liberated itself from its 'class character', 'the state will cease to be a state and will become an organ of economic and cultural self-government'.³⁵ Argument raged not over the commune state as such but over the question as to when and how its anti-statist promises might be realized.

Lenin initially emphasized that given the circumstances that followed the birth of Soviet power, the disappearance of the state was a long-term goal: in the meantime the strictest controls of the state over society were required. Towards the end of his life, however, he began to express increasing alarm at the power and arbitrariness of the new state, and the measures he advocated to deal with this problem echo those that his critics in the ranks of the 'Democratic Centralists' and 'Workers' Opposition' had earlier proposed. Essentially they boiled down to purifying a party that had apparently become contaminated by hostile class forces.

Lenin was to propose, for example, that a majority of the Central Committee should be reserved for cadres of working-class origin, but inevitably 'solutions' like this could only exacerbate the anti-liberal character of the party and state that was the source of the elitism and arbitrariness in the first place. These 'anti-bureaucratic' measures reflected an authoritarian belief that will-power and moralism could resolve problems that were institutional and structural in origin. They could only, as Polan comments, provide a cure worse than the disease itself.³⁶

The problem of trying to move closer to an illiberal political model in order to dissolve away the state is seen particularly clearly in the case of Bukharin whose attraction to anarchist ideas had been earlier criticized by Lenin.³⁷ In April 1918 Bukharin boldly proclaimed that the 'proletarian dictatorship is no parliamentary republic, with all its accessories, but a commune-state, without police, without standing army, without civil service'. In the first issue of paper of the short-lived 'Left Communist' group, he quoted extensively from the passages of *State and Revolution* that deal with the withering away of the state, only to be rebuked by Lenin for concentrating on the irrelevant parts of the pamphlet! Bukharin again quoted Lenin against Lenin when he opposed policies that curtailed the power of the factory committees.³⁸

His arguments demonstrate just how fragile are the anti-authoritarian credentials of pre-liberal political models. Writings that presented dazzling visions of a stateless society also laid great emphasis upon the need for centralization and coercion. Bukharin moved effortlessly from pleas for a draconian use of force to a passionate advocacy of proletarian 'self-

government', while progress towards communism appeared at times as a process in which all social organizations would be gobbled up by an omnipotent state.³⁹ Although it is true that the New Economic Policy which Bukharin in particular championed did involve a recognition of market forces and a relaxation of political terror, it remained firmly within the framework of an authoritarian state.⁴⁰

In his *Economics of the Transition Period* Bukharin advocated that, as the state withered away, the army and the navy would be the first to go, followed by punitive and repressive institutions, and ending finally with the disappearance of 'the compulsory character of labour'. The relationship between his ideas and those of Lenin is (amusingly) revealed by the fact that while the Soviet leader accepted the basic thrust of Bukharin's argument, he sought to reverse the order in which the statist institutions would disappear!⁴¹ Given the fact that the anti-statist model is a form of proletarian dictatorship militantly opposed to the liberal institutions of the parliamentary republic, these contradictions and ironies are hardly surprising. Oppositionist and functionary alike were trapped by the same naive belief that loyalty to the commune state (as elaborated in 1917) would expedite the process of dissolving away the state.

This point was also poignantly (if somewhat cynically) demonstrated in 1929 when Bukharin lamented that the USSR was still 'as yet very, very far' from Lenin's commune state. He was subsequently reprimanded by the Stalinist M.B. Mitin, who dismissed his 'preposterous' criticisms by asserting that 'our state is a commune-state'.⁴² Stalin for his part took the view that a commitment to 'socialism in one country' could only be strengthened by campaigns to 'chase away the residues of bureaucracy' and 'prepare for the transition from the dictatorship of the proletariat to the communist society'. He even presented the programme of forced collectivization unleashed in 1929 as the first step towards creating the agrarian components of the commune-state, and a writer in *Izvestiya* at the time asked whether the village *kolkhoz* was not 'the beginning of the withering away of particular elements of statehood?'⁴³

It is true that as attempts to root out the 'enemies of the people' became more draconian, greater and greater emphasis was placed upon the need to strengthen the dictatorship of the proletariat. This, Stalin told the sixteenth party congress in 1930, embraced 'the mightiest and most powerful authority among all the forms of the state that have ever existed'.⁴⁴ In these circumstances the 'withering away thesis' was increasingly identified with the 'chatter' of opportunists. As long as the USSR was surrounded by hostile capitalist countries, a state was not only necessary, but it needed to be continuously strengthened. Engels's formula, Stalin declared in 1950, would become relevant only when

socialism was triumphant on a world scale. Until then the concept remained 'abstract' and those who continued to refer to it simply betrayed their support for the 'Trotskyite-Bukharinist' traitors dedicated to the destruction of the Soviet state.⁴⁵

Despite this attempt to criminalize the 'withering away' thesis as a weapon of anti-Stalinist criticism, its Marxist credentials were never formally denied, and Stalin could still present the Paris Commune (in contrast to the democratic republic) as 'the most suitable form of the dictatorship of the proletariat' – just as Lenin had done. There is a further irony that illustrates the extent to which all Bolsheviks, Leninist, Stalinist or oppositionist alike, paid homage to a model whose anti-statism was ultimately illusory in character.⁴⁶

Stalin had provided the classical formulation of the problem in 1930 when he declared that only by 'strengthening' the state would it eventually die out. 'The higher the development of state power', the closer it comes to disappearing. That, Stalin declared, is the 'Marxist formula': a contradiction, to be sure, but one of a supremely dialectical kind!⁴⁷ The 'contradiction' was, of course, inherent in the adoption of an anti-liberal political system as the vehicle through which to realize the disappearance of the state: it expressed the dilemma of all who adhered to Lenin's illiberal version of the commune state.

In his *Terrorism and Communism* (written in June 1920) Trotsky had declared in a famous passage that just as a lamp shoots out in a brilliant flame before it is extinguished, so a state about to disappear will assume its 'most ruthless form' embracing the life of the citizens authoritatively in every direction.⁴⁸ Stalin's language may have been more prosaic, but the sentiment is the same. An exiled Trotsky could denounce the Stalinist system as 'a society unable to tear itself out of the straitjacket of the state',⁴⁹ but there is a real sense in which the mightiest and most powerful state 'that has ever existed' had evolved logically out of a model whose anti-statism was forever condemned to remain purely theological in character.

Voluntarism and Stagnation under Khrushchev and Brezhnev

The twentieth congress of the CPSU rejected among other things Stalin's thesis that war between capitalist and socialist states was inevitable. In a more liberal political climate, it was now possible to raise once again the question of the withering away thesis.

In 1957, in a speech to the Supreme Soviet, Khrushchev re-emphasized the importance of the Marxist theory of the state, and informed a journalist that the withering away of the Soviet state was already under

way. A year later, addressing the thirteenth congress of the Komsomol, he declared that he expected that the state would ultimately give way to purely social organizations 'whether they be called Komsomol, trade unions or something else'. The authoritative *Fundamentals of Marxism-Leninism* (1959) identified the stateless order as a system of 'communist societal self-government', and both the twenty-first and twenty-second party congresses stressed the need to hand over political functions to 'public organizations' in order to prepare for the onset of self-government.⁵⁰

These arguments were (as Tarschys has pointed out) elaborated and explored in a veritable tidal wave of pamphlets and books published at the time. What would communist self-government actually amount to in practice? What was the time-scale and how precisely might a transition from socialist statehood to stateless communism be effected? During the period 1961–63 there was far more written on the question of the withering away of the state than had appeared during the whole of the Lenin and Stalin eras put together.⁵¹

For Khrushchev, the thesis provided the theoretical rationale for his reforms. The Stalinist terror was denounced and the security agencies downgraded; central ministries were replaced by regional economic councils, and welfare functions were transferred from state agencies to 'public organizations' like the trade unions. Attempts were also made to limit the number of terms party officials could serve and measures were taken to strengthen the soviets as representative institutions able to facilitate the evolution of communist self-government. Electoral candidates were to be selected more sensitively, and the 1961 party programme argued that administrators should be more accountable to public representatives. The 'Leninist' principle of electivity was eventually to be extended to 'all leading officials'.⁵²

These were clearly significant proposals. To the extent that they sought to make the Soviet state more liberal and succeeded in doing so, they can also be regarded as (rather modest) steps in the direction of limiting state power. The problem, however (and this was reflected in the conception of a movement 'back to Lenin'), was that the 'withering away' thesis was projected and popularized in the Khrushchev period within the framework of an essentially illiberal state: hence the relationship between state and society remained theoretically confused. The notion, for example, that a 'civil society' exists outside of and independent of the state was necessarily contradicted by the continued existence of an authoritarian political culture in which party and state are inextricably intertwined. Hence Khrushchev's bizarre insistence that mass participation in public organizations should take place *within* rather than outside the apparatus

of the state,⁵³ so that strengthening popular involvement in governmental activities meant at the same time strengthening the state!

The paradox about the dying out of the state, enunciated by Trotsky and Stalin, continued to be reiterated, and Khrushchev (in this sense), like Lenin and Stalin before him, warned the twenty-first congress that the state could really be expected to wither away only with the full victory of communism. 'To weaken the state now would be to help the enemy.' The process of liberalization must take place within the confines of an authoritarian state, constrained by the understanding, as Khrushchev put it rather colourfully, that the withering away process does not involve 'an autumnal shedding of leaves'.⁵⁴ The thesis, in other words, remained wholly implausible in the absence of the establishment of liberal political institutions to limit the concentrated powers of the state. The fact that Khrushchev could call for the retrospective introduction of the death penalty for 'economic crimes' in 1961 is symptomatic of the unreality of his anti-statist gestures.

Nevertheless, a reform process was initiated that Gorbachev would return to and accelerate over two decades later, and it is worth noting that the great ferment of interest that momentarily erupted over the withering away thesis did register useful insights that could (in different political conditions) contribute to a more realistic appraisal of the problem. Some sought to elaborate a point that Marx himself had made that a state may carry out tasks that are not necessarily and inherently 'statist' in character. For example, the formulation of policies in economic or welfare matters may have little to do with repressive violence and the need for forcible sanctions. Other writers during that period were concerned to distinguish between the specifically political coercion of the state and wider coercive pressures of a psychological and social kind.⁵⁵ In my view any serious assessment of the prospects for a stateless society in the future would certainly need to build upon insights and distinctions of this kind.⁵⁶

What clearly emerges from Tarschys's invaluable survey of Soviet literature on the 'withering away' thesis during 1961–63 is the ultimate futility of trying to project the disappearance of the state while uncritically accepting the existence of a culture and institutions that reject rather than transcend the liberal tradition. Thus he quotes, for example, from writers who argue that elections themselves are part of the state and can be expected to wither away 'like all juridical norms'. At the same time the communist party would still have a guiding role to play in a stateless society, and the future order can be expected to derive its economic cohesion as the expression of 'one single will'.⁵⁷ The authoritarian utopianism of the Leninist model intervenes in the analysis again and again.

With Khrushchev's fall from office in 1964, speculative interest in the withering away thesis largely ceased. Such speculation was now identified with the eccentricity and 'voluntarism' of a leadership that had rashly projected 1981 as the year in which the USSR would have in the main built the technical basis for a communist (and presumably a stateless) society. The twenty-third and twenty-fourth party congresses saw themselves taking a much more businesslike approach to Soviet problems, and although the notion of communist self-government was not seen as necessarily subversive or disloyal in the way it had been during the later years of the Stalin period, it was not given any particular emphasis either.

There is an interesting analogy here between the withering away thesis and the concept of the 'state of the whole people' or 'all-people's state' that was introduced in the party programme of 1961 as a theoretical replacement for the 'dictatorship of the proletariat'. The state of the whole people was seen as a conceptual innovation that would emphasize the transitional character of the Soviet state as a polity destined ultimately to wither away. After 1964 both the withering away thesis and the all-people's state were put on the back burner, and in place of Khrushchev's stress on the 'unfolding building of communism', preference was expressed for the notion of the USSR as a society of 'developed' or 'mature socialism'.

The emphasis on socialism and 'socialist democracy' could still convey a sense of progress and development but without the anti-statist hostages to fortune that the withering away thesis generates. The concept of 'mature socialism' projected the firm and sober view that change should occur within the confines of a state whose authoritarian structures are here to stay. Indeed, Article 62 of the 1977 Constitution obliged the citizen to safeguard the interests of the Soviet state and – in a classically Stalinist formulation – 'to further the strengthening of its might and authority'.⁵⁸ Yet there was greater continuity with the Khrushchev period on both the withering away thesis and the all-people's state than is at first apparent. Georgii Shakhnazarov, writing in 1974, referred to long-term tasks of communist construction in preparation 'for the transfer of the government system to communist public self-administration',⁵⁹ while Fedor Burlatskii four years later linked the two concepts in a 'Khrushchevite' manner by declaring that the 'ultimate purpose of the state of the entire nation' is 'to build communism and develop forms of social self-administration'.⁶⁰

Article 1 of the 1977 Constitution itself refers to the USSR as 'a socialist state of the whole people' while Brezhnev could comment that the constitution envisaged statehood 'gradually being transformed into communist self-government'.⁶¹ Although Harding suggests that the 'withering

away' thesis was in some way a conceptual causality of the all-people's state,⁶² in fact the fortunes of the two notions remain linked. The point is that the anti-statism of the withering away thesis itself was problematic, whether presented voluntaristically as under Khrushchev or in more staid and ceremonial form, as under Brezhnev. Indeed, as we have already seen, even in the Stalin period the authoritarian version of the commune state associated with Lenin was never completely abandoned as part of a theologically conceived 'Marxism-Leninism'.

Nor should we assume that, because the 'withering away' thesis was de-emphasized in the Brezhnev period, this represented a practical retreat from a movement towards a self-governing society. A realistic analysis of the withering away of the state presupposes (as I have argued) the development of a post-liberal state, and the Brezhnev period registered some (extremely modest) advances in the direction of further liberalization. Policy making became more sober and stable and an attempt was made to build upon Khrushchev's efforts to revitalize the soviets, delineate more sharply the boundaries between party, state and mass organizations, and strengthen the rule of law. It is true, as Hill comments, that the greater professionalism of political institutions in the Brezhnev period meant that the Soviet state was becoming more akin to the modern bourgeois state,⁶³ but in view of the pre-liberal character of its past, this represented a step in the direction of the kind of political system in terms of which the 'withering away' thesis could be seriously debated.

Gorbachev's Democratization: Where Will It End?

In retrospect Gorbachev's aspirations as the new party leader in 1985 appear extraordinarily modest. The intention certainly was reform – but to reform, not to abolish, the structures of the authoritarian system established after the Russian Revolution. The tender shoots of liberalization had already appeared under Khrushchev (albeit somewhat extravagantly and exotically) and they had not disappeared even under Brezhnev.

Gorbachev began by building upon Andropov's 'authoritarian *perestroika*',⁶⁴ directing his opening salvoes against the problem of corruption in the party and the sluggishness of the economy. He was to tell the Polish Sejm in July 1988 that he had not at first appreciated just how important institutional changes were going to be.⁶⁵ By the twenty-seventh party congress in February–March 1986 a strategy of 'accelerating' economic development had been transformed into a form of *perestroika* that (as Gorbachev himself acknowledged) required a veritable democratic revolution for its success.

The democratization process was to be extended to the party, the soviets and the legal system itself. A decree in March 1987 allowed for the introduction of multi-member constituencies in the local elections as an experiment: at the nineteenth party conference in June–July that year Gorbachev proclaimed the results a success.⁶⁶ By December 1988 a major overhaul of the Brezhnev constitution had taken place. Elections were now to involve an unlimited number of candidates and deputies were forbidden to hold government positions. As part of the programme of revitalizing the legislative process, the Supreme Soviet became a working body of 400–450 deputies meeting for up to eight months in the year as, in Sakwa's words, 'a full-time parliament on the Western model'.⁶⁷ Elected by a much larger Congress of People's Deputies (which met twice annually), one-fifth of the membership of the Supreme Soviet turned over each year and the non-Supreme Soviet deputies had the right to make up half the membership of the standing committees empowered to scrutinize and challenge executive bodies, represented at the top by the Council of Ministers.⁶⁸

In May 1989 Gorbachev was elected to a presidential-style post of Chairman of the new Supreme Soviet. In March 1990, however, a completely new post was created, quite separate from the Supreme Soviet: an American-style presidency (as provided for in a new Chapter 15 of the constitution). The creation of this post thus shifted the centre of political gravity still further away from the party to the Supreme Soviet, the President and the executive council he or she appointed. Although Gorbachev was elected President (initially and exceptionally) by the Congress of People's Deputies, there was intended to be a nation-wide election for the presidency when his first five-year term ended in the spring of 1995.

This process of liberalization has been extended no less dramatically to a reform of the legal system. In Gorbachev's view (and it is an argument with impeccable liberal credentials), 'law is designed to protect society from abuses of power and guarantee citizens and their organizations and work collectives their rights and freedoms'.⁶⁹ The notion of a 'law-governed state' or *Rechtsstaat* – hitherto regarded as inherently and irretrievably bourgeois in character – received Gorbachev's blessing in May 1988.⁷⁰ One of the constitutional amendments central to realizing this *Rechtsstaat* set up a Committee of Constitutional Review elected by the Congress and charged with the task of deciding the constitutionality of government decisions, while other amendments sought to strengthen the independence of the courts. Judges were to be elected for a ten-year period and any 'interference' in their work by party or state officials was deemed 'impermissible'.⁷¹

The intention of these constitutional and legal reforms was *not* to replace an authoritarian state by a liberal one. 'We are not,' Gorbachev insisted in 1988, 'retreating even one step from socialism, from Marxism-Leninism',⁷² and the reforms were invariably presented as attempting to create a *socialist* rule of law, a *socialist* pluralism and a *socialist* system of checks and balances. Writing in January 1990, Stephen White could still characterize the reform process as one that *combined* Leninism with elements of a 'Western-style limited government', and its limited character seemed admirably summed up by Fedor Burlatskii's crisp formula of a 'socialist pluralist democracy under single-party conditions'.⁷³

What is now increasingly clear is that Gorbachev's reforms have unleashed a momentum that recalls Tocqueville's celebrated concept of the democratic process as 'universal and permanent', 'daily passing beyond human control' with 'every event' helping it along. 'Will it stop now, when it has grown so strong and its adversaries so weak?'⁷⁴ In this regard, the position of the communist party – its prestige, its cohesion and its capacity to control events – is all-revealing.

The elections to the Congress of People's Deputies in March 1989 saw the defeat of many party and state officials, and communist party candidates routed in the Baltic republics. Boris Yeltsin, forced out of the Politburo in 1987, became a deputy in the teeth of fierce establishment opposition. In July 1990 he resigned from the party and his election in 1991 as president of the Russian republic undoubtedly reflected growing opposition to Gorbachev and the communist party itself. As the CPSU prepared for its twenty-eighth congress in the summer of 1990, it was clear that the ban on factions and platforms dating back to 1921 had become a dead letter. Following the bitter wrangling that occurred at the congress, the most liberal of the opposition groups, the Democratic Platform, reconstituted itself as an autonomous political organization.

It was perhaps inevitable therefore (although no less astonishing) that in February 1990 the communist party would decide (and the measure was legally enacted by the Congress of People's Deputies the following month) to accept the principle of a multi-party system. The political monopoly enshrined in Article 6 of the Constitution and enjoyed by the CPSU since 1918 has gone. As Hill commented, 'the Soviet Union appears to be heading rapidly in the direction of an unadorned "pluralism"',⁷⁵ and the prefix 'socialist' that the reformers had bravely applied to the institutional changes was crumbling fast. The party's future? It is likely, in Hill's view, 'to follow that of its ideological brothers in Eastern Europe, whatever means it may choose in the short term to secure its ruling position'.⁷⁶

A veritable revolution is under way, but what is its significance for the

classical Marxist thesis of the withering away of the state? Certainly we have seen no revival of interest in the concept of a stateless communism of the kind that characterized Soviet political writing during the Khrushchev years. On the contrary, the drive (ostensibly) to 'perfect' democracy has been accompanied by a growing (and gloomy) realization of just how far Soviet political life actually falls below liberal democratic norms in the West. 'Today,' Gorbachev writes, 'it is as though we are going through a school of democracy again. We are learning. We still lack political culture'.⁷⁷ Vadim Medvedev has commented on the need to learn from both social democracy and capitalism in the creation of 'an up-to-date conception of socialism',⁷⁸ while the radical communist reformer, Yuri Afanas'ev, denounced Lenin in March 1990 for having founded 'a system based on violence and mass terror' and declared that the whole development of the Soviet system since 1917 had been a disastrous mistake.⁷⁹

In circumstances in which some reformers even urged Gorbachev to adopt dictatorial powers in order to safeguard democratization, the withering away thesis hardly seems relevant. Migranyan, for example, argued that the USSR must return to the mainstream of human history by building a legal state. The attempt to abolish the state after 1917 may have led to the disappearance of the state as it is understood in the West, but it simply created in its place a totalitarian regime that swallowed up 'both the individual and society'.⁸⁰

The point is that without the existence of a liberal legal and constitutional structure in society, the notion that the power of the state could even begin to wither away is fanciful and absurd. But does it follow, as Sakwa contends, that the movement towards a legal state constitutes 'a retreat from the radical Utopianism of the Communist project', and represents 'relegitimizing' of the political state 'after the strictures of Marx and Lenin, and indeed Khrushchev's attempts to achieve its "withering away"'?⁸¹ Soviet reformers may well be in the process of abandoning their Marxist allegiances, but the fact remains that the establishment of a liberal political system is a precondition for any serious consideration of the 'withering away' thesis, and for precisely the reasons that Marx himself had spelled out in 1843. As long as political emancipation has not been secured, the conditions for 'human emancipation' and thus *meaningful* self-government do not exist. It is the liberal polity and only the liberal polity that makes it possible to look 'beyond' the state.

Hence, as I have argued above, the 'withering away' thesis can be coherently analysed only as part of the post-liberal logic of Marxist political theory. Sakwa argues that the stress placed by the reformers on some of the proceduralism of liberal democracy is 'in tension with the alternative discourse of the Marxist critique of liberal democracy',⁸² but

this argument rests upon the assumption that Marxism has a negative view of liberalism and that the commune model in particular has an unproblematic place in Marxist political theory. In fact, as we have seen, Marx took a far more positive view of liberal constitutionalism than Sakwa imagines, as demonstrated (for example) by his comment in the *Critique of the Gotha Programme* that the forms of the state are more or less free to the extent that they restrict 'the freedom of the state'.⁸³

Of course, as Sakwa notes elsewhere, the 'withering away' thesis takes the form of 'an irresolvable antinomy' when the contrast is 'between having a dictatorial state and not having a state'.⁸⁴ But this is because a dictatorial state has neither the liberal culture nor the institutions that entrench the notion of self-government as an abstract political norm, and it is only when this norm becomes prevalent and predominant that the paradoxical character of the liberal state itself becomes apparent.

As long as the 'withering away' thesis is tied to a model of the commune state that (even in Marx's formulation) has an ambiguous relationship with the liberal tradition, an 'irresolvable antinomy' persists. The 'subversive abstractions' of the liberal tradition must be allowed to take root before the idea that the state can be transformed into self-governing institutions at local, regional, national and international level becomes theoretically plausible and of practical interest.⁸⁵

NOTES

1. On occasion Marx and Engels did refer to the state forms of a future communist society but this is untypical. For references, see Daniel Tarschys, *Beyond the State: The Future Polity in Classical and Soviet Marxism* (Uddevalla, Sweden: Laromedelsforlagen, 1971), p.79; for Marx and Engels's general position, see H. Draper, 'The Death of the State in Marx and Engels', in Ralph Miliband and J. Saville (eds), *The Socialist Register 1970* (London: Merlin, 1970), pp.282-307.
2. S. Avineri, *The Social and Political Thought of Karl Marx* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1970), pp.202-3; also Tarschys, op. cit., p.80.
3. Eduard Bernstein, one of the classic exponents of 'revisionist' socialism, argued that 'the so-called coercive associations, the state and the communities, will retain their great tasks in any future I can foresee': cited by P. Gay, *The Dilemma of Democratic Socialism* (New York: Collier, 1962), p.246.
4. J. Femia, 'Gramsci: Marxism's Saviour or False Prophet?', *Political Studies*, Vol. XXXVII, No.2 (1989), p.283; see also Ch.4 of his *Marxism and Democracy* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1991).
5. Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels, *Collected Works (MESW)*, Vol.3 (London: Lawrence & Wishart, 1976), pp.80, 589.
6. See John Hoffman, *State, Power and Democracy: Contentious Concepts in Practical Political Theory* (Brighton: Wheatsheaf, 1988), Ch.8.
7. Thomas Hobbes, *The Leviathan* (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1966), pp.211, 225.
8. *MECW*, Vol.3, p.296.
9. *Ibid.*, Vol.1 (London: Lawrence & Wishart, 1975), p.202.
10. *Ibid.*, Vol.3, pp.121, 30.

11. In the two volumes of his *The Political Ideas of Marx and Engels* (London: Macmillan, 1974 and 1984), Richard Hunt presented an effective and detailed rebuttal of the argument that Marx and Engels supported illiberal notions of 'totalitarian democracy'.
12. For the insistence that the proletariat must turn 'bourgeois weapons' against the bourgeoisie, see *MECW*, Vol.6 (London: Lawrence & Wishart, 1976), pp.490, 493.
13. *Ibid.*, p.349.
14. Cited in Michael Levin, *Marx, Engels and Liberal Democracy* (London: Macmillan, 1989), p.69.
15. Cited in John Hoffman, *The Gramscian Challenge: Coercion and Consent in Marxist Political Theory* (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1984), p.168.
16. See the discussion in Hunt, *op. cit.*, Vol.1, pp.176-91.
17. Hunt, *op. cit.*, Vol.2, p.187.
18. *MECW*, Vol.5 (London: Lawrence & Wishart, 1976), p.49.
19. See Engels's letter to Schmidt, 5 August 1890; Bloch, 21-22 Sept. 1890; Schmidt, 27 Oct. 1890; Mehring, 14 July 1893 in Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels, *Selected Correspondence* (Moscow: Progress, 1975).
20. Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels, *On the Paris Commune* (Moscow: Progress, 1971), pp.75, 71.
21. For reference and discussion, see Avineri, *op. cit.*, pp.239-49.
22. *Ibid.*, p.210.
23. Hunt, *op. cit.*, Vol.2, p.144.
24. A. Polan, *Lenin and the End of Politics* (London: Methuen, 1984), p.70.
25. Letter to Bebel, 18-28 March 1875, in *Selected Correspondence*, p.275.
26. Rosa Luxemburg, *Selected Political Writings*, edited by R. Looker (London: Cape, 1972), p.250.
27. In his fierce polemic with Kautsky, Lenin insists (apropos of the Constituent Assembly) that 'universal suffrage sometimes produces petty-bourgeois, sometimes reactionary and counter-revolutionary parliaments': Lenin, *Collected Works*, Vol.28 (Moscow: Progress, 1965), pp.268, 280.
28. *Collected Works*, Vol.9, p.81.
29. *Collected Works*, Vol.25, p.424.
30. *Ibid.*, p.426.
31. Polan, *op. cit.*, Ch.2.
32. *Ibid.*, p.57.
33. In my view, however, Richard Sakwa overlooks the tension between Marx's analysis of the Paris Commune in *The Civil War in France* and Lenin's analysis of the Commune in *The State and Revolution*: see his 'Commune Democracy and Gorbachev's Reforms', *Political Studies*, Vol.XXXVII, No.2 (1989), pp.225-6.
34. Lenin, *Collected Works*, Vol.32, p.24.
35. Tarschys, *op. cit.*, p.138.
36. Polan, *op. cit.*, p.68; see also I. Meszaros, 'Political Power and Dissent in Post-revolutionary Societies' in Il. Manifesto (ed.), *Power and Opposition in Post-revolutionary Societies* (London: Ink Links, 1979), p.117.
37. Polan, *op. cit.*, p.13.
38. Tarschys, *op. cit.*, pp.137, 144. Polan, *op. cit.*, p.28.
39. Hoffman, *The Gramscian Challenge*, p.189; Tarschys, *op. cit.*, p.145.
40. Stephen Cohen, 'Bukharin and the Eurocommunist Idea' in Vernon V. Aspaturian, Jiri Valenta and D. Burke (eds), *Eurocommunism between East and West* (Bloomington, IN: University of Indiana Press, 1980), p.68.
41. Tarschys, *op. cit.*, p.148.
42. *Ibid.*, p.147.
43. *Ibid.*, pp.143, 148.
44. *Ibid.*, p.152.
45. *Ibid.*, pp.154-6.
46. Hoffman, *The Gramscian Challenge*, p.196.
47. Tarschys, *op. cit.*, p.152.

48. Cited in Stephen Lukes, *Marxism and Morality* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1987), p.113. The similarity between Trotsky and Stalin on this is also noted by G. Kline, 'The Withering Away of the State', in Walter Laqueur and Leopold Labedz, *The Future of Communist Society* (New York: Frederick A. Praeger, 1962), p.67.
49. Tarschys, op. cit., p.149.
50. Ibid., p.156-7.
51. Ibid., p.159.
52. Ronald J. Hill, 'The "All-People's State" and "Developed Socialism"', in Neil Harding (ed.), *The State in Socialist Society* (London: Macmillan, 1984), p.114.
53. Ibid.
54. Tarschys, op. cit., pp.198, 157.
55. Ibid., pp.193, 232.
56. See John Hoffman, 'Capitalist Democracies and Democratic States: Oxymorons or Coherent Concepts?', *Political Studies*, Vol.XXXIX, No.2 (1991), p.347.
57. Tarschys, op. cit., pp.220, 195.
58. Cited in Neil Harding, 'Conclusion', in Harding, *The State in Socialist Society*, p.303.
59. Georgii Shkuzharov, *Socialist Democracy* (Moscow: Progress, 1974), p.150.
60. Fedor Burlatsky, *The Modern State and Politics* (Moscow: Progress, 1978), p.108.
61. John Hoffman, 'The Coercion/Consent Analysis of the State under Socialism', in Harding, *The State in Socialist Society*, p.144.
62. Harding, op. cit., p.303.
63. Hill, op. cit., p.123.
64. Richard Sakwa, 'The New Conception of Democracy under Perestroika', in David McLellan and S. Sayers (ed.), *Socialism and Democracy* (London: Macmillan, 1991), p.138.
65. Stephen White, '"Democratisation" in the USSR', *Soviet Studies*, Vol.42, No.1 (1990), pp.16-17.
66. Ibid., p.5.
67. Richard Sakwa, *Gorbachev and his Reforms, 1985-1990* (London: Philip Allan, 1990), p.144.
68. Sakwa, 'The New Conception of Democracy under Perestroika', pp.152-3.
69. Mikhail S. Gorbachev, *Perestroika: New Thinking for our Country and the World* (London: Fontana, 1988), p.105.
70. Theodor Schweisfurth, 'The Advent of a Rechtsstaat' in Ronald J. Hill and Jan Zielonka (eds.), *Restructuring Eastern Europe: Towards a New European Order?* (Aldershot: Edward Elgar, 1990), pp.95-6.
71. White, op. cit., p.10; Schweisfurth, op. cit., p.100.
72. Sakwa, 'Commune Democracy and Gorbachev's Reforms', p.238.
73. White, op. cit., p.20.
74. Alexis de Tocqueville, *Democracy in America*, Vol.1 (London: Fontana, 1966), p.8.
75. Ronald J. Hill, 'The CPSU: From Monolith to Pluralist?' *Soviet Studies*, Vol.43, No.2 (1991), p.230; Sakwa, 'The New Conception of Democracy under Perestroika', p.151; Ronald J. Hill, '"Democratisation" and the CPSU', Paper for the annual conference of the Political Studies Association of the United Kingdom, Lancaster, 1991, pp.9-10.
76. Hill, '"Democratisation" and the CPSU', p.10.
77. Gorbachev, op. cit., p.82.
78. White, op. cit., p.19.
79. Sakwa, *Gorbachev and his Reforms*, pp.379-80.
80. Sakwa, 'The New Conception of Democracy under Perestroika', p.149.
81. Sakwa, *Gorbachev and his Reforms*, p.133.
82. Sakwa, 'The New Conception of Democracy under Perestroika', p.151.
83. Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels, *Selected Works* (one volume) (London: Lawrence & Wishart, 1968), p.330.
84. Sakwa, 'Commune Democracy and Gorbachev's Reforms', p.239.
85. I have explored these questions further in *State, Power and Democracy*, Ch.3, and in 'Can We Get Rid of the State?', *Politics Review*, Vol.1 (1991).

Economic Reform and Political Evolution in Eastern Europe

MARTIN MYANT

Examination of the relationship between economic reform and political evolution in Poland, Czechoslovakia and Hungary, focusing on past changes to the economic management system in response to declining economic performance, suggests that economic reform made little difference either to the operation of the system or to its performance. Five barriers existed to effective economic reform in the past, and while ideas emerged for overcoming these barriers, it was only with the complete ending of communist power that the economic system could be changed substantially. Current attempts at a transition to a market economy show that some new obstacles have emerged, and difficulties in implementing economic policy are influencing the shape of emerging political structures.

This contribution explores the relationship between economic reform and political change in Eastern Europe, concentrating principally on Czechoslovakia, Hungary and Poland, the countries in which the issue of economic reform ultimately played a major role in the final collapse of communist power. Czechoslovakia also has a rich experience of economic reform attempts and has now joined Poland in seeking the fastest possible transition to a market economy. These countries thus provide examples of evolutionary change *within* and *away from* communism as a form of rule.

Failure after 40 Years

'Socialism', an evolutionary stage on the road to 'communism', was presented as a system that could provide faster growth and a more egalitarian distribution of income than Western European capitalism. Published figures for the 1950s and 1960s went some way to support these claims: comparisons could show 'socialism' catching up 'capitalism' in

Martin Myant teaches in the Department of Economics and Management, Paisley College, Scotland. His publications include *The Czechoslovak Economy, 1948-1988: The Battle for Economic Reform* (1989).

production of basic goods and even overtaking it in some areas. It was, however, never possible convincingly to argue socialism's superiority: weaknesses and doubts always impelled a search for means to improve performance. Attempting to summarize the situation in 1978, Michael Ellman concluded that neither system had clearly demonstrated its superiority, and suggested that 'the two systems are equally good at producing tendentious arguments'.¹ A decade or so later, he was still cautiously arguing that conclusions from actual experience of the two systems 'are more complex and have more nuances than would be expected on the basis of simple-minded a priori expectations, either liberal or Marxist'.²

As far as Eastern Europe is concerned, his conclusion appears far too cautious. It is now clear that past comparisons were based on exaggerated official figures for East European growth rates. Comparisons are notoriously difficult in the absence of free trade between the two blocs and given different national accounting conventions. Nevertheless, recent attempts to compare national incomes leave little doubt that, although central planning may have allowed for some 'catching up' in the 1950s and possibly also the 1960s, Eastern Europe has steadily fallen behind in the last two decades. The system apparently had some potential at first but this was soon exhausted. By the 1980s, growth had generally given way to stagnation or even decline, leading to low living standards, disastrous environmental conditions and outdated industrial structures with obsolete capital equipment.³ There was no obvious basis for a renewal of the growth of the early years, and even the claims to equality were questionable. Figures on income distribution taking account of the black economy showed very substantial inequalities and little sign of the stated concern for distribution related to merit.⁴

The reasons for that poor performance do not concern us here. Throughout those four decades, however, economic disappointments have variously contributed to the pressure to improve the system's performance, essentially through reform which, if pursued consistently, would have affected the political system's evolution.

Ideas for economic reform were initially based, to varying degrees, on a critique of 'over-centralization'. Familiar problems were noted: distorted output patterns under quantity targets; enterprises concealing their potential; the lack of incentive to innovate.⁵ These may have been thought of as mere teething troubles, surmountable with more experience. Certainly, many leading economists were eager to dismiss suggestions that the socialist system as such might be inherently inefficient. But gradually economists' criticisms became more sweeping with declining performance, and by the end of the 1980s few prominent

economists in Poland, Hungary or even Czechoslovakia could confidently reject Hayek's sweeping condemnation of socialism made in the inter-war years.⁶

Attempts at decentralising reform, usually implying a move towards a market mechanism, have been made at slightly different times in the various countries. There is, however, a clear tendency towards coincidence in timing and the reform 'waves' can be linked both to general political developments and to economic performance. The start is usually set as 1956 or its aftermath, with reforms in Poland (1956), the USSR (1957) and Czechoslovakia (1958). The next major wave came around 1965, following economic disappointments in the early 1960s. The 'Kosygin' reform in the USSR set the scene, followed by more ambitious efforts in Czechoslovakia (1965–69) and Hungary, where the New Economic Mechanism (NEM) was introduced in 1968. During the political retrenchment and economic stability of the 1970s, changes aimed to decentralize without shifting towards the market. Ideas from the 1960s began to re-emerge around 1980 in some countries, especially Hungary and crisis-ridden Poland, while others took longer to rediscover those old ideas. By the end of the 1980s, when both economic collapse and political disintegration seemed imminent in at least some countries, the quest for reform had become a permanent part of official policy as it never had before.

Have Reforms Helped?

Three general questions can be posed concerning the experience of economic reforms. First, did they significantly affect how the system really worked? There were some apparent differences and there have been claims that the reforms of the 1960s, especially, were never really reversed. This needs to be treated with caution, however. The details of individual reform attempts are not relevant to present purposes,⁷ but the most ambitious reforms retained state ownership, many of the institutional structures of central planning and at least some central controls over prices, wages and many other economic variables. Detailed plans were always reduced in scope, but enterprises continued to be assessed using success indicators. Changes in their form need not be decisive if details are still subject to arbitrary manipulation from above.

Thus, for example, if an enterprise is given a target in quantity terms (as was normal in the early 1950s), it will try to bargain for the lowest possible quantity target, and distort or conceal information so as to achieve this. If the target is profitability, it can similarly bargain for conditions – say, appropriate prices of its end products – to make the

target more attainable. Even if price increases are excluded, it may exploit political influence to win credits or subsidies to compensate for the inability to reach a target. The important question, then, is not the form the indicators take but whether the success of an enterprise depends on its own efforts within a market on the enforced beneficence of a higher authority. So long as the latter applies, many standard criticisms of the traditional central planning system are likely to remain valid.

Next, have reforms led to a discernible improvement in economic performance? Given that they have led to no fundamental change in the system, it seems unlikely. However, some hopes have been attached to Hungary's NEM, widely cited in the mid-1980s as a model for emulation: Alec Nove even saw it as a possible basis for 'feasible socialism'.⁸ There clearly were some 'different' elements, including the absence of rigid instructions to enterprises and slightly greater scope for private enterprise, but macroeconomic performance has not shown a clear distinction from other countries of the area. The fundamental basis for success was evidently still the ability to win favours from the centre.⁹

Third, can all the different reform attempts really be lumped together under one heading? Very substantial distinctions can be made among reform efforts, but there are also cases of one 'kind' evolving, or threatening to evolve, into another. Concerning the links between economic reform and political evolution, the important distinctions reflect the relationship between the origins of an economic reform and wider political and social changes and, in turn, the social impact of the changes. Ed Hewett, after studying Soviet experience, has formulated a general framework for the reform process, running through preparation, implementation and retrenchment.¹⁰ Experience is far richer in some Eastern European countries, but the framework is a useful starting point.

A limited reform process, following this rough model, starts with the identification of a problem by the top leadership; an expert commission works out detailed proposals, which return to the political arena and are accepted, possibly in amended form; various forces then ensure that the actual implementation changes little. The study of economic reform can thus be partly a study of the policy process in the narrowest sense, and obvious questions are how far success depends on the form of the expert commission, on its members' relationship to leading politicians, its size, its degree of independence and similar matters. These points have been widely debated, and the simple model outlined here fairly accurately describes many of the past changes in economic mechanisms.

One of the closest examples is the reforms of the early 1970s, especially in the Soviet Union and Poland, in which enterprises were grouped together into larger units (following similar reorganizations in the GDR

and Czechoslovakia). The justifications for this reform differed slightly but in each case it attempted, among other things, to solve the problem of overload in the central planning organs by devolving some decisions to intermediate-level bodies. That alone helps define the extreme social narrowness of their origins. For various reasons to do with the economic consistency of the idea, substantial decentralization was never achieved. In any case, the whole idea was out of favour by the next decade, not least because it supposedly helped to create still more powerful sectoral lobby groups, so any gain in reducing the planners' overload was counter-balanced by a reduction in the centre's ability to get detailed information on the performance and potential of individual units within what had become powerful combines. Beyond that, however, society's input into formulating ideas was minimal, as was the social impact of the changes.

The reform attempts in Czechoslovakia between 1970 and 1989 provide a still clearer example of minimal social involvement.¹¹ The term 'reform' was, in fact, outlawed following the Soviet invasion of 1968 and significant measures were not really tried until 1983 (the so-called Package of Measures) and from 1987 onwards. Quite remarkably, the authorities had so little confidence in their own leading economists, and such a lasting fear that public discussion could encourage a new political movement, that they kept consultations even with experts down to the minimum. Instead, ideas were developed mainly by lifting policies from the USSR, meaning in practice little more than changes to success indicators, so that the whole process could proceed practically unnoticed by society at large.

Some economic reforms, by contrast, were closely related to sweeping political changes, notably in Poland in 1956. Working-class protest forced a change in political leadership, led to the creation of workers' councils in factories as permanent organs of a new system, and opened up expert discussion of a new economic system. The ordered process adapted from Hewett's account was thus substantially changed, although the final outcome was rather similar: by 1958 'retrenchment' was the dominant trend. Political change was again the key in Poland in 1980: although professional economists were increasingly aware of the need for a new system comparable with Hungary's NEM, the political authorities resisted all pressures until the rise of Solidarity.

Czechoslovakia in 1968 again diverged from Hewett's model, as the economic reform started in an 'orthodox' way, but then became part of a wider social and political process. This changed its form somewhat, especially with the creation of employees' councils, but there were already strong pressures for 'retrenchment' even without Soviet military help.

Five Barriers to Reform

Although the processes embraced by the phrase 'economic reforms' display great variety, firm distinctions are difficult to identify. Every change reflects more than just the whim of leading figures and each change impinges on someone's immediate interests. Moreover, an intended change confined to the economic management system may develop into something with wider social implications, as the Czechoslovak leadership in the 1970s and 1980s clearly appreciated. By contrast, broadly conceived reforms can shrink back into minimal changes, as happened in Poland in 1956. Perhaps most importantly, despite all the distinctions, none have achieved the implicit objective of a major improvement in economic performance.

One recent Polish study listed 11 possible explanations for lack of success, and the list cannot be considered comprehensive.¹² For present purposes five broad areas, overlapping and interacting, can be usefully distinguished.

The first is *opposition from the top*. While obviously this cannot be total, political leaders' attitudes have usually been at best mixed. They are concerned at poor economic performance, and their concern grew, especially in the 1980s, as that performance deteriorated. On the other hand they are firmly wedded to the existing system of power, they often have little knowledge of and no faith in seemingly radical alternatives, and they would not like to see changes 'getting out of hand'. Three examples illustrate the point.

First, in Czechoslovakia in 1963 the dull president and party first secretary Antonín Novotný positively encouraged Ota Šik in his ideas for economic reform. Novotný backed the creation of a commission of independent experts. The economy had been experiencing some embarrassing difficulties and he hoped for a painless way to rectify matters. Šik's orthodox background and acceptance within leading political circles helped enormously. Novotný – and probably almost the whole political leadership – never understood the essence of reform proposals either then or as they developed in subsequent years. His public statements contained continual references to strengthening planning. He was unhappy with anything that challenged his traditional values by, for example, generating greater inequalities or bringing about unemployment. He thereby limited the scope of the reform, amended and blocked documents from the expert commission, and was gradually identified as a major opponent. Although not the principal cause of his downfall, that factor helped to weld a broad coalition within the party hierarchy opposed to his conservatism in diverse spheres of life.

A second example is the Polish reform of 1956 which fairly quickly ground to a halt. Gomulka's hostility is frequently cited as a major factor.¹³ A somewhat different third case is Kádár's support for Hungary's NEM¹⁴ and his acceptance of its strengthening in the late 1970s and early 1980s – an attitude related to his view of Hungary's peculiar political circumstances following the uprising of 1956. Kádár was personally convinced that the pre-1956 system had failed: therefore, despite depending initially on severe repression, he trusted economists and allowed them to develop ideas for economic reform. He set limits, including the obvious ultimate one that the existing political system was not to be questioned. Nevertheless, he actively fought against the strongest opponents of reform, and the achievements largely depended on his backing.

The second reason for failure could be the *conflict between economic reform and economic policy*, manifested as inconsistent implementation of a reform, if the objective is greater reliance on the market, or unwillingness to wait long enough for a market mechanism to start functioning. The real point must be that the reform appears to decision-makers to be less important than the immediately pressing economic problems. Moreover, its mechanisms seem less reliable than the traditional solutions that they know will bring acceptable results. Reform may have been accepted as a general policy, but it does not dominate all decisions. The apparent conflict can be reconciled with such phrases as 'the old system has ceased to function but the new one has yet to start working'. Meanwhile, maintaining the familiar objectives of stability and security demands intervention by the centre.

There are many examples of this, especially concerning inflation, unemployment and increasing inequality. Thus in Czechoslovakia in 1967 the government intervened to even out conditions between enterprises after price changes seemed to have given unjustified bonuses to some. In 1969 the post-invasion regime could portray a situation of impending inflationary chaos and reimpose tough central price controls. In Hungary, despite the leadership's continuing verbal commitments to reform, price stability following the oil price rises of 1973 was also given priority: the subsequent increasing dependence on price subsidization contributed significantly to the effective recentralization of the system. Here, in the choice of current policy priorities, as much as in the initial formulation of a reform programme, the regime's ideological predilections become clear.

The third explanation is *widespread popular opposition*, in particular from the working class. Hewett identified this as the central problem, suggesting that security and stability were now regarded by Soviet

workers as 'the gains of socialism that should be preserved as far as possible'. Reforming authorities therefore had to find a way to 'dilute the egalitarian bias of this system . . . without jeopardising the foundations of the party's legitimacy'.¹⁵ Although evidence that Soviet workers have actively frustrated reform efforts is thin, their voices were frequently raised in Czechoslovakia, Poland and Hungary.

Although it is some years since socialism was described as a gain, attitudes have otherwise been similar to those suggested by Hewett. This is hardly surprising as transition to a market will inevitably mean that some lose while some gain. The losers will include those suffering wage reductions and possible unemployment in the traditional heavy and extractive industries, which will probably decline. However, the losers may be to some extent randomly distributed, as the market does not always penalize the least efficient: monopolized markets and the unevenness of price changes have in the past made the emerging distribution patterns appear especially unfair.

Moreover, arguments can always easily be found against one's particular enterprise suffering, not least because its weak position is likely to be due to past decisions taken by the centre. Hence voices are quickly raised suggesting 'we were discriminated against in the old system and we expected a better deal in the new one'. Furthermore, the existing economic structure has left many enterprises with an absolute monopoly in the domestic market, so threats of bankruptcy or closure are relatively easily laughed off.

A more careful analysis of popular attitudes towards economic reform is called for. The two possible sources are opinion polls and actual political activity, both of which point towards approximately the same conclusion for those cases where reforms have really come to the public attention. Poland is the richest source, with frequent indications of support for the general idea of economic reform.¹⁶ However, it is expected above all to solve the most pressing and visible economic difficulties such as queues, shortages and low or falling living standards: this was the clear message of working-class protests from 1980 onwards. The suggestion that reform should entail immediate price increases need not command much support, and such indeed is the history of economic reform up to 1989.

Evidence on the attitudes towards reform as it may affect employees points in generally the same direction. They justify reform by referring to failings in the immediate work environment: the waste of materials, poor organization of work and low levels of effort and commitment. Reform, it is hoped, will rectify this and ensure that those who work well receive adequate rewards. Surveys do not suggest a recognition of the need for

the market as a system of relations throughout the whole economy that might lead to job losses, retraining, substantial changes to work patterns and possible pay cuts.

It may be risky to generalize from Polish experience alone, although the unwillingness of employees to contemplate sacrifices has often been cited in Czechoslovakia and Hungary. This may be exaggerated by those in power, but that makes it no less real: popular uprisings and working-class protests have warned ageing, authoritarian rulers to avoid risks.

The fourth explanation is *opposition from within the economic apparatus*, meaning planning officials and possibly also enterprise managers. Planning officials might be the first to feel their interests threatened and also be the best placed to 'sabotage' unpalatable measures. Enterprise managers, by contrast, have sometimes been seen as potential gainers who might win greater independence and possibly larger bonuses in a less centralized system. Sketchy opinion poll evidence confirms that central planners have had little time for any changes that alter their role. The position of enterprise directors is more complex, depending on whether or not the sector in which they work relies heavily on central subsidies: if it does, that indicates that they have learnt how to work within the old system, and could hardly expect to gain from a move to the market. Those in traditionally less favoured sectors may take a different view.

Pressure for special treatment does not come from management alone. All employees have an interest in the wellbeing of their enterprise and may use any available channel to press their demands, including trade unions, party organizations and local government bodies. One remarkable – and perfectly credible – result from opinion surveys in Poland is that employees often regard enterprise management as their best representative, since it exerts pressure through powerful lobbies demanding subsidies or easier access to labour or materials. This is frequently cited as a reason for the retreat from the market in Hungary in the early 1970s. The same process occurred in Czechoslovakia slightly earlier, with a major difference: in Hungary the leadership was still verbally committed to its past policies and therefore did not exclude reform, whereas in Czechoslovakia centralization was praised as an end to 'indiscipline' in the economy.

This, however, is only part of the problem. The conservative influence of the economic apparatus seems to have been further strengthened when reform attempts failed to ensure the genuine independence of enterprises. This point was made particularly strongly in relation to Hungary's NEM, which retained the old ministerial hierarchies throughout the 1970s; even their later abolition does not invalidate the point that

managers work in state-owned firms and are part of a larger hierarchy. Success and promotion depend on impressing their superiors, which creates strong pressures for maintaining old styles of work.

Perhaps most significant of all is strong evidence that enterprise managers simply do not understand what a market system means. Thus in Czechoslovakia in 1968, despite the relaxation of the relevant controls, enterprises failed to compete vigorously by encroaching on each other's markets:¹⁷ when offered price flexibility they did not use price as a competitive weapon, but simply moved prices to the top of the permitted range. In Poland, too, enterprise managers were said by a leading planning official in the mid-1980s to have equated production for the market with production for export to the West.¹⁸ Opinion surveys confirm this, showing that reform announced from above has had minimal impact on their behaviour. Over time this managerial approach seems ever more rational, as they had learnt that rules are continually being changed and the reforms are usually soon abandoned. The question, then, is not whether someone has been obstructing reform: rather that, for a market system to work, new forms of behaviour and activity are needed if the new structures and formal relationships are to have any meaning.

The fifth and final explanation is the *inadequacy or inconsistency of the reform programmes*. The central issue is whether a 'middle way' between plan and market is possible. Experience suggests that the two are clearly divided. In past reforms, some familiar market features – such as profit as a success indicator – are used in an effort to improve planning, whereas in a true market system enterprises freely take their own decisions and suffer for their mistakes. Whether this is possible without a transition to a fully capitalist system is a separate question: the point here is that inconsistencies always seem to appear during the implementation of a reform which stops well short of a full market. Obstacles force the question of whether the reform should not be developed further. Hewett's picture of implementation encountering problems and culminating in retrenchment is only one option.

Consider Czechoslovakia in the late 1960s, where an initial price reform in 1967 established prices on a cost-plus basis, replacing the almost random previous structure. It quickly emerged that enterprises had manipulated the price formation process in their own interests, and the chosen response was to confiscate some excess profit – in effect, a move towards the old system in which enterprises had minimal financial independence. The alternative would have been to allow the market to determine prices and competition to prevent excessive profits. In 1969, with the problem of unequal profitability reemerging, a capital market was suggested as a means to allow transfer of funds between enterprises

without central intervention. Again, this was rejected in favour of a reimposition of central controls.

This also illustrates the connections among some of the five barriers to reform listed above. The reform programmes, it can be argued, have been theoretically inconsistent and therefore could not be implemented as a complete package. The authorities were therefore confronted with certain choices, and their options reflected their own lack of faith in the market, the primacy they attached to lasting policy objectives such as price stability, their fears of arousing popular opposition and the failure of managers to adopt new forms of behaviour appropriate to a market environment.

This interaction between the five barriers created formidable obstacles to successful economic reform. In fact, the view was often expressed that reform failed because absolutely no social force had a direct interest in its implementation. Even if not everyone stood to lose, even in the short term, practically everyone could have justified grounds for fearing that they might do so. That is the obvious recipe for caution.

Overcoming the Barriers

This apparently static presentation of the barriers to reform does not imply that nobody ever learned from the experiences and developed their ideas. On the contrary, the opponents of reform, especially after the experience of Czechoslovakia in the late 1960s, became for a time still more cautious of any changes and certainly tried to limit their political implications. The supporters, at times narrowed to groups of professional economists, began to identify the barriers and looked for means to overcome them. The key questions were the extent of change required to provide a coherent and practicable package and the links to wider political changes.

The latter issue centres on the possibility, often repeated as virtually a general slogan, that economic reform is possible only if accompanied by thoroughgoing political reform. If this is the case, it should be possible to argue it by reference to the five barriers. The point can be taken in two parts. First, is democracy essential in the form of political pluralism and broadly open politics? The answer is not simple. A freely elected and therefore in principle trusted government might stand more chance of overcoming suspicions and winning commitment to reform measures, since it need not yield to hints of possible discontent over some of the social consequences or to every lobby from large and previously favoured enterprises.

However, past experience is inadequate either to confirm or refute

these expectations. Economic reforms were associated with the removal of old leaderships in Poland in 1956 and 1980 and in Czechoslovakia in 1968, but in no case did it solve the problem. Poland's political changes in 1956 were followed in 1957 by a wave of strikes, largely over wage demands. Public support for Gomułka, at least in his early years, was connected with the expectation that he would provide a rapid improvement in living standards: this proved realistic thanks to economic policy shifts that encouraged consumer goods production. After the events of 1980, the new leadership enjoyed little more trust than its predecessor. In Czechoslovakia in 1968, the immediate effect of Dubček's rise and democracy was to bring into the open lobbying which had previously gone on privately and to give greater scope for groupings of employees to raise wage demands that had lain dormant for years. A popular government's capacity to resist pressures and impose tough conditions for sectors due to decline was not tested because the leadership did not see this as an essential part of the reform programme: instead, it saw democratization as entailing giving a voice to all, and winning popular support. Democratization has no necessary effect unless the government that emerges is fully committed to reform as the basis for other economic policies.

The second aspect of democratic change that has attracted attention is direct democracy in the work-place. This usually centres on elected employees' councils such as emerged in various countries at the end of the Second World War and again in Hungary and Poland in 1956 and in Czechoslovakia in 1968. They typically started as semi-political bodies rather than as a conscious component of a new economic management system, often seen as little more than a means to break the power of the nomenklatura in the economy (sometimes blamed for poor economic performance in general): having removed incompetent managers their task was completed.

When formalized into the notion of self-management, however, this has immediate general appeal, as is repeatedly confirmed by opinion polls. Apart from Yugoslavia, Poland has the most experience with employees' councils, continuing in various forms from 1956 up to the present; however, they have never really lived up to expectations. The problems are threefold. First comes ideologically grounded distrust from traditionalist leaders. The Polish workers' councils were, it seems, deliberately pushed into the background after 1956, by incorporation into a formalized management structure, but it is not clear that this was the most important problem: survey evidence suggests that many employees quickly lost faith in them.¹⁹

Second is the ambiguity of their place as representative organs. Employees seem to want more control over the detailed organization of

work, more bargaining power over wages and a voice in major economic decisions. These are normally the sphere for trade unions, and an additional elected council, lacking the unions' shop-floor network, contributes little if other bodies are functioning properly. Evidence from Yugoslavia fully supports this.²⁰

The third problem is their place within the management system. As has long been argued, if central control over enterprises persists, then local powers are obviously limited. On the other hand, elected representatives of employees cannot take on the full task of management in the complex and fluid conditions of a market, and must settle for some kind of supervisory role. This has been presented as a key to breaking down the existing hierarchies, thereby establishing the enterprise independence for a market to function without private property. It suffers, however, from objections relating both to past experience and to theoretical predictions. The Yugoslav economy's ultimately disappointing performance is obviously no recommendation for self-management, but that country's experience seems to show that such councils may be unable to play a substantial role in controlling management.

These doubts are strengthened by theoretical arguments about the behaviour of firms controlled by their employees. Their interests are not identical to society's and an elected council might, for example, use a firm's assets to pay out massive wages until the business is bankrupt and then go on to work for another. The system might therefore function only following the reimposition of central authority.

It is not clear, then, how far 'democracy' represents a means to overcome the five barriers referred to above. The most comprehensive proposal was the self-managed republic advanced by Solidarity in 1981. Its starting-point was work-place self-management,²¹ originally intended to remove the nomenklatura's power in the economy without running the political risks associated with the complete overthrow of communist power. This was Kuroń's 'self-limiting revolution', which was then broadened with the obvious notion of adding the standard institutions of parliamentary democracy.

The proposal fell short of the full introduction of a market, making no provision for a capital market with the possibility of takeovers, bankruptcies and foreign investment, and embodying no clear understanding of a labour market. Solidarity, a trade union and mass movement with over nine million members, opposed unemployment and price increases without which a genuine market could not possibly operate.

Despite the banning of Solidarity, the 1980s saw renewed attempts at economic reform stimulated by the continuing poor performance. The leaderships in Poland and (even more clearly) in Hungary tried to take

positive lessons from past experience, and 'reform' became central to their faith in their own ability to overcome the crises engulfing them. They were prepared, albeit reluctantly for a time, to do virtually anything short of abandoning political power. By the time communist rule ended, both countries had seen attempts to break down the old hierarchies by giving substantial powers to employees' councils and by various forms of reorganization that could be presented as 'privatization'. Poland's last communist-dominated government even set about closing some large loss-makers and took the decisive step of freeing food prices. The Round Table talks with the opposition in 1989, which eventually led to the ending of communist power, were initially intended to persuade the opposition to share responsibility for unpopular economic measures.

Generally, however, the Polish and Hungarian leaderships continued to display indecisiveness and helplessness in the face of circumstances. They still yielded, at various times throughout the 1980s, to popular fears and to large sectoral lobbies. Polish reform proposals were very clearly based on a compromise with firm opponents of the market,²² and offered no vision of a way out of the crisis. The governments could not command the popular trust necessary for tough measures and that lack of trust was amplified by their inability to implement the economic reforms that they were advocating as essential. The result was an impression of helplessness that, by the end of the decade, had spread demoralization into the hearts of the two regimes.

Economic Reform after the Communists

The removal of communist governments in 1989 and 1990 has been followed by sweeping economic changes.²³ The German Democratic Republic, incorporated into a larger German economy, has been exposed to the full force of the market with immediately catastrophic results for much of its industry. Poland and Czechoslovakia have embarked on strategies for rapid transition to the market, embracing almost complete price liberalization, freeing of imports, partial currency convertibility and IMF-style stabilization policies. These are to be followed as quickly as possible by large-scale privatization which may involve the free distribution of vouchers to the public to be exchanged for shares. Hungary, already further down the road before 1989, has elected a government with little economic expertise which has acted less decisively, opting for a more gradual strategy. The results so far must be judged an outstanding success in having eliminated the queues and shortages of the past decades, but they must be judged a failure in terms of improving some other aspects of economic performance. Figures for Czechoslovakia,

TABLE 1
ECONOMIC PERFORMANCE IN 1990
(Percentage changes on previous year)

	Poland	Hungary	Czechoslovakia
National income	-13	-5	-3.5
Industrial output	-23	-10	-4
Consumer prices	600	30	10

Source: Economist Intelligence Unit Quarterly Reports

Poland and Hungary illustrate the extent of the drop in production and the accompanying inflation (see Table 1). Czechoslovakia seems to have done better, but figures for 1991 could show a drop of up to 25 per cent in industrial output, while the decline is continuing in the other countries too. To some extent this has been exacerbated by a collapse in trade with the USSR, but it nevertheless raises serious questions about the policies adopted.

In several respects the strategy of rapid transition is a reaction to the failure of past reforms. The inconsistency of previous attempts, and the tendency to adopt specific policy measures that conflict with the philosophy of reform, are being overcome by a deliberately uncompromising programme of putting transition to the market first. Active opposition or obstruction within the economic apparatus remains, but it is no longer necessary to play a careful game of compromising with old structures: recalcitrant officials can now be removed.

The possibility of popular opposition, especially from the working class, is countered by the attempt to be uncompromising and also by the attempt at the maximum of speed: it is hoped that irreversible changes can be in place before 'social demagogues' can arouse working-class opposition. Within the population at large, however, there is a quite remarkable willingness to accept price changes (to eliminate subsidies) and cuts in living standards that seemed unthinkable only a few years ago. Moreover, judging by strong protests at petrol price increases in Budapest in October 1990, this willingness seems greater in Poland and Czechoslovakia than in Hungary.

The key to popular acceptance in the two countries following the fastest option has been the unequivocal statement of a definite target: the market system as understood and observed in advanced West European countries. It has been hinted that this can be achieved reasonably quickly. Ideas of a 'third way', the most ambitious target for all previous reform attempts, are firmly rejected. There is, it is argued, no need to indulge in further risky experiments when a manifestly better system already exists.

Moreover, this economic philosophy ties the economic transition firmly into the wider process of dismantling the old system and 'returning to Europe', part of the political evolutionary process.

The extent of public trust should not be exaggerated, however. Opinion polls, and even election results, show considerable disillusionment: opinion polls in Slovakia in May 1991 even suggested an outright majority for a coalition of 'don't knows' and 'won't votes' while the ruling coalition had the support of under ten per cent. This disillusionment, however, has yet to be articulated into a coherent opposition to press for a slower transition strategy.

Nevertheless, the economic transformation has become a major complicating factor in creating a stable political structure. It has been very widely assumed that development would lead to the automatic emergence of a Left against Right (or Christian Democrat against Social Democrat) division, which is assumed to be normal in Western Europe. In fact, this is not the universal pattern in advanced countries, and such divisions are gradually breaking down to make way for new alignments. Political life in Eastern Europe may also be expected to be more chaotic since the only established mass parties are the former ruling ones.

Indeed, problems in the process of economic transformation influence the development of the new political system by retarding the consolidation of firm socio-political groupings. In particular, the chosen method of transition in those countries that have adopted the fastest option is inconsistent in economic terms and not easily harmonized with other aspects of the process of dismantling the communist system. It is based on an assumption that it is relatively easy to create a market system that will then function broadly on its own, the one key step being the elimination of inherited central controls. This simple view derives directly from the notion, familiar in neo-classical economic theory, of a market operating outside any but the most rudimentary of institutional environments. It is, however, a valid description of modern capitalism only at a very high level of abstraction. In reality, advanced market economies are based on a long history of evolution during which large, well-organized, management-controlled corporations have grown to positions of dominance. They depend, moreover, on substantial state intervention, albeit quite different in nature from that encountered under central planning.

This could be related to the fourth barrier to economic reform: there may be little opposition from within the apparatus, but neither have new forms of behaviour appropriate to the market environment emerged spontaneously within established enterprises. Indeed, under the restrictive macro-economic conditions that are an essential part of 'stabilization' policies, firms may not have the necessary means to search out new

opportunities. They teeter on the brink of bankruptcy and beg for state support, behaving very much as they did under the old system.

Hopes of a rapid and spontaneous economic recovery once conditions for the market have been created are therefore illusory. The process of creating a market takes far longer than initially hoped and the disappointments must lead to disillusionment. So far, however, this disillusionment has strengthened the Right rather than the Left, encouraging 'market demagoguery' rather than 'social demagoguery'. The obvious example is Wałęsa's presidential election campaign in November 1990, based on the slogan of 'acceleration'. In practical terms this meant faster privatization, but the new government has been unable substantially to change either policies or the economy's performance.

The mismatch with wider aspects of the social transformation relates in particular to hopes for social justice. Despite Hewett's view, the communist past is not widely perceived as a time when egalitarianism, or even security, took priority over efficiency: a more common view today is that claims to social justice were just another sham, and the new system, it is hoped, will be more just as well as more efficient. To many on the right, impressed by the ideas of Hayek or Milton Friedman, this need present no dilemma.²⁴ They have convinced themselves that the freest market provides the most efficient, most morally acceptable and even most egalitarian system (even though this is difficult to reconcile with West European experience). Eastern Europe is, in fact, experiencing considerable pressure for better pensions and minimum wages above the subsistence level, and there is also deep concern over unemployment. So far this has risen much more slowly than output has dropped (reaching, for example, only 2.5 per cent of the Czechoslovak labour force in mid-1991 while industrial output was down 20 per cent on the previous year's level), and, despite governments' claims to toughness, there has yet to be a major enterprise closure.

The implications of these economic factors for the emerging political structures can be summarized around the development of five vaguely defined tendencies. The first, the 'hard right', who want to press ahead to the market with the utmost speed, is best exemplified by Czechoslovakia's finance minister Vaclav Klaus and to a much lesser extent by Leszek Balcerowicz in Poland. Klaus believes that this target can be reached soon, so there is no need for a separate transition period with a distinct approach to policy; instead, it is just a matter of eliminating central controls and subsidies while maintaining macro-economic stability. Poor results are associated, they argue, with a tardy pace of change, and are best overcome by creating a strong and clearly-defined right-wing party: the approach has won the epithet of 'Thatcherite

Leninism', and there is some analogy with the Stalinist approach in the early 1950s which saw all obstacles in the failure to eliminate vestiges of capitalism. Klaus's approach is assured of support – opinion polls give his Civic Democratic Party up to 20 per cent of the vote – not least because it appears as the most consistent rejection of the hesitancy and inconsistency of past reforms. There is, however, no firm social base for such a party. One frequent claim is that a new 'middle class' – understood in the traditional sense of owners of small businesses or shares – will be created very swiftly by rapid privatization. That is proving a slower process than originally hoped, however.

The second tendency can be characterized as 'soft right', or possibly 'centre'. The philosophy here is to reach a full market system, but with the widest possible consensus, carrying forward the broad traditions of the former opposition in harmony with the policies required to overcome the barriers to reform. It could smack of a repeat of past weaknesses, especially of Hungary's NEM, in which the search for universal acceptability led to economic inconsistency. Most representatives of this 'centre' position are in fact fairly silent on economic issues.

There are some surprising common features with Wałęsa's 'right populist' demagoguery – clearly a response to popular disappointment over economic performance – and with some of the statements of the Liberal Democratic Congress of the Polish Prime Minister Bielecki. They are firmly pro-capitalist – indeed, their faith is so immense that they believe it can be introduced with almost universal social acceptance. The corner stone is the hope that privatization can be rapid and spread ownership very widely, while more painful adjustments are postponed. Thus, paradoxically, some of the firmest believers in the market can actually bend towards a 'soft' position, and perhaps win popularity, at least temporarily.

The label of 'left' is typically avoided in Eastern Europe at present, so the fourth tendency is best described as 'interventionist'. It holds that the government cannot evade social responsibility, environmental policies, support for agriculture and the selection of certain enterprises for state support. Various groupings that have emerged out of Solidarity in Poland put this view, as do some of the smaller parties in Czechoslovakia. The Right typically responds by arguing that advocates of *any* state intervention are yielding to sectoral interests and thereby repeating mistakes of past reform efforts. In their view, the first and only task is to create the market system. It is summed up in Klaus's slogan of a 'market economy without adjectives': in particular he objects to notions of a 'social market economy' which he sees as another attempt at 'squaring the circle' by combining two irreconcilable concepts.²⁵

In fact, although there is considerable support for the interventionist

approach from threatened sectors, it does not necessarily mean 'softness' in social terms: even Czechoslovakia's trade unions have accepted the need for cuts in living standards, but they do not believe that current market signals are an adequate basis for deciding which enterprises have long-term prospects and which should be left to close. They argue forcefully that in advanced countries the state has not opted out of economic activity.

The final tendency to be considered has been given the awkward title of 'post-communist'.²⁶ Support, when set against past claims to a monopoly of power, is derisory. Votes of nearly ten per cent in Poland's presidential election, of 13 per cent in Czechoslovakia and 8.5 per cent in Hungary suggest, however, that communists have retained support beyond those most directly tied to the old regimes. Solid backing comes especially from some pensioners as well as former high officials and some workers in industries threatened with decline. In terms of economic policy, post-communist parties start by accusing the firmest advocates of the market of dogmatism. Specific targets are privatization by the distribution of vouchers to the public, to be exchanged for shares, and by restoring property to former owners or their heirs. Some sophisticated economists remain loyal to the communist tradition and they are generally working towards the notion of a gradual transition, lasting perhaps ten years, to a system based on political pluralism, self-management and a relatively slow pace of privatization. One trouble is that, given the present strength of anti-communist feeling, nobody wants to unite with them.

Where Will It Lead?

The relationship between economic changes and political evolution is clearly complex and unstable over time. At times economic reforms were a product of political changes. Occasionally economic reforms were a more active factor in political developments, but not the main one. The 1980s, however, saw a major shift in the relationship in the two key countries of Poland and Hungary. Economic reform, the concern of a narrow group of professional economists, and possibly the bogey of some leaders, became the central plank in party policy. The failure of those reforms was virtually inevitable and contributed substantially to the final process of decay in those countries' power structures.

The ending of communist rule has changed the significance of various barriers to reform identified in the earlier period, and altered the relationship between economic change and political evolution. For the moment, those countries pursuing the most vigorous pro-market strategy can do so because of the political support for dismantling the old system.

Its failures are seen to be economic as much as anything else, but support for government policies does not imply a deep understanding of what is being proposed or of the likely consequences.

An early economic recovery is unlikely and falling living standards and rising unemployment are more probable. In this situation it is extremely difficult for stable political formations to appear. The right-wing economists, dominating much of current policy, are not fulfilling their promises. They are not threatened by the traditional Left, which is divided, uncertain and open to the accusation of not being anti-communist enough. Concessions to a more interventionist approach may be needed, but there is also a strong threat from others with right-wing credentials willing to make demagogic claims about the possibility of a rapid and painless transition.

NOTES

1. Michael Ellman, *Socialist Planning* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1978), p.257.
2. Michael Ellman, *Socialist Planning*, 2nd edn. (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press), p.311.
3. For a damning condemnation from one time cautious critics, see Włodzimierz Brus and Kazimierz Laski, *From Marx to the Market: Socialism in Search of an Economic System* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1989).
4. For evidence from Poland, see Mieczysław Mieszcankowski and L.Pawlicki, 'Kto w Polsce dużo zarabia', *Zycie Gospodarcze*, 1989, No.18, p.7.
5. Numerous accounts exist of the problems of central planning and of attempts to overcome them. As good as any are Alec Nove, *The Soviet Economic System* (London: Allen & Unwin, 1977), and Alec Nove, *The Economics of Feasible Socialism* (London: Allen & Unwin, 1983). For details on Hungary's NEM see Paul Hare, Nigel Swain and Hugo Radice (eds.), *Hungary: A Decade of Economic Reform* (London: Allen & Unwin, 1981). and Xavier Richet, *The Hungarian Model: Markets and Planning in a Socialist Economy* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1989).
6. See Brus and Laski, *From Marx to the Market*; for Hayek's view see F.A. Hayek (ed.) *Collectivist Economic Planning* (London: Routledge, 1935).
7. For an account see Michael Kaser (ed.), *The Economic History of Eastern Europe 1919-1975* (5 vols, Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1985-), Vol.III.
8. Alec Nove, *The Economics of Feasible Socialism*.
9. This view has been argued convincingly over the years by the Hungarian economist Janos Kornai and is repeated in his *Vision and Reality, Market and State* (Budapest: Corvina, 1990).
10. Ed Hewett, *Reforming the Soviet Economy: Equality versus Efficiency* (Washington, DC: Brookings, 1988).
11. For details see Martin Myant, *The Czechoslovak Economy 1948-1988: The Battle for Economic Reform* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1989), Chs. 8 and 10.
12. Wiesława Kozek, *Reformy gospodarcze a społeczeństwo* (Warsaw: Wydawnictwo Uniwersytetu Warszawskiego, 1989), Ch. 1.
13. See the discussion with Józef Pajestka in *Polityka*, 1985, No.35. Kozek, *Reformy*, pp.85-7, discusses Gomułka's position in relation to the economic apparatus.
14. For details see Judy Batt, *Economic Reform and Political Change in Eastern Europe* (London: Macmillan, 1988), pp.126-32.

15. Hewett, *Reforming the Soviet Economy*, pp. 49 and 3.
16. Kozek, *Reformy* contains details of an enormous number of surveys and is used extensively in this article. Some information is available in English: see, for example, James McGregor, 'Economic Reform and Polish Public Opinion', *Soviet Studies*, Vol. XLI, No. 1 (1989), pp. 215–27.
17. Myant, *The Czechoslovak Economy*, Ch. 6.
18. Franciszek Kubiczek, 'O drugim etapie reformy gospodarczej', *Gospodarka Planowana*, Vol. XLII (1987), p. 283.
19. Martin Myant, *Poland: A Crisis for Socialism* (London: Lawrence & Wishart, 1982), pp. 71–6. For more complete accounts see Witold Morawski, *Samorząd robotniczy w gospodarce socjalistycznej* (Warsaw, 1973) and Maria Jarosz, *Samorządność pracownicza: Aspiracje i rzeczywistość* (Warsaw: Książka i Wiedza, 1988).
20. As confirmed in the best account in English, Ellen Turkish Comisso, *Workers' Control under Plan and Market* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1979), and in numerous Yugoslav sources.
21. Myant, *Poland*, pp. 189–211.
22. Martin Myant, 'Poland – The Permanent Crisis?', in Roger A. Clarke (ed.), *Poland: The Economy in the 1980s* (London: Longman, 1989), pp. 6–17.
23. Major sources for what follows have been the daily and weekly press in Czechoslovakia and Poland and the quarterly reports on those countries produced by the *Economist Intelligence Unit*.
24. For the most forceful statement see Milton Friedman, *Capitalism and Freedom* (Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press, 1962).
25. *Lidove noviny*, 21 March 1991.
26. Apart from ideological issues about the nature of 'communism' that complicate the use of 'post-communism', in Czechoslovakia the party has yet to drop its old title.

Groups, Interests and Political Aggregation in East Central Europe

MICHAEL WALLER

The political systems of East Central Europe are still subject to the flux arising from the fall of the communist regimes. It is taking time for clear constituencies to emerge with coherent leaderships in a stable network of autonomous political activity. But certain forms of organization dating from the gestation period have been influential. First, the structures of the communist period have in some cases developed an autonomous role. Secondly, a series of major aggregating forces emerged in the 'forum' movements. Creatures of the transition period, they have had a strong influence in setting the stage for later developments. Thirdly, the end of the communist monopoly led to the emergence of clubs and circles often of a libertarian kind, reflecting the generational factor in the process of change. Finally, the circumstances of flux have allowed to emerge, or re-emerge, strong religious, ethnic and regional identities.

A great many terms have been generated over the years to describe the complex political, economic and social system of Stalinism. Now that the system is collapsing, one particular but deceptively simple aspect of it is emerging into a very clear light – its monopolistic character. This study analyses the collapse of that monopoly in East Central Europe, and the development of autonomous forms of political association and aggregation in the region.

In the discussion the term 'East Central Europe' will be used to cover collectively Poland, Czechoslovakia, the GDR and Hungary. References will also be made to Bulgaria and Yugoslavia and Soviet experience will be invoked where it aids an understanding of events in East Central Europe.

From Monopoly to Marketplace

The communist power monopoly, which collapsed so spectacularly in East Central Europe in 1989, was both economic and political. Moreover, the two were clearly and closely linked.

Michael Waller is Senior Lecturer in Government at the University of Manchester; his latest book is *Comrades and Brothers: Communism and Trade Unions in Europe* (1990), edited with Stéphane Courtois and Marc Lazar.

It is not a matter in this case of Western commentators fixing on the Soviet-type systems a terminology of their own making, nor of left-wing critics reminding the practitioners of communism of their Marxist credentials. Soviet spokesmen themselves now focus on monopoly, in both economic and political life, as the major cause of their present woes. In a *Pravda* article in 1990, Vadim Medvedev quoted Weber to the effect that

the gathering into the state's hands of the means of production inevitably leads to the bureaucratization of the economic sphere and to a 'dictatorship of the state official' ... The processes of monopolization of property and power in our country have gone hand in hand, encouraging and stimulating each other.¹

It is admittedly a little less simple to justify analysing in terms of a marketplace the new structures that are emerging from the rubble of the crisis of the Stalinist system. Common usage endorses the extension of the metaphor of monopoly more easily than that of the marketplace from the economic to the political realm. And yet in point of fact the whole discussion of reform in the east of Europe has from an early day had to accommodate a parallelism between economic and political decentralization, a parallelism that was perhaps at its clearest in the debates in the Czechoslovak reform movement that led to the Prague Spring. More recently Abel Aganbegyan put the point forcefully by saying that 'economic reform can succeed if it includes all sectors of the economy, and can only work if the whole of society is democratized'.² Nor has attention to this parallelism been the concern of commentators on socialist development alone. In the literature of the 1970s not only were theorists of socialism such as Włodzimierz Brus and Eduard Kardelj analysing the reform process in terms of both economic and political decentralization, but S.E. Finer also was pointing out, in the context of West European political economy, that 'it is helpful to consider the capitalist economy as one in which economic management (so-called *free enterprise*) is nothing else than a very highly decentralized form of public administration'.³

A second reason for resorting to a terminology of the marketplace is suggested by the direction that events took in the bloc countries during the actual process of the communist party's collapse. As the party's control weakened, and the forces opposing it consequently were placed in a position where they could cash in organizationally on their successes to date, there was a tendency for those forces to present themselves as 'forums' (Civic Forum, Democratic Forum, New Forum), and as centres around which discussion and support could gather. In historical terms it has of course been one of the functions of the marketplace, *forum* or

agora, to serve as a locus for discussion and debate. This view of the marketplace emphasizes community and discussion, and therefore is less concerned with sectional interests and preferences. As a matter of fact, those 'forums' of the early transition period did not last long in their original form. They succumbed to the electoral process once it had been set up, since it structured political action and the relationship between political action and discussion in a different way. But their period of influence was an important one: they served to show that the move from the power monopoly was not only towards choice, but towards voice too.

The emergence of a political market place in the east of Europe cannot properly be analysed without at least a minimal presentation of the key features of the monopoly that it was replacing. Since the Stalinist system has been so fully picked over and so variously described, only the barest skeleton of the political power monopoly that it has involved need be given here, and the emphasis will be on those of its features that best highlight the predicaments involved in the process of change. Only in this way can the true nature of the transition that has taken place be sensitively portrayed.

First, the monopoly of economic power, articulated through the system of central command planning and through centrally administered supplies and prices, needs no further word, although Gorbachev's ability to bring an errant Lithuanian leadership to heel by the simple expedient of turning off the oil supply at its central and effectively only source may be offered as a graphic illustration of the economic monopoly.

A second cardinal feature of the power monopoly is equally familiar: the control that the ruling party has exercised through its apparatus, two functions of which have been of particular salience. Through the *nomenklatura* the central leadership has been able to control appointments, including appointment as representative or delegate to deliberative and law-making bodies, whilst through its propaganda function the party's apparatus has been able to control information flows and the entire realm of communications. These functions of the apparatus lie at the heart of what has familiarly come to be known as the 'leading role of the party'.

A third feature of the power monopoly is perhaps less familiar. It has an economic dimension – autarky – which in turn has generated a political dimension in the closed frontier and an obsession with borders.

Recent events have revealed how important a part of the power monopoly is vested in autarky and a closed frontier. They constitute the dam that has held the monopoly in place as a system. Competition from abroad in terms of both goods and ideas was to be kept out, through a monopoly of foreign trade and a monopoly over the means of communication, whilst trained manpower, which is being paid at rates determined

by the power monopoly and not by an international market, was to be kept in.

The fourth and final feature of the power monopoly is for the present exposition the most important, in that it has provided the ideological bonding for the other three features and has proved to be one of the biggest obstacles to the development of the autonomous expression of interests and political preferences until well into the transition period. This is the collectivist psychology associated with the 'Leninist principle of democratic centralism'. Democratic centralism, which is often seen as a practical guide to action, is in fact much more usefully seen as a particular way of thinking about social, political and economic relationships. It concerns the image of its role in society that the party has presented and the pattern of social relations that it has fostered through its control over the means of communication. It is an image that promotes and justifies the power monopoly; it justifies also the mechanisms that have held the monopoly in place. What results therefore is a closed system – which, of course, is what has given that system its monopolistic character.

Central to the orthodox theory of democratic centralism has been a notion of organic unity, that a house divided against itself will fall, that the ranks must be closed to prevent the enemy slipping through, that discussion breeds disunity and saps the efficacy of the political and social organism. It is all-embracing, and – so long as the ruling party can sustain it – all-powerful. It renders any distinction between the economic and the political monopoly irrelevant, simply by reducing the value of choice, autonomous competition and even initiative in whatever realm. There is presented a single, collective social interest, and one single collective voice should speak for it. Elections cannot involve choice, but must consecrate the unity of the people around the collective national spokesman.

Taken together, these components of the power monopoly constituted a structure that was in one sense extremely strong, whilst being in another very vulnerable. It has led to a starvation of the information necessary for the sensitive functioning of an advanced industrial society, with a resultant tendency to oversteering on the part of the holders of the monopoly.⁴ The isolation of the leadership group has led also to inflexibility: change was delayed until crisis occurred, at which point it occurred abruptly.⁵ The choking off of information enabled the leadership to conceal the symptoms of impending crisis from society, and thus, effectively, from itself. 'We communists', said Kardelj

must pose the question of how ... we can overcome the historical

practice ... under which every political change imposed by the course of events in a socialist state, be it a change of government or of political policies, is always attended by political disturbances reminiscent of a coup d'état.⁶

No choice in the economy, then, no voice in politics, a requirement of loyalty to the social organism and to its privileged spokesman, and strictly no exit.⁷ Politics, in an important sense, was ruled out: 'What communism did was to erode all social structures in the community, to abolish all social groups. In place it left a kind of amorphism. On account of this politics – at least as it is understood in other parts of the world – was ruled out.'⁸

Such was the communist power monopoly that succumbed so spectacularly in the countries of the Soviet bloc in 1989. Its collapse in Poland, the GDR, Hungary, Czechoslovakia, Bulgaria and Romania was, of course, abrupt, the political monopoly of the ruling party in all those countries being surrendered during the single year 1989. Certain symbolic events heightened that sense of rupture and of a cataclysmic collapse of communism, punctuating the end of a system, and suggesting the dawn of a new era. Four demands of that hectic period had a particular symbolic salience, and early steps were taken to give them effect. The first was that the constitutional guarantee of the party's leading role be rescinded; the second that an end be put to the practice whereby the party's organization was based on the workplace; the third was the abolition of the party's militia; and the fourth was an endorsement of the ideas of the Prague Spring. These may seem minor events when compared with the formation of a non-communist government in Poland (12 September 1989), or the conversion of the Hungarian Socialist Workers' Party into the Hungarian Socialist Party (7 October 1989), or the resignation or dismissal of individual leaders and political bureaus in Bulgaria, the GDR, Czechoslovakia and Romania. But they were highly symbolic events which were seen by society as being of particular importance in the undoing of the power monopoly. However vague and contradictory were proposals for what might replace the party's monopoly, these demands were crystal clear and utterly specific.

These highly symbolic demands were given a pre-eminent priority by the people who were actually taking part in these epic events. History, however, is likely to settle on a different series of events as the key turning-point in the dismantling of the communist monopoly. It is a major part of the argument of this study that this dismantling was a much more drawn-out process than is generally thought. The signing of the Helsinki accords in 1975 was no doubt not seen by the Eastern European sig-

natories as binding them to very much in real terms. Neither for them nor for the historian can those accords be taken to mark the birth or rebirth of pluralism in the east of Europe. They nevertheless constituted a small but significant early step in a constitutional process that was indeed, over the years, to replace the communist power monopoly with the beginnings of a pluralist system in most of the countries of the region. The process had something in common with the secession of the plebs at the dawn of constitutional order of republican Rome. Solidarity in Poland, Charter 77 in Czechoslovakia, and the Evangelical churches in the GDR, were unable to challenge the state; but in the new circumstances ushered in by the Helsinki process, and even more so by *perestroika* in the Soviet Union, they could make constitutional gains by withholding their support from the regime and by developing a parallel political base which could at least avail itself of a tribunician voice.

In this line of argument the registration of Solidarity in November 1980 was a major turning point; but the constitutional process was a gradual and fitful one. Solidarity had to fight that constitutional battle anew after a period of enforced clandestinity, and it was not until the round table discussions and other tractations of 1989, and after wringing a host of other juridical concessions from the ruling parties of the region, that the constitutional groundwork was truly laid that would make the establishment of a pluralist system possible, even if it did not guarantee that outcome.

In comment on that story of democratization, both within the societies affected and without, attention has focused naturally enough on the establishment of an electoral system and on the formation of political parties. In what follows, however, a much broader lens is used – one that will enable the development of autonomous political parties to be set in a wider perspective. For, long before the cardinal year of 1989, there had developed in East Central Europe a process of articulation and aggregation of political preferences that prepared the way for the changes that were to come, probably did much to ensure the remarkable peacefulness of those changes, and provided the counter-elites that were to take over from the discredited communist leaderships.

A Group Analysis of Change in Eastern Europe

In the Western world's discussion of democracy and of pluralism, political parties and pressure groups are presented as the central modes of political representation and of popular participation in politics. Students of politics learn about democracy with reference to these institutions,

which conveniently lie around them as part of the abiding furniture of a world with which they have grown to be familiar. In most West European societies political parties have often had a remarkably long life, whilst a whole literature of corporatism has been built around government's relations with interest groups which are fixtures in the political system. The notion of 'consultative status' conveys this fact, relying as it does on permanence of implantation and all the trappings of bureaucracy.

That is, the analyst of liberal democratic politics is rarely faced with a situation of flux, where the boundaries between party, movement and interest group are indistinct and where a stable relationship between clearly defined elites and equally well delineated constituencies is the exception rather than the rule. But the politics of the East Central European countries today is marked by just such a state of flux. The transition that we have been witnessing has thrown up problems of semantics common to such periods of social and political change. The contrasts between the communist monopoly and pluralism had already created problems of this sort for the analyst of communism – problems that lay at the heart of the discussion of the extent to which communist political systems have been *sui generis*.⁹ Attempts at analysing the politics of communist countries in terms of interests, or indeed of pluralism itself, although associated with some of the greater names of the literature, ran into constant difficulties over the years before *perestroika*.¹⁰

With communism in retreat these difficulties have not abated. If anything they have increased – certainly as far as the transition period is concerned. The discussion on dissent in Eastern Europe, for example, resisted a treatment in terms of resource mobilization, or at least few were prepared to undertake the exercise, preferring a very general (far too general, as we now see) discussion in terms of civil society and the state.¹¹ But the latter could be only the beginning of analysis, not its end, since civil society by its nature is politically differentiated, and the development of a discourse to cope with that differentiation – or *process of differentiation* in the present case – remained a task to be undertaken.

In view of this problem a treatment of the transition has to go deeper than the labels that are attributed to current institutions and organizations, and to analyse in very basic terms the process of political association that we have been witnessing. We have to help us in this exercise the work of Arthur Bentley, *The Process of Government*, described by its author as 'an attempt to fashion a tool'.¹² This work dates from 1908, and could be called seminal were it not for the fact that the seeds fell mostly on the stony ground of a tradition of political analysis tailored to a pluralist world where parties and interest groups existed in an already established and institutionalized form. Bentley was concerned less with the anatomy

of an established system than with an analysis of political activity. His insights have a particular salience in the present conjuncture in the east of Europe, where the analyst has to deal with flux, and where existing labels do not necessarily make a clear reference.

Bentley, it will be recalled, insisted on the dynamic of the group process, equating the interest with the group, and thus deliberately privileging activity at the expense of structure: 'If we say activity we have said all.'¹³ For Bentley it was the interest that constituted the group; and politics was a process in movement.

Some such view is needed in dealing with change in Eastern Europe. As the Bulgarian Dimitrina Petrova put it in early 1991: 'The status quo at this moment is not the totalitarian "system" any more. It is a fluid state of change – an open "dynamis quo".'¹⁴ Consider the evolution of Civic Forum in Czechoslovakia. It had its origins in Charter 77 in a political system where the possibilities for the autonomous formation of groups were ruled out. The Charter was never strictly an organization, beyond the three spokesmen and the list of signatories. It is difficult even to speak of it as articulating an interest, as opposed to a set of general political preferences (a distinction, be it said in passing, with which Bentley has no difficulty).¹⁵ Yet, as we shall see, it performed an aggregating role that was to be highly influential in the political drama that was unfolding. Civic Forum and its Slovak counterpart, Public Against Violence, were its continuation in the brief period surrounding the collapse of the communist power monopoly, when politics was reduced to a simple confrontation between two protagonists: Civic Forum and Public Against Violence on the one hand, and the Communist Party of Czechoslovakia on the other. Success in that confrontation once assured, Civic Forum then found itself faced with a choice: to retain its character as a movement or to enter the electoral lists as a political party. The debates and anxieties to which such a choice gave rise were then carried forward after the elections, as what had once been a single movement with a single aim began to separate into rival organizational strands with rival leaderships. Moreover, it was a process that was being acted out in a somewhat similar way by Solidarity in Poland at very much the same time.

Given the mobility of the situation, and the evolution of the political roles of the collective actors involved in it, there is a good deal to be said for using primarily a terminology of groups, and for regarding the assigning of institutional and structural labels as secondary.

The process of change, moreover, and the emergence of new political forces, often of inchoate form, had the effect of loosening some of the organizational straightjackets of the communist system. It breathed life into certain hitherto ossified structures, and it enabled group interests

that had up to that point been concealed behind the smokescreen of democratic centralism to expand on a public stage. In what follows we shall be encountering many examples: the mass organizations of the communist period, some of which took on a semi-autonomous role in the final months of communist power; the trade unions; the satellite parties; the administrative and economic bureaucracies; the scientific institutes and communities; the communist parties themselves (and their institutionalized apparatuses); and the new political parties that a free electoral process produced by the simple fact of being in operation.

In sum, it must be acknowledged that the flux was by no means total, and that the transfer of power did not dissolve existing structures. The changed political possibilities did, however, have a profound effect on the input side of the political process, as the opportunities for voice to replace an enforced loyalty were being fought for, won, and consolidated. It is here that a dynamic view of the group process such as that held by Bentley is valuable.

The Process of Group Formation

The raw material of the process of group formation and activity in the east of Europe from 1975 can now be examined. The date of 1975 is chosen for convenience. It would follow from the arguments presented here that the signing of the Helsinki Agreements, and all that followed from it in terms of the development of dissent in East Central Europe, were but milestones on a long road of change leading from a truer watershed of 1956. But during the years from 1975 to 1989 certain processes of political aggregation took place that were to qualify, and ultimately to replace, the communist power monopoly. These will be examined in this section.

Before going on to describe how new facilities for autonomous political activity were to open up in East Central Europe, it is important to record certain elements of autonomy that the communist political system did tolerate, and to an extent in fact depended upon for its functioning, before the period which most concerns us – that is, the period from the mid-1970s.

First of all, *the power monopoly was from the start leaky*. Just as black markets qualified the monopoly in the economy, so political networks of mutual protection formed, often as a means whereby local leaders in various power structures could make common cause against the political centre. These cliques and mafias were part of the pathology of communist politics, but they were none the less cases of political aggregation. They extended to include clientelist relationships at all levels, up to major

informal factions at the very centre of the political structure. Power within the monopoly has thus been oligarchically distributed.

Secondly, the power monopoly has accommodated oligarchy in another form: the *vested interests of the major bureaucracies of state and party*. It is not only the administrative bureaucracies that have been involved. Research institutes and professional groups have generated departmental views or *schools of thought* which have become part of the policy-making process. This has been partly a developmental matter. The birth of a public opinion had to await the coming of *glasnost* in the Soviet Union, and the great year of 1989 in East Central Europe. But in all these societies *expert opinion* has been much freer to develop throughout the region, and in its development it has functioned in the political arena in group form. It is important to point this out, since it has been one of the growth points for democratization across the region, including in the Soviet Union, and we shall return to it below.

Thirdly, the communist power monopoly has in some cases seen fit, or been led, to tolerate *organized rival centres of cultural, and therefore potentially political, power*. The incidence of this factor has varied from country to country. The case of the Catholic church in Poland has long been clear enough; but from 1978, on the GDR's Socialist Unity Party was prepared to countenance an enhanced role for the Evangelical churches, which soon acquired a marked political character.

Even more pregnant for future developments was the autonomy that national groups had in many cases succeeded in carving out for themselves long before the coming of *perestroika*. This had developed in Yugoslavia to the point where rivalry between the national republics became the stuff of political life. A degree of autonomy in a federal state remained as a permanent gain for the Slovaks after the other advances of the Prague Spring had been clawed back. In a celebrated article, Teresa Rakowska-Harmstone showed in 1974 how the constituent republics of the Soviet Union, simply by being endowed with formal governmental institutions, had managed to at least hold their own against Moscow, while less institutionally protected groups were facing assimilation.¹⁶

On this reading of the situation, the nationality problems that Gorbachev has had to face, not to mention those that confront Yugoslavia, have grown out of a long-standing development.

These examples of groups, organized or less so, that were able to play a role in politics often long before the period that chiefly concerns us are adduced to show, first, that the political monopoly did in fact secrete a degree of group activity, even if its autonomy at that stage was eclipsed by the party's monopoly; and secondly, that the process of change, when it came, had something to build on. There is a contradiction between these

considerations and the equally important fact that the power monopoly not only characteristically resisted group autonomy, but was unable to react to pressures for change. The break in European history constituted by the period from Gorbachev's accession to power in 1985 and the fall of the communist regimes in Eastern Europe in 1989 therefore has two aspects. On the one hand it clearly was a rupture, which was sudden in its incidence. On the other hand, the pressures that the communist power holders shut their eyes to, and pretended did not exist, did in fact exist, and had accumulated lethal power. The rupture was a long time gestating, just as it is taking a long time for a new order to settle into place.

It is with this gestation that we are here concerned, and in order to pursue it further we must turn to more recent manifestations of group activity in the countries of the area during the 'heroic' period, defined here as that from 1975 to 1989. These will be presented under three heads: group activity within the system (and thus a continuation of the more long-standing examples presented above); the 'forum' or 'milieu' movements which aggregated and channelled the popular attack on the communist power monopoly once it had been weakened by the withdrawal of Soviet support; and the less momentous groups, clubs and circles that came into being during the heroic and transition periods.

Growing Autonomy within the System

The *bureaucratic interests* and *institutional schools of thought* which the communist state as a complex multifunctional organization could not but secrete not only became more visible in the 1970s and 1980s, but gradually assumed an autonomy that verged at times on contestation. The clearest examples concerned environmental issues, which the party did not regard as providing a threat to its power position. In the Soviet Union itself the issue of the pollution of Lake Baikal had already provided an interesting case of this kind in the 1960s, with various ministries and research institutes taking rival positions.¹⁷

In East Central Europe the environmental issue caused many individual voices to be raised against government policies from within the administrative and scientific structures. Thus Włodzimierz Bojarski, head of the energy section of the Institute of Technical Problems of the Polish Academy of Sciences, clearly expressed his reservations over the government's nuclear policy in the mid-1980s. A second example comes from Hungary, where János Vargha, an eminent biologist and a member of the Hungarian Academy of Sciences, not only spoke out against the

building of the Gabčíkovo–Nagymáros dam on the Danube, but became a leading member of the Danube Circle, an association formed to contest the building of the dam (on which more below); and we find scientists in Königswalde contesting in the early 1980s the official view in the GDR that economic growth should have priority over the protection of the environment.¹⁸ Official voices joined with activists also in the celebrated case of *Bratislava Nahlas* (Bratislava Aloud) – which was a booklet commissioned by two Bratislava branches of the Slovak Union for the Protection of the Environment, and the contributors to which included experts from 65 scientific, administrative and cultural instances in Slovakia.¹⁹

Even when the voice is that of an individual, cases such as these are evidence of a group process at work. The views expressed are set in a debate; they function as points of identification and as potential rallying points in that debate.

A second example of growing group activity within the system is provided by the *mass organizations*. In the heyday of Stalinism these bodies, sponsored and organized by the party to control strategic sections of society, relayed party policy to the masses. Through control of their press and of appointments to their leading positions the party could ensure their compliance. Examples were the trade unions (including the very special cases of the writers' and the journalists' unions), the women's federation or committees in certain countries, and the party's youth league. Seen once as 'transmission belts' that 'bind the masses to the regime', they began to develop a very different role in the period we are examining.

The party's youth organizations provided the most graphic illustrations, not least because of the particular salience of the generational factor in the process of change in Eastern Europe and the Soviet Union. Some time before the arrival of *glasnost* on the scene, the Soviet *Komsmol'skaya pravda* had become a major source of sociological data which often questioned official party policy either explicitly or implicitly. Cases abound from Central Europe and the Balkans. In Yugoslavia the youth organization of the League of Communists of Slovenia, and its newspaper *Mladina*, played a prominent role in the peace movement that arose in the wake of NATO's dual-track decision in 1979.²⁰ In 1988 in Czechoslovakia the Socialist Youth League organized a protest against the building of a dam at Křivoklát.²¹ These examples of initiatives by official party youth organizations were only the tip of the iceberg of group action by young people, much of which was libertarian in inspiration, and seemed to presage the arrival in Eastern Europe of the 'spirit of 1968'. The antics of the Orange Alternative in Poland, the prominence given to

anniversaries of John Lennon's death, the tribulations of the Jazz Section of the Prague Musicians' Union were all manifestations of an independently minded youth culture and all, in the circumstances of the time, had a marked political significance.²² But the fact that this independence of thought and action had invaded the party's own youth organizations was a mark of change indeed.

The situation with the trade unions was rather more complex, but here again autonomous political activity outside the official channels was accompanied by the development of an independent stance on the part of the official party-sponsored bodies. What engaged the world's attention at the time was the emergence of new trade unions, with the Polish Solidarity leading the way both in time and in terms of its impact. Equally indicative of the changes that were taking place was the creation of the white-collar Democratic Union of Scientific and Academic Workers in Hungary in December 1989. In other countries, too, white-collar workers were prominent in the birth of new trade unions. But not even in Poland did these new organizations eclipse what had been the official unions of the communist period. Far from it: the latter were able to adjust their policies to the new circumstances. Moreover, not only did they retain the substantial wealth that they had built up, but they managed to keep also a sizeable membership.

Thus, in 1991 the Hungarian ex-official trade union – the MSZOSZ – still retained 3,000,000 of the 4,500,000 members that it had three years earlier.²³ In Poland, also in 1991, the OPZZ, created by the party during the martial law period to counter the challenge of Solidarity, numbered 4,500,000 to Solidarity's 2,300,000.²⁴ In Bulgaria, where the newly created trade union Podkrepa, under its colourful leader Trenchev, had played a crucial part in the movement to dethrone the communist party, the ex-official Confederation of Independent Trade Unions of Bulgaria has lost rather little of its earlier membership.²⁵ In all these cases, the ex-official unions have succeeded in transforming themselves from the obedient servants of a communist party into an autonomous interlocutor with government, sharing this role with the newer unions. Given the memberships involved, a strong element of corporatism pervades the present relationship between government and unions, and on the trade union side the reinvigorated survivals of the communist era have considerable impact. The situation in Czechoslovakia, however, has been different. There, the old Revolutionary Trade Union Movement of the communist period was dissolved on 2 March 1990, and replaced by a new Czech and Slovak Confederation of Trade Unions.²⁶

The difference between the cases of the party's youth organizations and the trade unions in their responses to the process of change is that the

former acted as an important part of the spearhead of change. Nowhere did the official trade unions play this role. They adapted to changing circumstances, and the point of analytical interest is simply that they did succeed in so adapting.

It remains to record one further example of a mass organization that in the case of certain countries placed itself at the forefront of change. The dissolution of the communist glacier was preceded, and was indeed helped on its way, by the crisis that developed from the 1970s over the installation of first Soviet, and then Western, intermediate-range nuclear weapons in the heart of Europe. At this crucial juncture the Peace Committees, which had functioned as mass organizations in each of the communist countries, began – notably in the Hungarian case – to depart from their traditional automatic alignment with Soviet positions. Thus it was that the Western peace movement was presented with the ticklish question of the correct attitude to adopt towards these organizations when they decided, for example, to send their representatives to conventions of European Nuclear Disarmament.

From all these various examples it can be seen how, within the structures of communist rule, change was making itself felt. It can be seen also how in certain cases, notably that of the trade unions, the structures of the past adapted to the changed circumstances to emerge in a new role. But it was in the non-systemic area that there took place the chief process of aggregation of political preferences during the heroic period.

The 'Forum' Movements

Much has been written on the broad aggregating movements that were to go on to form the basis for the political parties of the period from 1989, and space does not allow a full treatment here. The historical importance of these 'forum' or 'milieu' movements cannot be overestimated. They were, strictly speaking, a transitional phenomenon. But that precisely was their contribution. It fell to them to see out the old and to bring in the new. In terms of political aggregation, the role that they played was powerful but simple; and once they had performed it, they were bound to fall subject to differentiation and transformation.

The first to appear was Charter 77 in Czechoslovakia. Despite police harassment, Charter 77 played a central role in that – in the words of one of its founders, Václav Havel – it 'broadened the space for diverse other dependent activities and initiatives'.²⁷ Not only did it succeed in establishing an authoritative place for itself as coordinating spokesman for almost all contestatory movements that developed during these years, but it

contrived also to speak in international forums for the whole of Central European dissent.

At first its chief strategy was to attack the regime through the latter's record on human rights, but the gradual widening of its concerns to include peace and the protection of the environment illustrated the nature of the aggregation that it was engaged in. These were all issues that made a universal appeal. The constituency that Charter 77 set out to rally was society itself. The chief message that it projected was a moral one, both in the positive sense contained in the promotion of these universal values, and in a negative sense, in that the battle to be fought was one against corruption and the perversion of humanistic values by the ruling party. Charter 77 thus constituted a reverse image of its opponent, as Havel himself realized.²⁸ Opposition to a monopolistic party was led by the circumstances to take on a united form.

Solidarity in Poland came to acquire these same features, as did the Evangelical churches in the GDR, and eventually the Union of Democratic Forces in Bulgaria.

So much has been written on Solidarity in Poland that little good would be served by rehearsing it here. It was the workers of Gdańsk, Szczecin and Jastrębie in this case who, in 1980, provided the initial impetus. As in the case of Czechoslovakia, Solidarity early on developed the role of national focus for all activity directed against the party. In this case, however, the latter was forced to bend to the storm, and was itself affected by the movement for renewal. By the time Jaruzelski called the army to the party's aid and declared martial law on 13 December 1981, Solidarity was claiming ten million members on a population of 36 million. Poland was somewhat exceptional in the number of autonomous and semi-autonomous organizations that came into being during the 1980s, or indeed existed before then, but Solidarity dwarfed them all. And, in this first phase, it was a united body, subject admittedly to strains between radicals and moderates, but constituting none the less a single massive pole of opposition to the party and its Soviet connection.

Very different in its origins was the pacifist and environmental movement that developed under the patronage of the Evangelical churches in the GDR after 1978. In that year those churches came to an agreement with the party, the terms of which allowed them greater autonomy. The fact that they used that autonomy to rally young people to the cause of peace and a cleaner environment did not – at least not overtly – conflict with the SED's own aims. The churches' activity, however, did amount to a significant process of aggregation: it rallied significant numbers, particularly of young people; it threw up a leadership of pastors who were to go on to form an important part of the spearhead of change when the

SED fell in late 1989; and it acquired a political identity through its semi-legal press and through activities which clearly extended beyond the brief that the churches had set themselves, but which they found themselves covering none the less (through providing premises, through failing to dissociate themselves from each and every overt political stand, and so on).²⁹

In these three cases the roots of change reach back before 1985, when Gorbachev became general secretary of the CPSU. In Bulgaria, on the other hand, the events leading to the creation of the Union of Democratic Forces (UDF) were telescoped into a very short period. The UDF was founded on 7 December 1989, rather less than two years after the appearance of the first viable protest action to rally significant public support – the Independent Committee for the Defence of the Environment, better known as the Ruse Committee.³⁰ That Committee was aggregated first into Ekoglasnost when this body was created on 11 April 1989, and then Ekoglasnost in turn joined a number of other organizations that had come into being in the new atmosphere to form the UDF under the leadership of Zhelyu Zhelev, an academic who could base his revolutionary credentials on a book on fascism which had got him into trouble during the Zhivkov years.

What linked these four very diverse cases in historical terms was the fact that they mirrored the circumstances of party monopoly. They were a product of their circumstances. They played a specific historical role at a specific moment. They did not bring down the regimes – the Soviet Union did that by withdrawing its support from them.

Their significance for the future was threefold. First they ensured a peaceful transition of power. Secondly, they provided an immediately available and, despite frictions, cohesive alternative leadership. Thirdly, they provided a myth, a memory of collective actions at a moment of immense historical significance.

Groups, Clubs and Circles

Particularly in Czechoslovakia and Bulgaria, the 'forum' movements aggregated not only individuals, but also groups that were themselves acting as agents of political aggregation. The latter during the period in question became so numerous and so diverse as to defy simple classification. In fact the burgeoning of autonomous political action from 1985, particularly in Poland, Hungary and (despite vigorous police repression) Czechoslovakia, was probably as great as in the period since the fall of the communist monopoly. I have elsewhere attempted a classification in the

case of environmental groups.³¹ In the space available here just a few examples will be presented, drawn from two countries: Poland and Hungary.

First, the case of Poland is particular. Here, for a number of reasons, a wide spread of semi-legal and illegal political organizations has existed for some considerable time, many of them, as recorded above, connected with the Catholic church. Among the most familiar are the Confederation of Independent Poland (KPN), which dates from 1979, and Experience and Future (DiP), which came into being in 1978. The years from the INF missile crisis of 1979–83 brought even greater profusion, with a strong element of youthful libertarianism. Examples of these last are the Peace and Freedom group (*Wolność i Pokój*), the Orange Alternative (*Pomarańczowa Alternatywa*), and most evocative of the ‘quality of life’ issues that were pervading East Central Europe during these years, I Want To Be (*Chcę Być*).³²

But despite the wide diversity of these groups and organizations in terms of social base, forms of political action and ideology – or perhaps precisely because of it? – they were eclipsed, as this phase neared its dénouement in the round-table talks and elections of 1989, by Solidarity. They were so many monuments to the movement mode of organization characteristic of the heroic period. Some of them survived into the electoral period, but at that point they were at a disadvantage as new patterns of political aggregation followed the establishment of electoral politics.

Secondly, whilst in Hungary the ‘democratic opposition’ never developed into a single umbrella movement capable of rallying opposition to the party on the pattern that was forming in Czechoslovakia, the GDR and Poland, and was to develop at the end of 1989 in Bulgaria, that country produced the most massive example of a single-issue protest movement of those years. In one sense the Danube Circle, whose aim was to halt the construction of the dam on the Danube at Nagymáros (itself part of a larger hydraulic scheme involving Slovakia, with substantial funding from Austria), had parallels with Polish Solidarity. Starting from this one issue, it touched a national nerve which brought it support from all sections of society. But, whilst many people supported the movement for reasons that had little to do with defence of the environment, the Danube Circle had a single focus which defined its existence and determined its future. It came into being over that issue, and was to decline as a movement when the Hungarian parliament decided in May 1989 to suspend work on the dam. Secondly, the Circle provided no individual political leadership capable of widening its agenda and of carrying the movement forward into the later electoral phase. To that extent, the

Danube Circle flowed into the channels of the emerging political parties, and lost its identity in them.³³

Conclusion: The Process of Aggregation in East Central Europe

The particular circumstances of flux in East Central Europe suggest that caution be exercised in adopting any analysis of the political process in the region in terms of interests. None the less, cases of autonomous political association, and of the aggregation of political preferences, can be seen to have been developing in the fifteen or so years before the final collapse of the communist regimes in the region. Prominent within this evolution, the 'forum' movements were necessarily transitional. They played a vital role in preparing the way for the demise of communist rule, but they were also crucial in shaping the transfer of power. First of all, they rallied the forces pressing for change to a single banner and a single leadership. This in itself provided a source of stability during the transition period. The aggregation involved, however, was simple and somewhat crude. If it paved the way for the representation of sectional interests, such interests were subordinated to the mobilization of society as a whole against a regime which had been weakened by the withdrawal of Soviet support.

The 'forum' movements performed another function in providing an alternative national leadership during the crucial period before elections could be held that would endow a new government with a new legitimacy. In their struggle to establish this new legitimacy, the 'forum' movements gave it a 'derivation' deeper than that offered by a simple electoral process. The myth created in the heroic period will infuse politics in the region for years to come. It was to create political problems in cases where the even newer electoral legitimacy conflicted with that based on the heroic period – as occurred in the ironic duel between Mazowiecki and Wałęsa in Poland in 1990 at the time of the presidential election.

Although the organizational field is far from unstructured in these countries, the present state of their political systems is still characterized by flux, making it difficult to offer hard and fast judgments on the articulation and aggregation of interests. The hectic years have not receded far enough for political pressure to replace mobilization, and for stable relations to emerge between clearly defined constituencies and elites. The very question of what constitutes an interest, as opposed to a simple political preference, must await further evolution of the situation, as must, *a fortiori*, any stable inventory of the interests in play. Until a market has been more clearly established, and public goods turned over more to private ownership, how is it possible to foresee the future shape of group, let alone class, pressures?

In the meantime group forces that had been subdued by the 'hard hand' of communism have moved to take advantage of the newly opened political space. The tense debate over abortion in Catholic Poland in 1991 showed the revived power of organized religion. A second case has been the emergence of strong national and regional forces. Yugoslavia was to produce the most alarming manifestation of the latter, but Czechoslovakia was to experience not only a resurgence of Slovak national self-assertion, but the emergence of a new political identity around the claims for regional autonomy put forward by Moravia and Silesia.

It is too early to determine whether these cases are distortions made possible by the circumstances of flux. Certain it is, however, that a good deal more time must elapse before the middle ground of the political system in these countries fills with a settled inventory of stably organized autonomous groups.

NOTES

1. *Pravda*, 18 Feb. 1990.
2. Abel Aganbegyan, *The Challenge: The Economics of Perestroika* (London: Hutchinson, 1988), pp.64-5.
3. For Brus's views see his *The Market in a Socialist Economy* (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1972); for the appropriate passages from Kardelj's works, see Michael Waller, *Democratic Centralism: An Historical Commentary* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 1981), pp.104-8, 113-14, 137-8; S.E. Finer, 'The Political Power of Organized Labour', *Government and Opposition*, Vol.8, No.4 (Autumn 1973), p.395.
4. Klaus von Beyme, 'A Comparative View of Democratic Centralism', *Government and Opposition*, Vol.10, No.3 (Summer 1975), pp.259-77.
5. See Malcolm McEwen, 'The Day the Party Had to Stop', *Socialist Register 1976* (London: Merlin Press, 1976), pp.56 *et seq.*
6. Quoted in Dennison Rusinow, *The Yugoslav Experience, 1945-1974* (London: Hurst, 1977), p.139.
7. This is the terminology used by Albert O. Hirschmann in his *Exit, Voice and Loyalty* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1970). The arguments of that book will be found to be relevant to the process of democratization in East Central Europe.
8. Ivan Krustev, 'The Illusions of Politics', *East European Reporter*, Vol.4, No.4 (Spring-Summer 1991), p.32.
9. See Rudolf L. Tökés, 'Comparative Communism: The Elusive Target', *Studies in Comparative Communism*, Vol.VIII, No.3 (Autumn 1975), pp.211-29; and Michael Waller, 'Problems of Comparative Communism', *ibid.*, Vol.XII, Nos.2-3 (Summer-Autumn 1979), pp.107-32.
10. See H. Gordon Skilling and Franklyn Griffiths, *Interest Groups in Soviet Politics* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1971), and Jerry F. Hough, *The Soviet Union and Social Science Theory* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1979).
11. Two key texts on this, amongst a substantial literature, are John Keane (ed.), *Civil Society and the State: New European Perspectives* (London: Verso, 1988); and Andrew Arato, 'Civil Society against the State', *Telos*, 50 (1981).
12. Arthur F. Bentley, *The Process of Government*, edited by Peter H. Odegard (Cambridge, MA: The Belknap Press, 1967), p. vii of original text.
13. *Ibid.*, p. 217.

14. Dimitrina Petrova, 'Political Pluralism in Bulgaria', *East European Reporter*, Vol.4, No.4 (Spring-Summer, 1991), p.34.
15. Op. cit., Ch.VI.
16. Teresa Rakowska-Harmstone, 'Ethnic Politics in the USSR', *Problems of Communism*, Vol. XXIII, No. 3 (May-June 1974).
17. Charles E. Ziegler, *Environmental Policy in the USSR* (London: Pinter, 1987), pp.53-7, gives a straightforward account of the Baikal affair. Also involved was the All-Russian Society for the Preservation of Historical and Cultural Monuments, dating from 1966. Although, strictly speaking, it was a voluntary organization, its closeness to certain centres of oligarchical power marks it more as a pre-echo in the earlier period of later developments than as an example, in Brezhnev's Soviet Union, of autonomous group activity: see John B. Dunlop, *The Faces of Contemporary Russian Nationalism* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1983), pp.63-87.
18. I deal with these three cases in my 'The Ecology Issue in Eastern Europe', *The Journal of Communist Studies*, Vol.5, No.3 (Sept. 1989), pp.303-28.
19. Pavl Slansky, 'Pollution: The Tale of Bratislava', *East European Reporter*, Vol.3, No.3 (Autumn 1988); 'Ecological Report on Bratislava Causes Political Dispute', *Radio Free Europe RAD Cz SR/3*, 1 March 1988.
20. *Libération*, 20/21 Sept. 1986.
21. *RAD Cz SR/13*, 1 Sept. 1988, pp.39-40, quoting *Rudé Pravo*.
22. Waller, 'The Ecology Issue ...', pp.313-26.
23. *RL/RFE Report on Eastern Europe*, Vol.2, No.13 (29 March 1991), p.27.
24. *Gazeta Wyborcza*, 23-4 Feb. 1991; and Louisa Vinton, 'Poland: Disparate Responses to Democracy and the Market', *RL/RFE Report on Eastern Europe*, Vol.2, No.13 (29 March 1991), pp.29-37.
25. Kjell Engelbrekt, 'Bulgaria: Partnership or Opposition?', *RL/RFE Report on Eastern Europe*, Vol.2, No.13 (29 March 1991), pp.19-22.
26. *RL/RFE Report on Eastern Europe*, Vol.2, No.13 (29 March 1991), pp.23-5.
27. H. Gordon Skilling, 'Independent Currents in Czechoslovakia', *Problems of Communism*, Vol. XXXIV, No.1 (Jan.-Feb. 1985), p.38.
28. Václav Havel, 'Anatomie d'une réticence', *Lettre Internationale*, 7 (1985), p.18.
29. Pedro Ramet, 'Church and Peace in East Germany', *Problems of Communism*, Vol. XXXIII, No.4 (Aug.-Sept. 1984), pp.45-7; John Sandford, *The Sword and the Ploughshare: Autonomous Peace Initiatives in East Germany* (London: Merlin/END, 1983); Roger Woods, *Opposition in the GDR Under Honecker, 1971-85* (London: Macmillan, 1986).
30. Vera Gavrilov, 'Environmental Damage Creates Serious Problem for Government', *RL/RFE Report on Eastern Europe*, Vol.1, No.21 (25 May 1990), p.7.
31. Waller, 'The Ecology Issue ...'.
32. For an annotated listing of Polish groups and parties, see Frances Millard, 'Emerging Pluralism in Poland: A Short Guide', *The Journal of Communist Studies*, Vol.6, No.1 (March 1990), pp.99-109.
33. Waller, 'The Ecology Issue ...', pp.318-19.

The Evolution of Party Systems in Eastern Europe

STEN BERGLUND and JAN ÅKE
DELLENBRANT

The Stalinist and neo-Stalinist system of government was imposed on Eastern Europe by the leading member of the Soviet bloc. It was a centralized and authoritarian system that was capable of transformation only within boundaries defined by the ruling communist parties. The revolution of 1989–90 was a by-product of a permanent legitimacy crisis in Eastern Europe compounded by a series of serious political and economic mistakes. In the aftermath of the anti-communist revolution, a new process of evolution away from the Stalinist system has been entered upon, in which the party systems of Eastern Europe have undergone profound change, as new cleavages have appeared and old cleavages have reasserted themselves.

The former socialist countries of 'Eastern Europe' were carbon copies of the Soviet model; to the extent that there were deviations from the original, they were of a formal nature. Some of them preserved traces of the pre-war multi-party system in the sense that they had one (Bulgaria) or several (the GDR, Czechoslovakia and Poland) parties in permanent coalition with the leading Marxist-Leninist party; and they all retained some traditional parliamentary institutions. The Baltic republics, following their incorporation, were of course more closely tied to the Soviet system of government. Across the region, virtually no traces of the pre-war parliamentary system were preserved.

In theory, the institutional and constitutional setting of Eastern Europe held out prospects for a development towards the Scandinavian post-war model, with a single dominant party in competition with a number of smaller parties. Such a development would in fact have been welcomed by many of the non-communist party leaders of Eastern

Sten Berglund is Professor of Political Science in the University of Helsinki, Finland; Jan Åke Dellenbrant is Associate Professor of Political Science in the University of Umeå, Sweden. They recently edited *The New Democracies in Eastern Europe: Party Systems and Political Cleavages* (1991).

Europe in the early stages of popular democracy, when the rules of the game were yet to be spelled out in detail; but when they were, they did not leave much room for diversity and even less for competition. The communist parties pledged themselves and their respective societies to the time-honoured principles of the world communist movement: the leading role of the party, democratic centralism, and friendship with the Soviet Union. The first principle put the East European communist parties firmly in command and made them the final source of authority in their respective countries; the principle of democratic centralism with its emphasis on discipline and obedience was helpful in making Eastern Europe safe for Marxism-Leninism; so was the friendship with the Soviet Union which, among other things, implied that the newcomers to socialism had to defer to the oldest and wisest member of the alliance. The penalties for opposition and dissent became increasingly steeper and pluralism became very much a negatively-loaded term in the official rhetoric.

The Stalinist and neo-Stalinist system of government set out to eliminate diversity and pluralism, but in most cases the ruling communist parties had to be content with something short of complete success. In general, the level of tolerance towards alternative organizations and views was at its lowest in the late 1940s and early 1950s and at its highest in the latter part of the 1980s, but there were also significant differences among the communist regimes of Eastern Europe. The majority of them resisted change until the very bitter end, but there were exceptions to this rule like the communist parties of Poland and Hungary which opened up a dialogue and embarked on formal negotiations with the informal opposition. Poland and Hungary were in fact innovators within the communist camp, on both the economic and political fronts. In the 1960s, Hungary initiated the kinds of economic reforms that were to be introduced to the Soviet Union as part of the *perestroika* process some 20 years later; moreover, although formally a one-party state, Hungary had developed into an openly pluralistic society by the late 1980s, almost on a par with neighbouring Poland with its long-standing experience in formal and informal political pluralism. In the 1970s, Poland embarked on a process of gradual political reform, interrupted only temporarily by the proclamation of martial law in December 1981: the pressures for reform remained, and re-emerged towards the end of the decade. In the Baltic republics of the Soviet Union, too, political pluralism emerged towards the end of the 1980s. The process was gradual and initially sponsored by Moscow, but when it became clear that the leaders of the Baltic republics were striving for full political and economic independence, the reactions from the central government in Moscow became increasingly negative.

The radicalization of the Baltic republics resulted in deadlock *vis-à-vis* Moscow.

It is tempting to account for the differences within the communist bloc in terms of the factors that play such a prominent role in various country-specific analyses. Hungary and Poland have pre-war parliamentary traditions. In the East European context, they are developed rather than developing countries, unlike Bulgaria and Romania, and they have civic cultures capable of producing and sustaining opposition and dissent over a long period of time. But so does Czechoslovakia, whose pre-war parliamentary record is perhaps even more impressive than that of Hungary and Poland. It is definitely more economically developed than Hungary and Poland, and it did have a civic culture capable of producing and sustaining the small, but highly visible and highly effective, anti-system opposition in Charter 77. And yet the regime opted for a strategy of confrontation and repression rather than for a strategy of co-option and adaptation. Czechoslovakia was in fact one of the most oppressive countries in Eastern Europe until the Novotny regime was eliminated in the Prague Spring of 1968; and the 'normalization' which was proclaimed in the wake of the Warsaw Pact invasion of the country in August 1968 simply meant that the clocks were turned back by a few months. It may be argued that the new leaders in Prague had little choice but to dance to Moscow's tune: but similar comments apply to Janos Kádár, who was Moscow's choice to restore order in Budapest after the uprising of 1956 – yet he became the main architect of the gradual economic reforms that were instrumental in catapulting Hungary into the rapid political reforms of the late 1980s.

The democratic traditions of the Baltic states were of a mixed character. It is true that the constitutions of the early 1920s were democratic, but democracy had to be suspended for fear of a fascist takeover. Until the 1960s, the Baltic area was effectively sealed off from the outside world, but a cultural revival in this period paved the way for the current process of democratization and the drive for renewed independence.

This attempt at causal modelling is, in fact, rather futile, and it leads to the conclusion that the vicissitudes of East European politics under communism were a function of the whims and strategies of the communist party leadership. The principle of democratic centralism vested final authority in the hands of the Politburo of the communist party and its general secretary, whose wishes and instructions were faithfully executed by the lower echelons of the state and party apparatus in exactly the same

way as in the Soviet Union. The within-party odds were heavily in favour of the strategy which was advocated by the party leader, particularly if he opted for the status quo like Jakeš, Honecker, Zhivkov and Ceaușescu and particularly if he was perceived to enjoy the confidence of the senior Soviet member of the military alliance. A successful strategy of change required time and careful planning like the gradual economic reforms which were introduced by Kádár in the 1960s, almost a decade after his promotion to the post of general secretary of the Hungarian communist party, and like the gradual Polish political reforms which were put on temporary hold in December 1981, at a time when the pace was getting too fast for Moscow.

The Six Months that Changed the World

On 4 June 1989 Poland held its first free or almost free elections in well over 40 years. The election resulted in a landslide victory for Solidarity and paved the way for the first non-communist government in Poland since the end of the Second World War. Less than six months later, the Stalinist and neo-Stalinist regimes of Eastern Europe were virtually all dead and gone. The transition of power was smooth and peaceful in Poland and Hungary which had a tradition of dialogue and negotiations; it was peaceful but painful in East Germany, Czechoslovakia and Bulgaria; and it was painful and violent in Romania which was on the verge of civil war by Christmas 1989. The initial changes in the Baltic republics were peaceful, but resulted in more and more tense relations with Moscow, until suddenly resolved as a result of the incompetence of Moscow's traditionalist communists in August 1991.

The revolution was a by-product of a long-standing and deeply felt legitimacy crisis in Eastern Europe, including the Baltic states. The crisis was permanent and built into the Stalinist and neo-Stalinist system of government which ruled out the possibility that the ruling Marxist-Leninist party might be completely out of touch with the people it was supposed to represent. By the late 1980s, it had been compounded by a series of serious political and economic mistakes. The strategy of confrontation and oppression which had been adopted by the communist parties of the GDR, Bulgaria, Czechoslovakia and Romania had not worked. The strategy of appeasement which had been applied by the rulers of Hungary and Poland had done little to boost the authority and popularity of their respective communist parties. And, as if this were not enough, it had become readily apparent that the planned economies of Eastern Europe and the Soviet Union had exhausted most of their

potential. In Estonia, Latvia and Lithuania, it became apparent that the prevailing pattern of development merely led to a *cul-de-sac* and that alternative strategies had to be sought.

The partially free elections in Poland served as an outlet for the grievances of the Polish people and as a source of inspiration for the rest of Eastern Europe. If the transition of power in Poland could take place without provoking any negative reactions from the Soviet Union, there were good reasons to believe that Moscow had given up the standard military response to political change within the traditional Soviet sphere of interest. Moscow had in fact given up more. It had given up entirely on the hibernating Stalinist and neo-Stalinist regimes of East Germany, Bulgaria, Czechoslovakia and Romania which were openly critical of Gorbachev's political and economic reforms. The full extent of the Soviet rejection did not become apparent until the mid-autumn of 1989 when Gorbachev and the Soviet media lashed out against Honecker, Zhivkov, Jakes and Ceausescu while they were still in office, but when it became public knowledge it served as a starting signal for reform communists and anti-system dissidents alike all over Eastern Europe.

The movement towards political and economic reform in the Baltic states was parallel to that of Eastern Europe. Reform communists played an important role, particularly at the outset of the process of democratization, but the problems were of a different magnitude from those confronting the political leaders of the other Warsaw Pact countries. If the Baltic republics were allowed to break out of the Soviet Union, it might jeopardize the Union's very existence. In the final analysis, the central government in Moscow resigned itself to the fact that the East European countries went their own way, but it was reluctant to accept the erosion of its power base that Baltic independence would entail. Gorbachev's sympathies were with the reform communists; and it is a moot question whether or not he realized that the reform process would wipe out the communist regimes of Eastern Europe and jeopardize the military alliance on which the Soviet Union had relied ever since the end of the Second World War. He probably did. Whether reformist or not, the communist parties of Eastern Europe found themselves fighting a seemingly hopeless battle against a public opinion that had turned against them; and there was little or nothing the Soviet Union could do to improve the odds of the reform communists in Eastern Europe but to offer moral support.

The New Democracies of Eastern Europe

With communism on the way out, some of the old cleavages reasserted themselves in Eastern Europe. The competitive multi-party systems that emerged in the autumn of 1989 count a number of parties with ideological and organizational roots in the 1920s and 1930s, and to some extent even further back. There are agrarian parties, social democratic parties, left socialist or communist parties, Christian democratic parties and ethnic parties. As a rule, however, they have not been among the big winners in the process of democratization. The electoral wind favoured the catch-all umbrella organizations like Solidarity in Poland, Democratic Forum in Hungary and Civic Forum in Czechoslovakia which had been part of the struggle for democracy and against communism. But there are exceptions to this rule.

In East Germany it was an old bloc party, the CDU, that benefited from the profound anti-communist backlash; and in Bulgaria and Romania there was an electoral backlash against communism, but the old power structures remained intact under somewhat modified labels. East Germany may be dismissed as a special case. The East German CDU probably would not have won the Volkskammer elections of March 1989 had it not been adopted by Federal Chancellor Kohl's Christian Democratic Union in West Germany; and Bulgaria and Romania are so different from the mainstream that these cases raise the theoretically interesting question of how suitable it is to count them as part and parcel of Eastern Europe. In the Baltic republics the popular fronts gradually took over power. In the elections of 1990 they gained parliamentary majorities in their own right in Latvia and Lithuania; and in Estonia the popular front emerged as the single most important political formation and formed a government with the support of some small parties. The popular fronts of the Baltic republics are socially and politically heterogeneous organizations which are likely to crystallize into political parties in the future.

The distinction between East and West made good sense at the height of the cold war, but now that the cold war is over the traditional diversity is re-emerging in Eastern Europe. There are Central European countries like Poland, Hungary and Czechoslovakia and there are Balkan countries like Bulgaria and Romania. The prospects for democracy are perhaps bleakest in the Balkan countries. They are developing rather than developed countries; they do not have much of a democratic record before communism; and, with the exception of Yugoslavia which was excommunicated from the Soviet bloc in 1948, they have only recently emerged from a communist system of government which was totalitarian

rather than authoritarian. But what about the Central European countries and the Baltic states?

The Prospects for Democracy

Any discussion of prospects is bound to have an element of speculation attached to it and our discussion of the potential for democracy in Central Europe and the Baltic states is no exception to this rule. But it does not have to be normative. Our analysis departs from the simple notion that there have been stable and unstable democracies over the past century of European history. Most of the stable democracies like Britain, West Germany and the Scandinavian countries have a long-standing tradition of what Sartori would call moderate pluralism,¹ while most of the unstable democracies like the German Weimar Republic (1919–33), the French third and fourth republics, Spain before and immediately after Franco, Italy before and after the Second World War, etc. are plagued by what Sartori refers to as extreme pluralism.

In the final analysis, moderate pluralism is equated with a bell-shaped distribution of voter preferences and extreme pluralism with deviations from the statistically normal distribution of party preferences. A variety of deviations are possible. The preference curve could, for example, have two peaks on the far left and on the far right and flatten out as we move towards the centre. The dynamics of such a party system will be centrifugal rather than centripetal. The parties of the extremes will have little incentive to move towards the centre and the parties of the middle are also likely to defend their positions in the party space. In such a political climate, the process of government formation is likely to prove difficult and the country runs the risk of succumbing to the kind of political decision-making paralysis known as immobilism that toppled the third and fourth French republics. Democracy under conditions of moderate pluralism is entirely different. The political parties will try to position themselves where the majority of the voters are, that is somewhere in the middle of the bell-shaped political spectrum. The drive of the party system will be centripetal; the parties will try to carve out niches for themselves by a process of marginal differentiation that might eventually end up in the proverbial Tweedledum and Tweedledee of United States two-party politics; polarization is theoretically impossible and the process of government formation is likely to run smoothly.

In an early article Sartori lists a number of factors which are likely to affect the development of a party system.² The approach is historical and the list is not defined as exhaustive, but with his five groups of factors

Sartori does come rather close to the stage of theory formation. The following factors are identified:

- the timing of the franchise;
- the timing of proportional representation;
- the number of cleavages;
- the structure of cleavages;
- the degree of party organization.

The logic is relatively straightforward. A rapid process of democratization when subjects are turned into citizens literally overnight is conducive to the extreme kind of pluralism. So is proportional representation, particularly if it is introduced without being preceded by a transition period of majority representation. And in a similar vein, it may be argued that the existence of many cleavages which are more or less independent of one another promotes the extreme kind of multi-partyism, particularly if the parties are in the early stages of organization.

Eastern Europe today has a great deal in common with Italy and West Germany immediately after the Second World War. A dictatorship with totalitarian ambitions had just been defeated. The transition to competitive pluralism was rapid. Proportional representation was preferred over majority representation; and the political parties had only just begun to build up nationwide organizational networks. The party system was highly fragmented, perhaps even more so than in the Weimar Republic and the third and fourth French republics. But this was not a permanent condition. Some of the political entrepreneurs did not survive the electoral competition, while others decided to improve their odds by joining forces with neighbouring parties. This process is already well under way in Eastern Europe. There were many parties and candidates running for the first free elections in well over 40 years, but they were not all successful; and of those that failed, some dropped out of politics altogether, while others set out to find a potentially more successful coalition partner.

Electoral systems may also be subject to change. Post-war European history is in fact full of instances of creative electoral engineering designed to prevent party fragmentation. The West German five per cent threshold is perhaps the best known: it effectively bars from parliamentary representation parties that poll less than five per cent of the votes, and it was probably highly instrumental in giving West Germany a firm push towards moderate pluralism. Similar arrangements have already been introduced in Hungary and East Germany, and other countries may very well follow suit.

The conclusion is that the fragmentation and extreme multi-partyism in Eastern Europe of 1989–90 is not likely to persist. The number of parties

will be reduced drastically, but that may not be enough to eliminate the danger of extreme pluralism. It is also a function of the underlying cleavage structure. The transformation of the West German party system into moderate pluralism was not only a function of creative electoral engineering. The transformation would have failed if the underlying cleavage structure had not been simple enough. And conversely, electoral reform may not have been sufficient to wipe out extreme pluralism in Italy with its complex underlying cleavage structure. The Baltic states have all the attributes of fragmented societies, and they are likely to make themselves felt now that the struggle for national independence – a goal of overriding political salience – has been attained.

The cleavage structures of the East European countries have not settled yet.³ There is overwhelming evidence of an anti-communist backlash throughout Eastern Europe and the Baltic states, but this cleavage is bound to lose salience with the breakdown of the Stalinist and neo-Stalinist system of government. The fate of Solidarity in Poland is a good case in point. It always was a heterogeneous coalition of workers and intellectuals, believers and non-believers, radicals and conservatives. The common struggle against the communist regime provided the glue that held it together for more than ten years of both legality and illegality, but the latent tensions manifested themselves as soon as it became apparent that communism was defeated; and the presidential election of November and December 1990 which pitted the two leading Solidarity leaders Wałęsa and Mazowiecki against one another put an abrupt end to the myth of unity. There were early intimations of a latent left-right cleavage within Solidarity, as may be expected of a heterogeneous umbrella organization committed to a market economy without broad consensus about the methods. Similar comments apply to Civic Forum in Czechoslovakia, Democratic Forum in Hungary and the popular fronts of the Baltic states. Solidarity and Civic Forum are in the process of breaking up, but it is yet far too early to make predictions about political life after this kind of umbrella organizations.

The political parties that staged a comeback on the basis of past performance in the 1920s and 1930s were in a sense reborn only to be rejected. Many of them, particularly the social democratic parties and the old bloc parties, were hurt by the anti-communist backlash, but that is not all there was to it. All the parties with ideological and historical roots in a distant but glorious past returned to find their constituencies changed almost beyond recognition by more than half a century of dictatorial communist rule. The policies of extensive industrialization and collec-

tivized agriculture that were adopted by almost all the Soviet bloc countries throughout the 1950s had a profound impact on the social structure. They were designed to break up the rural way of life and to promote industrialization and urbanization, which is precisely what they did. By the 1980s the core groups of the pre-war parties no longer existed, and to the extent that they did exist, they clearly did not represent the same thing any more. The agricultural sector is a good case in point. The interests of an independent farmer in the basically rural economy of Eastern Europe in the 1920s and 1930s were not likely to be identical with those of his son or grandson in the semi-industrial collectivized rural economy of the 1980s and 1990s; and to the extent that the reformed agrarian parties failed to take this into account, they were doomed to failure.

With the benefit of hindsight, we can say that this kind of insensitivity seems to have been rather typical of the pre-war parties. The party organization and the party ideology had survived in the hearts and minds of old men and women with personal experience of political work in the heyday of democracy, most of them well over 70 and few of them younger than 65, who did not realize that the audience had all but vanished while they waited in the wings ready to perform a play that had been written well over 40 years ago. But this is not to say that the old cleavages have exhausted their potential in today's East European political landscape. The political parties with roots in pre-war parliamentary democracy may yet carve out viable electoral niches for themselves; and old cleavages based on religion, ethnicity and nationalism may find new outlets. Industrialization, urbanization and migration from the countryside have reduced the impact of religion, but the religious factor should not be discounted. It always served as a latent cleavage within Solidarity, and it remains a potential line of demarcation throughout Eastern Europe.

Ethnicity and nationalism, however, represent potentially the most explosive and divisive cleavage. The collapse of the Stalinist and neo-Stalinist system of government has provided the oppressed ethnic minorities of Eastern Europe and the Soviet Union with an opportunity to voice their grievances and to improve their situation, but it has also resulted in a revival of nationalism and a heightening of ethnic tensions. The situation is particularly severe and tense in Romania and Bulgaria with their large minorities of ethnic Hungarians and Turks, but the problem is by no means unique to those two countries. Poland has small but vocal German and Silesian minorities and a stake in the Polish settlements in Lithuania and other parts of the Soviet Union.

Czechoslovakia has a long-standing tradition of tensions between Czechs and Slovaks, the two dominant nationalities in a federal republic, but there is also a substantial Hungarian minority and a small German-speaking minority; and in the Baltic states, which are in the process of disengaging from the Soviet Union, there are places where the Russian-speaking minority constitutes a solid majority. On top of all this, there is the spectre of anti-Semitism with its deep historical roots in Eastern Europe and the Soviet Union. It has reappeared as a prominent part of the official rhetoric of a variety of right-wing movements, particularly in Poland and the Soviet Union; and it clearly strikes a chord in a political setting where there is a premium on easy answers to the question of whom to blame for the political, moral and economic bankruptcy of the entire nation.

If Not Democracy, Then What?

Anything is still possible in Eastern Europe, and the future course of political evolution in the region cannot be foreseen. The extreme multi-partyism of the early days of democracy will not necessarily carry over into the future. With the passage of time, the cleavage structure may settle into the British and North European mould with one dominant cleavage; and the distribution of party preferences may comply more and more with the precepts of moderate pluralism as time goes by.

On the face of it, however, such a development does not seem very likely. The stage is set for extreme pluralism, and the problem with that kind of democracy is that it tends to be unstable. The French third and fourth republics, the Weimar Republic and Spain before Franco do not count among the most successful experiments in democracy; and it would clearly be premature to rule out such a scenario in Eastern Europe. The market economy has no doubt come back to stay, but Eastern Europe is not yet safe for democracy. The transition to market economy with the many hardships which that entails may actually add additional fuel to underlying ethnic resentments; and right-wing authoritarianism has never been alien to Central Europe and the Baltic states. The democratic traditions to which there are so many references nowadays did not produce stable democratic regimes in the past and may turn out to be of little avail in the face of a nationalistic revival.

Our conclusion has perforce to be speculative. What cannot be gauged with any certainty is the impact of the changes in economic and social structure, in educational levels, in political experiences that have been part and parcel of communist rule, not to mention growing awareness of

other societies. How far have the values of stable prices, full employment and cradle-to-grave welfare provision (however inadequately provided in practice in recent years) been absorbed and internalized by the post-war generation? Once the thrill at overthrowing the communist system has worn off, will the more positive elements of that system's policies attain political salience? Has the enforced inter-ethnic 'peace' eroded ancient suspicions to any degree at all? Or are all the atavistic reactions and emotions resurfacing to displace the past half-century as merely a nightmare memory? The answers to some of these questions will become apparent as new parties, pressure groups and electoral forces emerge – and on the answers to such questions the post-communist political evolution of Eastern Europe depends.

NOTES

1. Giovanni Sartori, *Parties and Party Systems: A Framework for Analysis* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1976).
2. Giovanni Sartori, 'European Political Parties: The Case of Polarized Pluralism', in Joseph LaPalombara and Myron Weiner (eds.), *Political Parties and Political Development* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1966), pp.137–76.
3. See Sten Berglund and Jan Åke Dellenbrant (eds.), *The New Democracies in Eastern Europe: Party Systems and Political Cleavages* (Aldershot: Edward Elgar, 1991).

Communism and Political Evolution

ADAM WESTOBY and RONALD J. HILL

In its modern form derived from Marxism, communism has evolved several competing variants, resulting primarily from the different times and circumstances in which communist parties have existed and come to power. The history of the movement displays many paradoxes, not least in the obvious contrast between the goal of communist society and the reality of communist rule. Once established, communist regimes have competed with a capitalism that proved singularly more vibrant than Marxists believed, and established an international environment in which communist systems were found wanting; the communications revolution, in particular, undermined basic ground rules of communist power. The concept of evolution raises theoretical issues of relevance to the study of communism, notably the adaptability of a system to its changing environment. On that score, the Stalinist form of 'communism' is doomed as a system, but some of its effects will be transmitted to the next stage of those societies' evolution.

Communism as a form of rule, an attempt to put into practice the goal of building a fundamentally rational society, has undoubtedly been one of the most significant – although far from the most pleasant – human experiences of the twentieth century. Events over the last three years, from mid-1989, when communist rule in various countries of Eastern Europe began to collapse, to the end of 1991, when communist rule in the system's progenitor, the Soviet Union, finally gave way to a market-oriented and proto-democratic system of government, appear to bear out Zbigniew Brzezinski's identification of 'the birth and death of communism in the twentieth century'.¹

Nevertheless, the very term 'communism' covers a variety of forms and experiences, conceptually linked in their practical application by Leninism (implying specifically abhorrence of spontaneity, and its replacement by societal guidance by a vanguard party), but in their turn inspired by and in some measure different from the communism of Marx's and Engels's theory. As a guiding philosophy, communism – Marxism, Marxism-Leninism, Stalinism, Mao Zedong Thought, Kimilsungism, Fidelismo, Eurocommunism, call it what you will – is characterized by an impressive adaptability. This has made it applicable in

Adam Westoby is a Senior Lecturer in the Faculty of Social Sciences at the Open University, Milton Keynes, UK; Ronald J. Hill is at Trinity College, Dublin, Ireland.

widely varying societies and cultures, where an uneasy 'fit' has led to marked successes in some areas of human endeavour, and dismal failure in others – and has more often than not entailed significant levels of human suffering as convinced communists have striven to make the society compatible with their interpretation of the theory. The adaptability of the theory to circumstances, and the willingness to force circumstances into conformity with theory, has led, in effect, to several communisms, coexistent but consciously competing with one another, not all of them systems that attained their practical realization.

This contribution attempts to examine this experience, somewhat briefly, and to make some judgments about communism's capacity for adaptation and evolution, and consequently the value of the image of evolution for our understanding of communism (and more broadly of political processes and systems).

Individual communist systems – or Communism as a system of rule – have served as sites for the sharpest paradoxes of uneven economic and technical development. It should be recalled that Marxist theory envisaged that the 'socialist' revolution, which would ultimately usher in the stable society of 'communism', would take place in the most advanced capitalist countries. By providing a justification for a voluntarist 'revolution' in the relatively backward society of Russia and then acting upon that theoretical advance, Lenin indirectly paved the way for establishing forms of rule by communists in a variety of societies considered 'unripe' for the socialist revolution.

The word 'indirectly' is important here, because, of course, Lenin did not envisage that the Russian revolution would be required to survive alone in a hostile world: it would – as Marx and Engels had suggested in their preface to the 1882 Russian edition of the *Communist Manifesto*, in a formulation that Engels had quoted in his preface to the German edition of 1890 – be joined by proletarian revolutions in the advanced capitalist countries, which would therefore assume the lead in the construction of communism. The relatively unpropitious circumstances of Russia in 1917 and afterwards, and the failure of other countries to come to the Bolsheviks' aid, faced Lenin's successors with the choice of capitulating, going all-out to stimulate the revolution abroad, or taking steps to bring Russian (later, Soviet) society to the conditions appropriate for the socialist revolution.

In the intra-party debates of the 1920s, the third of these options (espoused by Stalin) won at the expense of the second (put forward by Trotsky): capitulation to a restored capitalism was, of course, rejected – until 1991, at any rate. The system of rule devised by Stalin to modernize the Soviet Union, characterized by an exceptionally high level of control

by the political authorities to replace private ownership of capital and the market as a mechanism for allocating resources, was deemed to be 'socialism', itself judged to be a preliminary stage on the road to 'communism'; in later decades, under Leonid Brezhnev, the terms 'developed socialism', 'mature socialism', 'real socialism' and 'existing socialism' were applied to that system in the Soviet Union and various countries of Eastern Europe. That is the system of rule popularly referred to as 'communism': it is, of course, quite distinct from the 'communism' towards which the rulers of those countries asserted they were leading their peoples.

It was a system that had been quite consciously in competition with capitalism: indeed, the ideological divide between 'capitalism' and 'communism' has been the major structural distinction in the world in this century. As such, it – that is, those who determined the dominating values of 'communism' – had felt impelled to match the technical advances of capitalism, above all in the realm of defence. So, while the needs of citizens as consumers were given a low priority, and even certain elements in the infrastructure were not developed effectively (say, the transportation network, or housing), the priority given to defence-related endeavours permitted the Soviet Union and even China to develop nuclear weapons and delivery systems, and to engage in space research.

Thus, while millions of subjects of communist rulers continued to live in primitive conditions and to engage in a traditional way of life – reindeer-herding, for example, or deploying relatively unsophisticated skills to produce artefacts known to their forebears of many generations – the application of advanced technical discoveries in the military field was such that the immensely wealthier and more sophisticated United States and Western Europe felt seriously challenged by 'communism'. Hence a paradox: in contemplating the image of the Soviet Union and its allies as 'Upper Volta with rockets', the West concentrated on the formidable weaponry and felt threatened, while the communist leaders themselves were ever mindful of the weak economy and the lack of social integrity that supported the protected and privileged military sector.

Moreover, by that stage, even 'communism' in power manifested protean characteristics, in part associated with the length of time various communist regimes had been in existence. As an ideology, 'communism' appealed deliberately and most obviously to the 'underdog': its anti-imperialist and pro-worker rhetoric, combined with Stalinism's promise of a means of rapidly modernizing a traditional society, made it in some ways 'natural' for leaders of post-colonial, Third World countries to adopt. So, in the 1970s, when the advanced countries of the communist

world were already approaching a state of 'development', others were only embarking on the road of development – indeed, were fending off the catastrophe of famine. It should not be at all surprising that the political forms of communism as a form of rule showed differentiation – evolution – in response to the very different problems that confronted the various countries, and the opportunities for their solution afforded by populations at different stages of educational, occupational and social advancement, not to mention the variety of political experiences both before and during communist rule.

Meanwhile, those parts of the world in which the founding fathers of modern communist ideology placed their confidence for the future of socialism had effectively turned their back on such hopes. It is certainly true that communism as a political force continued to enjoy success in Western Europe, notably in France and Italy. Yet that was despite, not because of, some of the features of 'communism' brought into the model by Stalin. It could scarcely be argued that the millions of communist voters in France, Italy and elsewhere in the decades since the Second World War wished to visit on their fellow citizens the horrors of the Soviet GULag, Chinese 'brainwashing' or the 'killing fields' or Pol Pot's Cambodia. In fact, given the historical experience of rising wealth for the masses of Western Europe, the United States, Japan and elsewhere in the ideological 'West' after the Second World War, the 'bourgeois' arguments about freedom fell on quite recipient ears.

The repressive nature of 'communism', contrasting both with that individual experience and with ideological and commonsense views of 'socialism', led to severe disenchantment in societies who derived their understanding of 'communism' from watching, usually from a fairly safe distance, other countries serve as laboratories of social experimentation. Even the most modest promises of rational, internally-coherent state action, experienced to some extent through programmes of nationalization and the provision by the state of welfare services for all, were widely rejected as undue interference in the lives of individual citizens, and largely dismantled in the very decade in which communism itself later collapsed.

The above account reveals a further characteristic of practical communism: its capacity for appealing, at key moments, to all sorts and conditions of people, to both the base and the brave in politically-active individuals. As an ideology, the 'communism' of the *Communist Manifesto* or of Lenin's *The State and Revolution* offers an inspiring vision: it is an ideology of liberation, of emancipation; it holds out the prospect of a society of equality, fraternity, collaboration and harmony; and it shows ways of attaining that goal. As such, that ideology corresponds to the

eternal quest for an understanding of society that will permit the elimination of evil in human affairs. However, in espousing the notion of revolution, identified as a struggle between classes, the founding fathers themselves endorsed the use of methods that in some senses contradicted those very goals, and Lenin and Stalin, confronting the very practical question of how to 'build communism', quite explicitly endorsed the use of various forms of repression in the interests of liberation.

The legacy of those who moulded communism as a political movement is therefore quite ambiguous: its vision can inspire the most lofty altruist; its methods of rule can justify the harshest repression. And it is the repression that has tended to outweigh the inspiration in the world's political evaluation. The noble end was deemed to justify the means in the cruel decade of initial 'socialist construction': but such an argument was not acceptable at the time to societies whose dominant values had evolved through Western Christianity and humanism, nor is it acceptable two generations later to the heirs and successors of those who suffered.

Indeed, immediately following the death of Stalin, who had brought communism as a system of rule to its pinnacle of intensity, his heirs began to question and abandon some of its more odious features, and replace overt violence or the plausible threat of its use with more subtle forms of control. The Leninist abhorrence of spontaneity was certainly not abandoned – Khrushchev saw it as 'the deadliest enemy of all' – yet a perceptible relaxation in the methods of social control was apparent, in which the use of heavy-handed methods by the political police was replaced by propaganda, education and forms of social control that were compatible with, if not influenced by, Gramsci's notions of class hegemony exercised through cultural influences.

This slow 'mellowing' of at least Soviet and East European communism doubtless reflected substantial 'generational' influences, private memories and fears, leaving in power functionaries with little stomach for the energy and violence of earlier years. After all, not only was society at large heartily ready for a measure of stability, but the Stalinist system, based on the generation of fear, suspicion and unpredictability, was insecure for those who directed the system, and it certainly was not conducive to a businesslike approach to the management of an increasingly complex and sophisticated society. While disagreements over the appropriate direction continued for almost four decades after Stalin's death, after a series of half-hearted efforts at party-led reform the process of attempting to control the system's further evolution culminated in the extraordinarily bloodless – and inept – self-effacement of the CPSU in August 1991, and the collapse of the whole system of rule by the end of the year.

That whole process in turn was the consequence of something more general: the accelerated technical and cultural development of human society in the twentieth century, and its profound (and, taken all in all, civilizing and improving) impact on the inherited institutions of the nation state and politics. The effects of this 'scientific and technical revolution' (as it came to be called in the Soviet Union) can be identified in numerous areas of society, and is symbolized by the invention, first, of the transistor and, later, of the integrated-circuit microchip.

Applied to computers and similar devices for precise control, the new revolution is having effects that render outdated the changes of the original industrial revolution. In particular, the old 'smokestack' industries – coal and mining, iron and steel, railways, heavy machine-building – are being supplemented and replaced by 'post-industrial' industries and services in terms of their economic and social impact. Increasing shares of the world's wealth comprise the manufacture and distribution of sophisticated, electronics-based consumer goods or the supply of high-quality services that frequently employ the products of the scientific revolution. The workforce is being transformed: the application of machines (including robots) to traditional industries implies fewer workers to perform traditional tasks; the application of sophisticated technology makes fresh demands on the skills of the workforce beyond the largely manual and physical skills of the first industrial revolution.

It follows that ideologies based on a traditional 'working class' are urgently in need of reassessment and reinterpretation. Traditionally strong leftist parties in Western Europe have discovered that to their cost in the past two decades, as their traditional heavy-industry strongholds have declined and left them deprived of their political base. That applies *a fortiori* to communist parties, ruling or not, whose conception of the working class is based heavily on that of nineteenth-century European industry. As the 'working class' by the late 1960s acquired some characteristics of and perhaps affinities with the 'intelligentsia' – specifically, an increasing mental or intellectual content to their work – sociologists in the more developed communist-ruled countries of the Soviet Union and Eastern Europe began to grapple afresh with the nature of the class structure of socialist society. The ruling parties, however reluctant for historical reasons to abandon their rhetorical obeisance to the 'working class', adjusted their political behaviour to meet the changing circumstances. Nevertheless, the technologically-induced social change posed difficulties that the communist political system found difficult to accommodate.

That applies in even greater measure to the means of mass communication, one of the areas of most significant change – and almost certainly the

area in which the economists' 'technical progress' has done most to elbow classical socialism aside. The communications revolution has transformed the world in ways that render the creation of a controlled society quite impossible to attain. A colossal amount of the consumer- and business-oriented revolution of the years since the Second World War has been associated with the manufacture and distribution of ever more impressive means of sound capture and reproduction, whether in the form of radio and television broadcasts, gramophone records, recorded tapes of both sound and visual images, or photocopying machines; to that can be added the spread of a telephone network which, with the assistance of satellites, has created a global communications network. The invention of the desktop computer has given enormous power to manipulate words and images and transmit them at the speed of light via telephone or radio links. The control of this technology is, of course, potentially a source of enormous power for communist (and other) regimes.

However, as they have discovered, the costs of doing so, in terms of stagnation in comparison with the rest of the world, are quite colossal; and in any case, the use of such technology cannot be controlled once it is in place. With the benefits come the political risks: radio and television sets can be used to hear materials that are not approved, whether emanating from inside or outside the country; air travel and the development of tourism likewise expose citizens of communist-ruled countries to alternative ideas, fashions, styles of behaviour, which may in turn generate demands to which the domestic system has to respond. A system based on the exclusion of spontaneity finds it increasingly difficult to maintain that stance, and pays an economic, social and political price for attempting to do so. Those communists who stick with traditional views of what constitutes 'socialism' and 'communism' find themselves left behind by the tide of history. Trotsky's rise – and fall – stemmed rather evidently from the habits of Second International soapbox-and-committee socialism. And he, in turn, thought events through most of all by analogy with the French Revolution, a century and a half earlier.

This point merits further elaboration. Lenin's (and Plekhanov's) innovations (often misdescribed as an architecture of party organization for 'intellectuals', with the labyrinth of forgotten nuances into which that assertion leads), was actually something more basic. What Bolshevik party organization did give its handful of leaders was effective and flexible machinery – active, structured and literate networks of local leaders, the wheels and cogs – to set in motion much larger, atomized, chiefly rural, and above all largely illiterate and only superficially-politicized populations. Plekhanov's notion of propaganda linked to and

powering agitation was a matter of communicating (mainly through print) many ideas to relatively few but receptive people. Those few then greatly amplify the effect by broadcasting ('agitation') fewer and simpler ideas to much larger numbers of – mainly illiterate – people. Stalin then silently (followed shortly and less opaquely by Mao) converted the machinery of revolution to run on the motivations and motivation of rule.

But within a few years the electronic revolution had begun to recast the nature of both literacy and political elites in modern societies and was beginning to short-cut the main linkages of Leninist party and social machinery. As it did so it overtook the textbook Leninist technologies of politics and rule. The barehanded young man who, in the spring of 1989, watched and protected by a billion TV viewers, dissuaded a tank from entering Tiananmen Square, was self-consciously a citizen of Marshall McLuhan's 'global village'. Mikhail Gorbachev was another – as were the demonstrators in Lithuania who, in January 1991, carried placards in English inviting the Soviet army to withdraw.

History's arrow flies through everyone's space, all the closer as we age, and few want to be remembered for presiding over genocide. In short, the communications revolution has changed the rules of the political game: not only is no man an island, entire of itself – the same can apply to whole nations, whose leaders' behaviour is under world scrutiny in ways that render the nineteenth-century concept of 'sovereignty' of far lesser significance than it once possessed. Willy-nilly, global developments have exposed communist leaders to influences and pressures that hinder the application of traditional methods, even if they do not render it impossible. A Ceaușescu, a Castro or a Kim Il-Sung may succeed in thumbing his nose at world opinion for a while, but the point is surely that their regimes are not of the world in which most communist-ruled countries had become involved well before their demise in the late 1980s.

Communist Studies and the Evolution of Communism

In the minds of the Western-educated classes knowledge about twentieth-century communism is already contracting towards being an esoteric specialism. Communism looks like completing its trajectory from obscurity to world movement and back, within the century. The study of communism in higher education will wither, or at best be absorbed into other topics within modern history or social science syllabuses. One already observable effect of this is to erode the perceived distinction between successful and unsuccessful communisms. It will not be many years before the names of Ho Chi Minh or Janos Kádár, Władysław Gomułka or Grigorii Zinoviev, Palmiro Togliatti or Nicolae

Ceauşescu, are almost as unfamiliar to undergraduates as those of Chen Tu-h'siu or Bela Kun, Vladimir Akimov or Heinrich Brandler, Amadeo Bordiga or Ana Pauker.

There is more than a little justice in this levelling effect. Communists themselves have often paid as much attention to their unsuccessful rivals as to the triumphant forms of communism which have won and held on to political power. In almost all its national forms and variants, communism integrates ideology and political discipline with a distinctive, and distinctively modern, intimacy. Communist leaders have been well aware, both as dissenters and as policemen, of the potency of ideas in dissolving 'scientific' claims to political legitimacy. And the formation of powerful communist parties and states has carved into harsh relief those subtler differences of shading which, early in their careers, distinguished a Lenin from a Martov, a Mao from a Maring – or a Gorbachev from an Andropov.

The variety and mutability of communisms, together with the unity of their origins, have encouraged terminology that invokes notions of 'evolution', 'natural selection' etc. Such transplantations from the life sciences are tempting. They hold out the promise of being – at least approximately and in principle – as applicable to the extinction of some forms of communism as they were to the emergence and proliferation of others. Darwinian notions of natural selection involve both the (relative) success and expansion of some species, and the failure and eventual extinction of others. They aim at explaining, eventually, the overall history and patterning of the terrestrial biosphere.

But are these more than superficial analogies with biological evolution? After all, the essential mechanisms are quite different. The finite lifetime of the individual organism, the endurance of species through the succession of generations, the division and recombination of genetic information, and its consequence, permanently shifting intra-species variation on which natural selection can act – these have no very close equivalents in the histories of modern social institutions, communist or other.

Social Darwinism had its day in the nineteenth century, seducing social theorists of widely differing political persuasions – including both Marx and Engels – with the chimerical hope of representing human history in terms of, even as an extension of, nature's history. But it yielded little. There are, of course, obvious difficulties in translating a model of development derived from the study of living organisms over countless generations across aeons of time into a model that applies to the historical evolution of human societies. The number of societies and systems is strictly limited in comparison with the range of all the living species that

have ever existed. Moreover, there are difficulties in identifying when a society has become a different type, whereas the ability to interbreed is a broadly acceptable test for speciation. And, while selective breeding, whether or not informed by the principles of the modern science of genetics, has been used from time immemorial to modify the evolution of living species (including settled cultivation, involving a degree of control over the environment, and the domestication of wild species), similar experimentation on human societies is quite impossible (although, of course, experimentation on human beings – including social experimentation – is not unknown). Hence, reference to ‘evolution’ in the context of historical development must be understood as lacking many of the characteristics of the evolution of species, so the analogy is only partly valid.

Nevertheless, the concept is not without merit. The earlier attempts at applying Darwinism to society (‘social Darwinism’) were made at an earlier stage of biological science, which has been enriched with new insights since Darwin’s day: these may help us to understand more of how societies evolve. Darwin’s most important achievement was to show that, given variation among the individuals comprising a species or a population, natural selection acted on differences within a population – over several, but not necessarily many, generations – so as to change a species’ ‘normal’ characteristics and could even give rise to ‘speciation’ – that is, the separation out of several inter-breeding populations from a single original population.

Nineteenth-century biology, however, could say little about the causes of, or the mechanisms giving rise to, variation among the individuals forming a species. Darwin and Mendel only had access to the ‘gross’ evidence of natural history: characteristics of individuals and groups, and fragmentary evidence about evolution over time in fossil records. It was only twentieth-century developments in the physical sciences that equipped biologists to study the detailed mechanisms of inheritance and variation at individual level. The ‘neo-Darwinian’ synthesis (as modern evolutionary biology is sometimes termed) bases itself upon an understanding of the splitting and recombination of genomes. Only since the Second World War have biologists been able to understand natural variation at a near-molecular level, governed by the genetic information passed on and altered from one generation to the next through the division and recombination of DNA/RNA. Indeed, they have been able not only to understand it, but also to manipulate it, with the result that ‘biotechnology’ is now among the most rapidly developing areas of applied science.

So what, if anything, may those parts of the human and social sciences

concerned with nineteenth and twentieth-century (essentially Leninist) communism, learn from the modern theory of biological evolution? Probably more from certain general analogies than from concrete results.

One of the questions that modern genetics promises some progress on is the – at first sight paradoxical – evolution of ‘altruism’: crudely speaking, this refers to behaviours or characteristics (or both) that benefit the population as a whole (and do so the more, the more widespread in it they are), but at the same time lessen the reproductive success (‘fitness’) of individuals that express them. Many danger signals among social animals appear to be of this type. The individual bird’s alarm call or behaviour warns the whole flock or colony of a predator, but also makes the individual emitting it dangerously prominent. On the face of it the evolution of altruism is paradoxical – at least in the sense that it contradicts any over-simple ‘survival of the fittest’ principles of natural selection. Ostensibly, in this example, the bird that first observed the predator would rationally preserve its own life and its own ability to pass on its genes through reproduction, by quietly flying to safety. The solution to the paradox lies in the shared gene pool of a species or population. If the behaviour or attribute in question is shared with a sufficient proportion of the population, it can be positively selected despite the fact that the individuals who express it have reduced their own life expectancies and reproductive fitness.

Something of this form of socially-beneficial behaviour can be seen in the very communal basis of Marxism, both in theory and in practice. The theory postulates that it is ‘better’ for the members of society – ultimately, the whole human race – to subordinate their own individual interests to the common good, a philosophical position that was converted into a dogma under Stalin. Principles of political organization aimed at (if not always achieved) by communists include class solidarity and international fraternity. And, as Soviet theorists pointed out in the early post-Stalin period, altruism is not an alien human experience: on the individual level, a mother will risk her own health by depriving herself of sleep and food to tend her sick child; a soldier is prepared to lay down his life for the protection of the society.² Indeed, it requires little thought to recognize that individuals are prepared to suffer in all manner of ways for the benefit of a cause in which they believe.

The long-term evolutionary goal of communists – that of a ‘communist’ society – necessarily entails the acquisition of such fundamental values and behavioural characteristics by all members of society. As an exposition of ‘communism’ by a Soviet theorist in the 1970s expressed it, that society would be characterized by ‘Peace, Labour, Freedom, Equality, Fraternity and Happiness’; work will become ‘a vital urge and will serve

as the basis of man's all-round development.' On the road to 'communism' 'Man steadily ... learns to combine his personal interests and aspirations with lofty social ideals, doing this voluntarily and consciously'. 'Every citizen will work according to his ability and receive material and spiritual benefits according to his needs.' 'Communism establishes fundamentally new and truly human relations among working people. These are relations of genuine brotherhood, collectivism and comradely mutual assistance ... These relations are founded on the principle of "one for all and all for one".' And finally,

Under communism man is happy because he, his interests and needs and his all-round development and improvement are the only concern of society. Man derives his greatest happiness from having the possibility and the need to work for himself and others; from making his contribution to the treasure-house of world culture; from the possibility of setting himself a lofty goal and achieving it; from confidence in a future that is free from poverty; from the possibility to improve his physical and spiritual abilities and be master of nature and his own powers.³

Quite clearly, given the gulf between the values implicit in that depiction of the 'radiant future' and the reality as experienced by societies that embarked on the experiment of building communism, a great deal of 'evolution' was needed. As the inspiring utopian ideology became a mechanism of control, and as some of the basic assumptions of economic wellbeing increasingly failed to materialize, the evolution of individuals' values was stunted. Indeed, those individuals who controlled the ideology – essentially the party *apparatchiki* – while mouthing the glories of the future regulated their own lives according to quite different principles, as has been made public in those very societies in recent years. Moreover, so long as such optimistic rhetoric was poured out to justify the continuing existence of a type of regime established in the peculiar circumstances of the Soviet Union in the 1930s, there was no need to make any adaptations to the system itself: in fact, to have done so would have undermined the validity of the rhetoric. The system was deemed to be intrinsically moral and superior to capitalism – indeed, it was the most advanced type of society known in human experience – so that the kind of adaptations that might have allowed it to survive in a changing world were either rejected outright, or implemented with such lack of enthusiasm that they failed. 'Communism' as a form of rule came to be seen, even by some of its apologists, as a political dinosaur: a system that performed important functions in breaking down old structures (political, economic, social), but that could not adapt sufficiently to secure its own future.

That there were adaptations is beyond dispute. Leninism was an adaptation of Marxism to the specific conditions of tsarist Russia, and Stalinism a further adaptation to meet the needs of Leninism isolated in power. Maoism was a further adaptation to Chinese conditions. Castroism reflected the Latin American revolutionary tradition. Various reformist attempts in the countries of Eastern Europe from the 1950s onwards reflected the needs of the societies in which they took place: one has only to compare Poland under Gierek, Czechoslovakia under Dubček or even Husák, and Hungary under Kádár with Albania under Hoxha to recognize that evolutionary adaptation of Stalinism took place in various degrees in different countries. Eurocommunism represented a further attempt to adapt Marxism (and Leninism?) to the still further different conditions of a Western Europe increasingly enmeshed in a global capitalism that had itself evolved towards the satisfaction of a strong defence against 'communism', on the one hand, and the production and sale of consumer goods, on the other.

Communism as a system of rule, feeling itself under threat from (or at least in competition with) this resurgent capitalism, competed relatively successfully on the first count: its defence effort was of a significantly higher magnitude than that of capitalism, given the lower level of development and technical sophistication of its economies, and the populations seemed to acquiesce. On the second count, that of attaining steadily rising living standards, communism faltered and ultimately failed. In a capitalist world driven by innovation and liberalization of trade, the rigid command system that had been successful in channeling resources into initial development could not find the incentives that would fire the population to match what capitalism could offer.

There is a final component of evolution, however, in which communism also failed: the political concepts of freedom, equality and participation. The communications revolution, and also the general international relaxation from the mid-1950s, made it impossible for the rulers of communist systems to isolate their citizens from the outside world (even Albanians were aware of Western popular musicians and sports stars, presumably through radio). Citizens of communist-ruled countries became aware to an extent that they had not been previously of various forms of individual freedom that permitted citizens of liberal democracies a measure of spontaneity in their lives that traditional communists would not tolerate; nor would they tolerate the political participation (including criticism and dissent) afforded to citizens under liberal democracy.

Pressure on this score was placed by both outside agencies – such as the mechanisms of the 'Helsinki process' – and 'dissidents' and indeed ordinary citizens domestically. At different times in different societies

(and still not yet in all) imbalances not only in the economy but in political life became a topic of public debate, as the contrast between the ruling bureaucracy's behaviour and its enunciated values became plain. By 1989, a reformist leader in the Soviet Union had, in effect, removed the guarantee of the security of other communist-ruled systems. These collapsed within months, across Eastern Europe, and even in Mongolia. In the Soviet Union, the inability of the communist authorities to agree on a programme of reforms for the evolution of the system led to gross miscalculations over several years, and the system collapsed before the end of 1991. In African countries, too, where communism had been adopted as a vehicle for rapid development, the system failed and was abandoned before it could effectively put down deep roots. It seems highly unlikely that the communism as a form of rule based on Leninism and Stalinism will survive anywhere to the end of the century.

At the end of 1991, therefore, 'communism' is widely condemned as a grand failure: an attempt to create a utopia that was as misguided in conception as it was cruel and harsh in its execution. As a form of rule, however, communism may have made a distinct contribution to the evolution of human society and political systems. The values of the welfare state, which became part of the political experience of much of Western Europe, particularly after the Second World War, was undoubtedly influenced by the values of the political Left including Marxism and its Stalinist variant. Moreover, it might be argued (although perhaps few would acknowledge this) that communism, as a form of rule based heavily on a bureaucratic state, was a source of influence over political and administrative technique, especially – but not exclusively – in non-industrial societies. Even in the liberal-democratic, capitalist countries of the world, the extension of the role and power of the state into areas from which was excluded until the present century has been colossal. But Stalinism paved the way in showing newly-independent countries a way of gaining control over their own destiny and, through the state bureaucracy, creating employment and directing resources towards certain 'national' goals.

As various countries abandon Stalinism as a political and economic model, they embark upon a fresh phase of their evolution – or, indeed, degeneration. As a 'species' the Stalinist form of communism seems doomed. But – to return to the biological analogy – a good deal of the 'genetic material' remains in the society, ready to recombine, and to combine with other 'genetic material' to form fresh species. Some of the material was already present in the society, having lain dormant during the period of communist rule; some has returned, after existing in émigré communities elsewhere in the world and mutating under the influence of

the host societies; other 'genetic material' is exogenous, and enters in the form of, say, advice and training from the former communist countries' new partners in the liberal-democratic, capitalist West. It is not yet clear what the resultant systems will look like, but it seems unlikely that three or four generations of rule under the conditions of communist rule will be obliterated – or that the experience of living under the perceived threat of 'communism' will prove to have left liberal-democratic capitalism unaffected.

NOTES

1. Zbigniew Brzezinski, *The Grand Failure: The Birth and Death of Communism in the Twentieth Century* (London: Macdonald, 1989).
2. G.M. Gak, 'Obshchestvennye i lichnye interesy i ikh sochetanie pri sotsializme', *Voprosy filosofii*, 1955, No.4, pp.17–28 (p.19).
3. V.G. Afanasyev, *Fundamentals of Scientific Communism* (Moscow: Progress, 1977), pp.265–9.

Index

- adaptation 8, 9, 11, 13, 15, 18, 38, 141, 160, 161, 171, 172
- administration 8, 66, 73, 91, 93, 129
- Afanas'ev, Yuri 103
- Africa 4, 10, 173
- Aganbegyan, Abel 129
- aggregation 128, 133, 135, 136–8, 141, 142, 143, 144, 145–6
- agriculture 45, 64, 67, 68, 72–3, 95, 124, 156–7
- Aitmatov, Chingiz 37
- Albania 172
- Alekseev, S.S. 34
- alienation 34
- altruism 170
- America, Central 4
 - Latin 172
 - North 5, 24
 - see also* United States
- Andropov, Yuri 27, 100, 168
- apparatus 8, 47, 48, 49, 50, 121, 122, 130, 136, 150, 171
- Ash, Robert 68, 72–3
- Asia 4, 9, 81–2
 - see also individual countries*
- Austria 37
- authoritarianism 10, 36, 52, 55, 81, 85, 88, 89, 93, 94, 95, 98, 99, 100, 102, 148, 158
- Avineri, Shlomo 91
- Bachman, David 72
- Bahro, Rudolf 49
- Baikal, Lake 138, 147n
- Balcerowicz, Leszek 47, 55, 123
- Baltic states 148, 149–50, 151–2, 153, 156, 158
 - see also individual countries*
- Bavaria 24
- Bentley, Arthur F. 134–5, 136
- Berglund, Sten 16, 18
- Berlinguer, Enrico 41, 42, 43
- Bernstein, Eduard 7, 104n
- Bielecki, Jan 60, 125
- Bogomolov, Oleg 37
- Bojarski, Włodzimierz 138
- Bolsheviks 8, 24, 37, 92, 93, 96
- Bolshevism 37, 43
- Brandt, Willy 38
- Bratislava Nahlas* (Bratislava Aloud) 139
- Breslin, Shaun 16
- Brezhnev, Leonid 8, 26, 27, 99, 100, 162
- Britain, British 24, 25, 78, 154, 158
- Brus, Włodzimierz 129
- Brzezinski, Zbigniew K. 37, 160
- Bukharin, Nikolai 94, 95
- Bulgaria, Bulgarians 128, 132, 140, 142, 143, 144, 148, 150, 151, 152, 153, 157
 - Union of Democratic Forces 142, 143
- bureaucracy, bureaucrats 31, 33, 34–6, 50, 67, 61, 77, 78, 90, 91, 93, 94, 95, 115, 121, 129, 134, 136, 137, 138, 164, 173
- Burlatskii, Fedor 32–3, 99, 102
- Burns, John P. 71
- Butenko, Anatolii 32, 33–4
- Cambodia 163
- capitalism 7, 11, 23, 24, 25, 33, 35, 36, 37, 38, 53, 66, 84, 86, 87, 89, 90, 93, 103, 107, 116, 122, 124, 129, 160, 161, 162, 171, 172, 174
- Castro, Fidel 167
- Ceaușescu, Nicolae 151, 152, 167, 168
- Chang, Parris 65
- change 5, 6, 44, 47, 50, 51, 52, 69, 75
- Chen Yun 64, 67, 70, 72, 80, 81
- Chernenko, Konstantin 28
- China 9, 12, 16, 26, 63–83 *passim*, 162, 163
 - CCP (communist party) 63, 64, 65, 68, 77, 79, 81
 - Cultural Revolution 64, 67, 68, 69, 72, 76, 80
 - Democracy Wall 75
 - 'Four Modernizations' 63, 73
 - 'Gang of Four' 68
 - 'Great Leap Forward' 67, 68, 69, 78, 82n
 - 'Hundred Flowers Campaign' 75
 - revolution (1949) 65–6, 78
- churches 157, 164

- Evangelical 133, 137, 142–3
 Roman Catholic 42–3, 51, 60, 137, 144, 146
Civil War in France, The 89–90, 91
 cloning 9
 coercion 9, 32
 see also repression, terror
 collectivization *see* agriculture
 communication 12, 13, 19, 130, 131, 160, 165–6, 167, 172
 communism:
 as model society 6, 7, 11, 15, 23, 24, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30, 35, 38, 64, 66, 69, 78, 79, 81, 85, 86, 87, 89, 90, 93, 94, 95, 97, 98, 99, 103, 107, 160, 161, 162, 163, 170–71
 as form of rule 3–4, 7, 8, 9, 10–12, 13, 14, 15, 18, 37, 38, 47, 85, 130–32, 153, 156, 158, 160, 161, 162, 164, 165, 171, 172, 173
 collapse of 7, 15, 16, 18, 19, 37, 38, 41, 52, 81, 85, 107, 120, 125, 128, 129, 132, 135, 138, 143, 145, 151, 156, 157, 159, 160, 163, 164, 172, 173
 Communist International (Comintern) 24–5, 94
Communist Manifesto, The 85, 87, 90, 93, 161, 163
 ‘comparative communism’ 3, 10, 19n, 167
 conflict 57–8, 60, 64, 65, 70, 71, 84, 86
 conservatism 112, 115
 constitutions 4, 23, 60, 91, 93–4, 99, 101, 102, 104, 133, 150
 control 8, 9, 14, 18, 50, 52, 71, 73, 74, 79, 81, 109, 116, 117, 119, 122, 123, 139, 161, 164, 166, 171
 ‘convergence’ 6
Critique of the Gotha Programme 104
 culture 30, 137, 150, 164, 165
 political 11, 18, 19, 32, 43, 87, 89, 97, 98, 103, 104, 150
 Czechoslovakia 4, 17, 43, 46, 48, 107–27 *passim*, 128, 129, 132, 135, 139, 140, 141, 142, 143, 144, 146, 148, 150, 151, 152, 153, 156, 158, 172
 Charter 77 133, 135, 141–2, 150
 Civic Forum 129, 135, 153, 156
 CPCz (communist party) 135
 Moravia 146
 ‘Prague Spring’ 129, 132, 137, 150
 Slovakia 137, 139, 144, 146, 158
 Public Against Violence 135
 Davies, James C. 77
 Dellenbrant, Jan Åke 16, 18
 democracy 6, 10, 11, 14, 16, 19, 30, 31, 36, 37, 42, 49, 52, 53, 54, 63, 85, 86, 91, 92, 93, 103, 117, 118, 119, 133, 134, 150, 153, 154, 157, 158, 172, 174
 democratic centralism 131, 136, 149, 150
 democratization 11, 14, 16, 19, 31, 33, 44, 52, 54, 61, 100–101, 103, 118, 129, 133, 137, 150, 152, 153, 155
 demonstrations 64, 77, 114, 115
 see also public opinion
 Deng Xiaoping 63, 64, 67, 72, 75, 78, 79, 80, 81
 Deng Yingchao 80
 de-Stalinization 48–9, 96–7
 development 5, 27, 29, 36, 41, 63, 65, 70–71, 77, 163, 165
 economic 5–6, 13, 15, 28, 30, 67, 78, 161
 dictatorship 8, 10, 48, 52, 88, 94, 95, 96, 99, 103, 104, 129, 155, 156
 dinosaurs 7, 171
 dissent, dissidence 18, 77, 78, 134, 149, 150, 152, 172
 see also public opinion
 Dittmer, Lowell 71, 80
 Domes, Jürgen 72
 Dubček, Alexander 13, 118, 172

Economics of the Transition Period 95
 economy 9, 11, 12, 16, 17, 23, 27, 30, 33, 36, 44–7, 50, 52, 55, 57, 58–9, 60, 63, 64, 74, 78–9, 151–2, 162
 elections 32, 33, 51, 55–7, 60, 97, 98, 101, 117, 122, 130, 131, 133, 135, 136, 144, 145, 151, 152, 155–6, 157
 Engels, Friedrich 6, 84, 86, 87, 88, 89, 91, 93, 95, 160, 161, 168
 environment 11, 13, 18, 38, 46, 108, 124, 138–9, 142, 144, 169
 Ellman, Michael 108
 equality 34, 113, 172
 Eurocommunism 160, 172
 Europe 24, 46, 81, 91, 122, 158
 Eastern 4, 6, 9, 10, 12, 17, 21n, 41, 44, 45, 47, 50, 51, 52, 81, 85, 102, 107–27 *passim*, 128–47 *passim*, 160, 162, 163, 172, 173
 Western 9, 16, 25, 38, 107, 121, 122, 123, 129, 133–4, 141, 162, 165, 172, 173
 see also individual countries
 ‘European Soviet Federated Socialist Republic’ 23
 evolution 5, 6–7, 7–10, 11, 11–12, 12–13,

- 161
 within communism 5, 9, 15, 17, 18, 26,
 31, 38, 41, 42, 43, 47, 65, 69, 78, 99,
 107, 145, 164
 from communism 5, 13–14, 15, 17, 18,
 19, 41, 50–58, 60, 61, 107, 120–126,
 148–59 *passim*, 173–4
 exploitation 34
 external influences 12, 13, 75–6, 119,
 130–31, 166, 173–4
 extinction 10, 14, 38
- feudalism 11, 25
 Finer, S.E. 129
 France, French 24, 154, 155, 158, 163,
 166
 revolution (1789) 166
 freedom 9, 172
 Friedman, Milton 123
 Fukuyama, Francis 40n, 64
Fundamentals of Marxism-Leninism 97
- Gazeta Wyborcza* (Election Gazette) 58
 genes 12, 13, 14, 168, 169
 genetics 7, 12
 genetic engineering 12, 13, 14, 169
 Geremek, Bronisław 61
 Germany, Germans 24, 25, 91, 157, 158
 FRG 9, 153, 154, 155–6
 GDR 9, 46, 110, 120, 128, 132, 137,
 139, 142, 144, 148, 151, 152, 153, 155
 New Forum 129
 SED (Socialist Unity Party) 137,
 142–3
 Gierek, Edward 44, 45, 46, 49, 50, 172
glasnost 137
 Gomułka, Władysław 44, 45, 49, 113,
 118, 167
 Goodman, David S.G. 75, 79
 Gorbachev, Mikhail 11, 13, 26–38
 passim, 84, 85, 98, 100–103, 130, 137,
 138, 143, 152, 167, 168
 Gramsci, Antonio 164
 groups 133–41
 Guevara, Ernesto 'Che' 67
- Hamrin, Carol 72
 Harding, Neil 99
 Havel, Václav 141, 142
 Hayek, F.A. 34, 109, 123
 Helsinki accords 132–3, 136, 172
 Hewett, Ed 110, 111, 113, 114, 116, 123
 Hill, Ronald J. 100, 102
 Hobbes, Thomas 86
 Ho Chi Minh 167
 Hoffman, John 7, 8, 16
- Holmes, Leslie 6
 Honecker, Erich 151, 152
 Hoxha, Enver 172
 Hua Guofeng 69, 78
 Hungary, Hungarians 4, 9, 17, 24, 43,
 66, 107–27 *passim*, 128, 132, 138–9,
 140, 141, 143, 144, 149, 150, 151, 153,
 155, 156, 157, 158, 172
 Democratic Forum 129, 153, 156
 Hungarian Socialist Workers'
 Party 132, 151
 New Economic Mechanism 109, 111,
 113, 114, 124
 Hunt, Richard 87, 88, 91
 Husák, Gustav 43, 172
 Hu Yaobang 77
 hybrids 12
- ideology 8, 12, 16, 42, 43, 67, 68, 70, 76,
 113, 118, 131, 144, 157, 162, 163, 168,
 171
 see also Leninism, Maoism, Marxism,
 Marxism-Leninism, Stalinism
 Indochina 4
 industrialization 6, 36, 44, 156–7
 inflation 47, 59, 75, 77, 79, 113, 114,
 116, 117, 119, 120, 121
 information 13, 111, 130, 131
 intelligentsia 165
 interbreeding 12, 14, 168–9, 173–4
 interests 17–18, 56, 86, 90, 115, 130, 131,
 134, 135, 137, 138, 145, 170–71
 Italy 154, 155, 156, 163
 PCI (communist party) 42
- Jakeš, Miloš 151, 152
 Japan 163
 Jaruzelski, Wojciech 51, 58, 60, 142
- Kaczyński, Jarosław 58, 60
 Kádár, Janos 43, 113, 150, 151, 167, 172
 Kardelj, Eduard 129, 131
 Kautsky, John H. 14
 Khrushchev, Nikita 8, 13, 22n, 26, 27,
 35, 36, 96–7, 100, 103, 164
 Kim Il-Sung 167
 Klaus, Václav 123–4
 Klyamkin, Igor 36
 Koestler, Arthur 22n
Komsomol'skaya pravda 139
 Kohl, Helmut 153
 Korea, People's Republic of 10
 Republic of 81
 Kosygin, Aleksei 17
 Krasin, Yuri 34
 Kurashvili, Boris 32, 33

- Kuroń, Jacek 119
- Lamarck, Jean Baptiste de 8, 22n
- Lasswell, Harold D. 66
- law 34
- leaders, leadership 13, 16, 35, 43–4, 47, 48, 50, 63, 64, 66, 69, 71, 72, 73, 78, 80, 81, 88, 111, 112, 115, 118, 131, 135, 150, 164, 166, 168
- Lenin, V.I. 8, 14, 24, 25, 33, 34, 36, 37, 78, 90, 92, 93, 94, 95, 96, 98, 103, 161, 163, 164, 166, 168
- Leninism 8, 9, 16, 23, 36, 48, 52, 66, 98, 102, 123–4, 160, 172, 173
- Lewis, Paul G. 15–16
- Leys, Simon 65
- liberalism 84, 86–7, 91, 92, 102, 103–4
- liberalization 44, 70, 75, 98, 100, 101
- Li Peng 64, 74
- Lithuania 130, 157, 167
- Liu Shaoqi 67, 70
- Luxemburg, Rosa 92
- Lysenko, Trofim 22n
- Maoism 10, 63, 64, 65–6, 67, 68, 70, 160, 172
- Mao Zedong 63, 64, 65, 67, 68, 70, 78, 80, 81, 167, 168
- market 33, 34, 52, 53, 55, 76, 79, 81, 86, 95, 107, 109, 110, 113, 114–15, 116, 117, 119, 120, 121–3, 124, 129–30, 145, 156, 158, 162
- Marx, Karl 6, 8, 14, 31, 34, 42, 78, 85, 86, 87, 89, 90, 100, 102, 104, 129, 149, 160, 161, 168
- Marxism, Marxism-Leninism 6, 10, 16–17, 36, 42, 66, 78, 84, 88, 90, 100, 102, 104, 129, 149, 160, 161, 170, 172, 173
- Mazowiecki, Tadeusz 41, 43, 47, 51, 52, 54, 59, 60, 145, 156
- McLuhan, Marshall 167
- Medvedev, Vadim 103, 129
- Mendel, Johan 169
- Michnik, Adam 54, 58
- military 10, 31, 32, 41, 42, 43, 46, 47, 49, 77, 81, 111, 142, 149, 152, 162, 172
- Mitin, M.B. 95
- modernization 5, 11, 50, 71, 73, 78, 161, 162
- Modzelewski, Senator 54
- Mongolia 4, 173
- monopoly, economic 114, 128, 130, 136
- political 4–5, 16, 128, 130, 131, 134, 137–8
- Mugabe, Robert 4
- mutation 12–13, 14, 15, 173
- Myant, Martin 17
- Najder, Zdzisław 55
- natural selection 12
- Naughton, Barry 71
- Netherlands 37
- nomenklatura* 53, 118, 119, 130
- see also* apparatus
- Nove, Alec 110
- Novotný, Antonín 43, 112, 150
- officials *see* bureaucracy
- Oksenberg, Michael 65, 71
- opposition 45, 54, 72, 73, 73–4, 91, 102, 112, 113, 116, 117, 120, 121, 122, 124, 142, 149, 150, 156
- Origin of Species, The* 6
- ownership 6, 32, 33, 34, 35, 53, 79, 109, 119, 125, 129, 145, 162
- Palme, Olof 38
- Paris Commune 89–92, 93, 96, 105n
- parliament 51, 54, 55, 56, 60, 91, 92, 95, 101, 148
- participation 14, 43, 56, 97–8, 133, 172
- parties, communist 4, 8, 9, 16, 17, 31, 33, 35, 37, 41, 42, 66, 75, 78, 79, 97, 98, 100, 102, 112, 115, 129, 130, 131, 132, 136, 139, 142, 148, 149, 150, 151, 160, 165, 167
- see also under countries*
- non-ruling 10, 87, 165
- non-communist 4–5, 8, 16, 18, 19, 23, 33, 51, 56, 57, 60, 102, 122, 124, 133, 134, 135, 136, 148–59 *passim*
- Passent, Daniel 52
- peace committees 151
- peasantry 9, 45, 55, 58
- perestroika* 30, 31, 33, 100, 133, 137, 149
- Petrova, Dimitrina 135
- planners, planning 30, 33, 44, 45, 53, 74, 79, 108, 109–10, 111, 112, 115, 116, 122, 130
- Plekhanov, Georgii 166
- pluralism 16, 19, 38, 52, 81, 102, 117, 125, 133, 134, 149, 154, 155–6, 158
- Polan, A. 91, 93, 94
- Poland 4, 9, 15–16, 17, 33, 41–62 *passim*, 66, 107–27 *passim*, 132, 135, 137, 138, 139, 142, 143, 144, 145, 146, 148, 149, 150, 151, 152, 153, 156, 157, 158, 172
- Gazeta Wyborcza* (Election Gazette) 58
- 'Orange Alternative' 139, 144
- 'Polish October' 43

- Polish United Workers' Party 41, 47, 48, 50, 51, 54
- Solidarity 41, 42, 46, 50–53, 54, 55, 56, 57, 58, 111, 119, 124, 133, 135, 140, 142, 144, 151, 153, 156, 157
- Solidarity Weekly (Tygodnik Solidarnosc)* 51, 58
- Pol Pot 163
- 'post-communism' 5, 15, 16, 17, 51, 53, 59, 85–6, 125
- prices *see* inflation
- privatization 53, 60, 71–2, 120, 123, 124, 125
- professionalization 7, 8
- progress 6
- proletariat *see* working class
- propaganda 10, 130, 164, 166, 171
- property *see* ownership
- public opinion 32, 53, 54, 55, 56, 57, 58, 59, 65, 76, 77, 78, 80, 111, 113, 114, 116, 118, 120, 121, 122, 124, 137, 152
- radiation 13
- Rakowska-Harmstone, Teresa 137
- Rakowski, Mieczysław 47
- Rechtsstaat 101, 103
- reform 17, 42, 44, 51, 64, 77, 78, 79, 80, 81, 84, 110, 111, 121, 129, 152, 164, 173
- economic 26, 47, 50, 52, 53, 65, 70, 71, 73, 75, 107–27 *passim*, 129, 149, 150, 151
- political 26, 41, 44, 47, 50, 71, 72, 86, 100, 101–3, 117, 149, 150, 151
- religion *see* churches
- repression 34, 43, 87, 92, 93, 95, 98, 143, 150, 151, 163, 164, 173
- see also* terror
- Revisionism 7, 104n
- revolution 11, 13–14, 15, 16, 24, 25, 36, 66, 67, 77, 87, 88, 90, 102, 161, 164
- 'self-limiting' 119
- see also* under countries
- Reykowski, Janusz 54
- Romania 128, 132, 150, 151, 152, 153, 157
- Rousseau, J.-J. 86
- Russia 8, 16, 23, 24, 25, 37, 42, 93, 161, 172
- Bolshevik revolution 8, 23–4, 31, 36, 37, 38, 42, 88, 90, 92–6 *passim*, 161
- see also* Soviet Union
- Sartori, Giovanni 154, 155
- Scandinavia 148, 154
- Schram, Stuart 66
- self-administration, -government, -management 7, 30, 32, 33, 55, 86, 94–5, 97, 99, 103, 104, 118, 119, 125
- Shakhnazarov, Georgii 34–5, 99
- Šik, Ota 112
- Skalski, Ernest 55
- social democracy 31, 37, 38, 103
- socialism 11, 23, 24, 25, 26, 29–30, 31, 32–7, 49, 53, 84, 93, 102, 103, 107, 110, 114, 149, 162, 163
- 'developed socialism' 26, 27, 28, 29, 99, 162
- 'socialism in one country' 26, 95
- society 11, 13–14, 15, 26, 27, 31, 33, 36, 50, 54, 78, 86–7, 90, 91, 93, 97, 111, 124, 157, 161, 164, 165, 168
- Solidarity *see* Poland
- Somalia 10
- soviets 23, 24, 33, 93, 97, 100, 101
- 'Soviet model' 64, 66, 69, 129, 148, 163
- Soviet Union (USSR) 4, 5, 7, 9, 10, 11, 12, 15, 16, 17, 23–38 *passim*, 67, 76, 85, 90, 93–103 *passim*, 109, 110, 111, 121, 128, 133, 137, 138, 139, 142, 143, 145, 149, 150, 151, 152, 157, 158, 160, 161, 162, 163, 165, 171, 173
- Communist Party 25, 26, 31, 38, 94, 100, 101, 102, 114, 143, 164, 166
- New Economic Policy 25, 32, 95
- 'war communism' 32
- see also* Russia
- Spain 154, 158
- species, speciation 6, 10–12, 14, 25, 168, 169
- stagnation 26, 29, 44–7, 52, 64, 100, 108, 112, 166
- Stalin, Joseph 8, 9, 15, 22n, 35, 43, 48, 93, 95, 96, 98, 100, 161, 163, 164, 167, 170
- Stalinism 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 14, 16, 17, 18, 19, 31, 32, 34, 35–6, 37, 66, 124, 128, 139, 148, 149, 151, 156, 157, 160, 162, 172, 173
- Staniszki, Jadwiga 54
- state 7, 16, 32, 36, 53, 55, 60, 84–106 *passim*, 173
- 'state of the whole people' 99
- State and Revolution, The* 92, 93, 94, 163
- Stuchka, Peter 23
- Sun Suyi 78
- Sun Yatsen 75
- 'survival of the fittest' 6
- Swayne, Michael 79

- Sweden 37
 Syski, Jacek 54
- Taiwan 81
 Tarschys, Daniel 97, 98
 technology 6, 13, 162, 165–6
 Teiweś, Frederick 65
 terror 8, 88, 95, 97, 103, 163
 see also repression
Terrorism and Communism 96
 third world 25
 Tiananmen Square demonstrations
 (1989) 77, 78, 167
 Tian Jiyun 73
 de Tocqueville, Alexis 77, 102
 Togliatti, Palmiro 35, 167
 totalitarianism 10, 34, 79, 103, 105n,
 135, 153, 155
 trade 10, 12, 108, 121, 172
 Trotsky, Leon 96, 98, 161, 166
 Trotskyism 9–10, 21n
 Tsipko, Aleksandr 36
 Tyminiński, Stanisław 60
- Ulam, Adam 14
 unemployment 59, 112, 113, 114, 119,
 123, 126, 159
 unions 136, 140–41
 see also Solidarity
 United States 5, 16, 21n, 27, 37, 76, 101,
 154, 162, 163
 see also America
- urbanization 6
 USSR *see* Russia, Soviet Union
- Vargha, Janos 138
 Vietnam 82
 virus 9
- Wałęsa, Lech 43, 58, 59, 60, 123, 124,
 145, 156
 wealth 76, 172
 Weber, Max 129
 Westoby, Adam 5
 White, Gordon 72
 White, Stephen 15, 102
 'withering away of the state' 7, 16, 29,
 84–106 *passim*
 working class 8, 9, 24, 25, 33, 37, 44, 45,
 58, 60, 85, 87, 88, 94–5, 111, 113, 114,
 115, 121, 165
 Wujec, Henryk 58
- Yao Yilin 70
 Yeltsin, Boris 38, 102
 You Ji 73
 youth 139–40, 141
 Yugoslavia 9, 11–20, 128, 137, 146, 153
- Zhao Ziyang 64–5, 72, 73, 78, 81
 Zhelev, Zhelyu 143
 Zhivkov, Todor 151, 152
 Zimbabwe 4
 Zinoviev, Grigorii 24, 25, 167

University of Pennsylvania Library
Circulation Department

Please return this book as soon as you have finished with it. In order to avoid a fine it must be returned by the latest date stamped below.

VAN PEEBLES

APR 29 1999

JUL 15 1999

RECEIVED
DEC 20 2000

VAN PEEBLES

APR 1 2002

RETURNED
APR 1 - 2002

MAY 5 2002

RETURNED
APR 23 2002

3 1198 01531 0027



N/1198/01531/0027X



P8-DFA-442